

ERNESTO CARDENAL

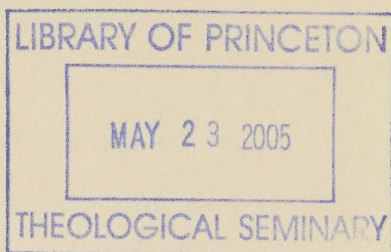
THE GOSPEL IN SOLENTINAME



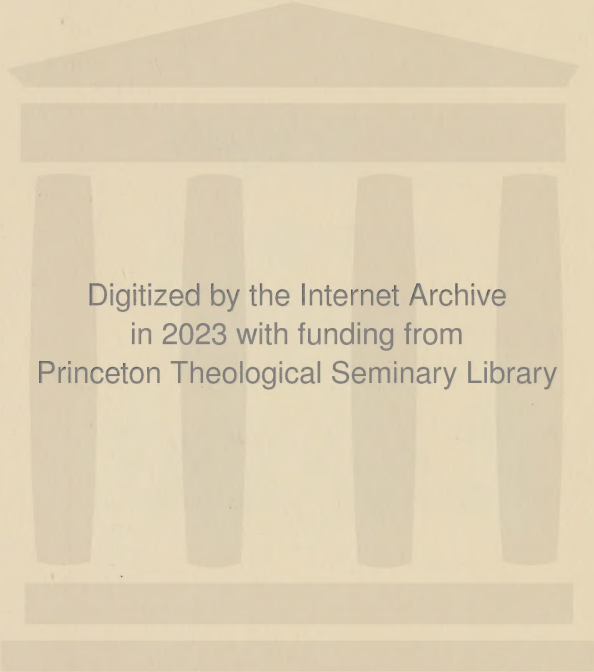
VOLUME 4



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Cardenal, Ernesto. c.2
The Gospel in Solentiname



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*The Gospel
in Solentiname*

The Gospel in Solentiname

Volume IV

✓
Ernesto Cardenal

Translated by Donald D. Walsh

ORBIS  BOOKS
Maryknoll, New York 10545

1982

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Orbis paperback edition 1982

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Manufactured in the United States of America

Library of Congress Cataloging in Publication Data

Cardenal, Ernesto.

The Gospel in Solentiname.

Translation of *El Evangelio en Solentiname*.

Dialogues on the Gospels between the author and community members of Solentiname.

1. Bible. N.T. Gospels—Criticism, interpretation, etc.—Miscellanea. I. Title.

BS2555.2.C27713 1976 226'.06 76-2681

ISBN 0-88344-173-x (v. 4) AACR1

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INTRODUCTION

In Solentiname, a remote archipelago on Lake Nicaragua with a population of *campesinos*,¹ instead of a sermon each Sunday on the Gospel reading, we would have a dialogue. The commentaries of the *campesinos* are usually of greater profundity than that of many theologians, but of a simplicity like that of the Gospel itself. This is not surprising: The *Gospel*, or “Good News” (to the poor), was written for them, and by people like them.

Some friends urged me not to let these commentaries be lost, but to put them together and publish them as a book. That’s the reason for this book. I first began collecting them in my mind, insofar as I could. Later, with more common sense, we used a tape recorder.

Many of these commentaries were made in the church, at Sunday Mass. Others were made in a thatched hut opposite the church, used for meetings and the communal lunch after Mass. Occasionally, we would have the Mass and the Gospel dialogue in the open air on other islands, or in a small house that we could get to by rowing along a beautiful river through very tropical vegetation.

Each Sunday we first would distribute copies of the Gospels to those who could read. There were some

who couldn't, especially among the elderly and those who lived on islands far away from the school. One of those who could read best (generally a boy or a girl) would read aloud the entire passage on which we were going to comment. Then we discussed it verse by verse.

We used the Protestant translation entitled *Dios llega al hombre*, which is the best translation of the Gospels that I know. The translation is anonymous, but it was unquestionably made by a poet. It is in the simple language of the Latin American *campesino*, but it preserves a maximum fidelity to the Scriptures.²

I'm sorry I can't include the many good dialogues we had before we began to collect them—they were carried off by the wind of the lake—nor some others we had when our tape recorder had broken down. But these dialogues have been lost only for this book, not for those who took part in them and who in some way retain them even though they may not remember them.

The archipelago of Solentiname has thirty-eight islands; some are very small, and only the largest are inhabited. The population is about a thousand, composed of some ninety families. The houses are usually thatched huts, all spread out, some distance apart, on the shores of the different islands. On one point of the largest island we established our little community or lay monastery, Our Lady of Solentiname. To this community came the Colombian poet William Agudelo and his wife, Teresita, and their two small children, Irene and Juan; and also some young people born on these islands: Alejandro, Elvis, and Laureano. Communication with the outside was infrequent, and our contemplative retirement was not disturbed in this

place, fortunately hard to reach, outside the paths of merchants and tourists.

Not all those who lived on these islands came to Mass, many because they had no boat, and others because they missed the devotion to the saints, to which they were accustomed. Others stayed away through the influence of anti-Communist propaganda, and perhaps also through fear.

Not all those who did come took an equal part in the commentaries. There were some who spoke more often. Marcelino is a mystic. Olivia is more theological. Rebeca, Marcelino's wife, always stresses love. Laureano refers everything to the Revolution. Elvis always thinks of the perfect society of the future. Felipe, another young man, is very conscious of the proletarian struggle. Old Tomás Peña, his father, doesn't know how to read, but he talks with great wisdom. Alejandro, Olivia's son, is a young leader, and his commentaries are usually directed toward everyone, and especially toward other young people. Pancho is a conservative. Julio Mairena is a great defender of equality. His brother Oscar always talks about unity. The authors of this book are these people and all the others who talk frequently and say important things, and those who talk infrequently but also say something important, and with them William and Teresita and other companions that we have had and who have taken part in the dialogues.

I am wrong. The true author is the Spirit that has inspired these commentaries (the Solentiname *campesinos* know very well that it is the Spirit who makes them speak) and that it was the Spirit who inspired the Gospels. The Holy Spirit, who is the spirit of God instilled in the community, and whom Oscar would call

the spirit of community unity, and Alejandro the spirit of service to others, and Elvis the spirit of the society of the future, and Felipe the spirit of proletarian struggle, and Julio the spirit of equality and the community of wealth, and Laureano the spirit of the Revolution, and Rebeca the spirit of Love.

NOTES

1. *Campesino* is literally one who lives in the *campo* (country, field). Most *campesinos* are farm workers, but some are fisherfolk.—D.D.W.

2. The Gospel quotations in this edition are my translations from the Spanish of *Dios llega al hombre*.—D.D.W.

1.

The Coming of the Kingdom of God

(Luke 17:20-37)

*The Pharisees asked Jesus when the kingdom of
God would come,
and he answered them: "The coming of the
kingdom of God
is not a thing that can be seen.
They are not going to say 'Here it is' or 'There it is,'
because the kingdom of God is already among
you."*

OLIVIA: "I don't see how they could think for so long that the kingdom of heaven was in heaven when Jesus has clearly said that it was in the midst of humankind."

REBECA: "I think the kingdom is among us already, because the kingdom is love. When we have love, there's the kingdom."

MARIITA: "I think you can't see the kingdom, because it's love. Love is in people's hearts, but it's not a

visible thing that we can say here it is or there it is. But I think you can look at it: when you see the changes. The whole world is changing. And so like that you can see the kingdom of God.”

LAUREANO: “The kingdom of God is inside you, but you do have to make it come true. You can have love but you have to make that love come true with the others: only then do you make the kingdom of God come true.”

ALEJANDRO: “No matter how far a country has advanced in making love come true, it will never reach perfection. Then you can never say: there it is. You can always do something more.”

FELIPE: “And besides we have the capitalist propaganda that always confuses you, and we can’t know for sure if the kingdom of God is in a particular place or it isn’t.”

OLIVIA: “I’d say that you can see it: it really isn’t the way people have always believed, that when Christ comes we’re going to see him coming in glory in the clouds: it’s going to be when we see the kingdom of love. In a country where there’s justice, where there’s respect for human rights and there’s food and schools for everybody, there’s the kingdom of love; and you can see it and notice it in a little community where we love each other and we all respect each other; it’s already the kingdom of love, the kingdom of God.”

*The time will come when you will want to see
just one of the days of the Son of Man,
and you won’t see it.
And they will say to you:
“Here it is,” or “There it is.”*

*But do not go, do not follow it.
Because just as you see a lightning bolt
flashing in one or another place in the sky,
that's how it will be when the Son of Man comes on
his day.*

ALEJANDRO: "He's saying there's going to be more changes, something more radical."

I: "Something more radical, and it's not going to be necessary to tell you that there is Christ, that he's come, because it's going to be obvious."

OLIVIA: "It seems to me that when all the people have complete justice, when they've been liberated, that's where it'll be the true kingdom, the coming of Jesus Christ will be very visible."

MARCELINO: "It seems to me that a lot of us folks would like to see those days, to see something at least close to those days. But now it's a little different. We can see by means of the spirit, when the spirit of God enters us, we can see the days that Jesus walked, and we can see the miracles. Other than that we can't see anything, we're blind. But someday, says Jesus, it's going to be like we see a lightning bolt, it's going to be bright and clear, it's not going to be seeing just with the spirit, as I was saying. Not then; we're going to see, with our eyes, the things that are happening. Anybody that looks and sees things is going to say: it's clear."

FELIPE: "And that part about how we shouldn't pay attention when they tell us 'Here it is' or 'There it is,' maybe it means we shouldn't pay attention to propaganda."

MANUEL: "Then he means that that second coming

that he's talking about there isn't about the end of the world, the Last Judgment, but it's . . . I don't understand that, then."

I: "Here he's talking about his coming, but he's not talking about the end of the world."

JULIO: "It seems to me that it's like when they say: 'Here's one candidate,' or 'There's another one.' Or they tell us now that the government is fair and just, and we're all getting screwed."

MANUEL: "Well, I hadn't noticed this part of the Gospel before, because I hadn't read it. I thought they were talking about Judgment Day. But there *is* a place where they talk about Judgment Day, right?"

I: "Yes, but Jesus doesn't exactly say that will be when the world has ended. Saint Paul says the living and the dead will be judged."

FELIPE: "If you can judge a dead person. If somebody's bad, all you can say is: 'That bastard was no good.' "

*But first he has to suffer a lot
and be rejected by the people of this time.*

TOMAS: "He means that the Son of Man is going to come at a time when people don't have faith in him, and they're going to say it isn't time yet."

ELVIS: "It seems to me that the coming is the liberation of all peoples; and as for the ones that are against him: they're the reactionary people that exist and will exist when that complete change comes."

*As it happened in the times when Noah lived,
so also it will happen in the days when the Son of
Man comes.*

ADAN: "It seems to me that when he comes, he's going to choose people. Like when in the flood all the unjust people died, and one just family was saved."

I: "This answers the question Manuel was asking, about the end of the world. Jesus compares his coming with the flood and afterwards he compares it with the ruin of Sodom, because it will be a destruction: the destruction of the unjust. It will be a catastrophe, but not for everybody."

*On that day, if someone is on the roof,
and he has his things inside the house,
let him not go down to get them out;
and if someone is in the country,
let him not return home.
Remember Lot's wife.*

TOMAS: "Nobody's going to have anything, just body and soul. What you think is yours isn't yours, so why are you going to go looking for anything in your house or wherever you've got it."

OLIVIA: "But it's not the destruction of the world he's talking about. It's when love is coming true on earth. If I have something in my house I shouldn't take it because maybe there's somebody else that needs it more than I do."

WILLIAM: "It seems to me that it means getting rid of all your personal wealth, because the kingdom of heaven, that is, the revolution, will take good care to give each of us all that we need; then what people have to do is be concerned only about that kingdom of justice, be concerned about others, and all the rest will come by itself."

TOMAS: "Maybe some will come out better because they leave little and get more."

BOSCO: "And he says he mustn't look back like Lot's wife, which is looking toward the past."

*I say to you that on that night
two will lie in the same bed;
one will be taken and the other left behind.
Two women will be grinding together;
one will be taken and the other left behind.
Two men will be in the field;
one will be taken and the other left behind.*

"It seems like some are going to be left behind because they're lazy, because so many of us don't do good. We're living just to live, and maybe we think we're going to be saved without doing any struggling to make the revolution win sooner."

ELVIS: "That choosing that he says there'll be between people, isn't that choosing between classes?"

REBECA: "The one who struggles for liberation is the one who has love, and that one will be taken to the kingdom of God and to the kingdom of love. The one who doesn't is the one who's locked up in selfishness and clinging to wealth: that one will be left behind, then."

FELIPE: "But I don't know, Ernesto. That business about some will be taken and others left behind confuses me. It seems like it's about your fate in another world, when you're already dead or something."

MARCELINO: "As I understand it, a person is left behind when that person is abandoned, because God's not going to be raising up some and not others; or in

other words, the one who's damned, that's the one that's going to be abandoned."

WILLIAM: "Somewhere else he says he'll set father against son and daughter against mother. Here he talks about two who are in the same bed, husband and wife; one is going to enter the kingdom and the other is going to go who knows where. And the same thing happens between the ones who are working together. It seems as though we've got the oppressor and the oppressed working together."

I: "And this is also the Last Judgment that Manuel was talking about. And we see that there is an end and a destruction, but for some and not for others."

On hearing this they asked him:

"Where will that happen, Lord?"

And he answered them:

*"Where the body is,
there the vultures will gather."*

I: "That's a very mysterious answer of Jesus. He says that where the dead body, the corpse, is, that's where the vultures will be, what we call buzzards."

LAUREANO: "Things like that are happening now. For example, planes come to bomb and they look like vultures."

ESPERANZA: "Ernesto, the way I see it is that before a victory there's got to be many battles. Then first there's got to be that sign, the buzzards, for the slaughter. But the kingdom of God can come piece by piece, country by country, because maybe it can't all happen at once."

OSCAR: "It's not just a matter of birds flying

around. There are guys fighting to free the people, and they're persecuted by the authorities: they are the vultures, because I imagine anybody persecuted by the authorities is a corpse. We're not talking about looking at birds."

BOSCO: "In Chile the buzzards are flying."

REBECA: "There's plenty of victims here too, all those who are in jail, who they've brought from Matagalpa. Up there in the north there's a lot of buzzards. So there we see the signs that Christ is coming."

LAUREANO: "Where there's injustice, that's what he says. Where there's victims."

OSCAR: "That's right, he was really the first corpse, the first victim; everybody that goes through the same thing for his cause is really him."

2.

The End of the World

(Matthew 24:1-14)

They went out of the temple. And the disciples were admiring the beauty of the temple. And Jesus said to them:

*Do you see all this? I tell you the truth,
here no stone will be left upon stone.
All will be destroyed.*

MANUEL: "That temple wasn't the true one. The temple is the union of people, not a house where they come together."

TOMAS PEÑA: "Of course: it didn't matter that the temple would be destroyed because that temple wasn't valuable; what was valuable was the people."

OSCAR: "And it seems to me it was a good thing that temple would be destroyed because it was a hindrance to them, because it was a material temple. I don't know how to explain it. Because it was idolatry. They were worshiping the walls."

ESPERANZA: "Was that temple made of stones?"

I said it was, and then she said: "And isn't it true,

Ernesto, that when we admire the riches of the rich and we say how well they live, Christ is also telling us that all that will be destroyed?”

OLIVIA: “I also think those luxurious temples alienate people more. The people endure so much misery and then they are supposed to be glad when they see how pretty those temples are. Jesus is not only telling them that’s going to be destroyed but that it’s good for it to be destroyed, that it has no value.”

I: “He has already told the Samaritan woman that the future was going to be without temples.”

WILLIAM: “I think Jesus is seeing the destruction of the temple as a sign of a whole old system that was going to be destroyed to give way to a new system. In that temple they had all their religious ceremonies, and what Christ is telling them is something very radical, very revolutionary: that the hour has now come to put an end to all those religious ceremonies. Christians haven’t understood this and they’ve filled the earth with temples. Jesus didn’t tell them that the temple of Jerusalem had to be destroyed so that they could build temples and cathedrals everywhere.”

I: “Keeping the same ritualistic religion in those temples.”

WILLIAM: “We’ve got that altar, or sanctuary, in the Church of Santo Domingo in Managua, that cost 80,000 pesos.”

TOMAS PEÑA: “That’s a sin. Because it’s money they’ve taken from others. That can’t be pleasing to God.”

I: “That temple that the disciples admired had been built by a tyrant, Herod I. And Jesus doesn’t seem to be sorry that the temple is going to be destroyed. On the contrary: he insinuates that that’s a good thing.

Communists are supposed to be antireligious, but Ezekiel had seen in a vision that God himself was setting fire to the temple. And the disciples have understood something, for the Gospel says that afterwards they questioned him 'in secret.' "

*We want you to tell us when this is going to happen.
What will be the sign of your coming
and of the end of the world?*

Then Jesus said to them:

"Beware, don't let anyone deceive you.

For many will come saying in my name:

"I am the Christ," and they will deceive many.

I: "The word 'coming' that Matthew uses here is the Greek word 'parusia'; that meant the triumphal arrival of an emperor. It was a political term."

"It's those political leaders that make false promises of salvation that are the false Christs. And also the dictators, the ones who deceive peoples and exploit them."

"Even though they don't exploit them or deceive them, even though they do good to the people, if they want to be adored like God, they also are false Christs."

LAUREANO: "You mean Fidel Castro, because you've been reading propaganda that the Yankees are handing out."

MARCELINO, with his calm voice: "Every false Christian is a false Christ. Because the Christian is another Christ; but the Christian who doesn't love, who exploits, is a false Christ."

FELIPE: "But it seems to me, Ernesto, that Christ was talking especially on a worldly level: there are

worldly teachings that deceive people with a false freedom, for example, the false prophecies of the capitalists, and people are left confused. They think that's the solution and meanwhile the people are starving, and meanwhile there are wars, like Christ said."

*You will have news of wars here and there;
but do not be alarmed,
for that's the way it has to be;
but it is not yet the end.*

*Because one nation will fight another,
and one country will make war on another;
and there will be hunger, illness, and earthquakes in
many places.*

*All this is scarcely the beginning of the pains of
childbirth.*

WILLIAM: "He's talking here, it seems, on a strictly political, not religious, level. He's talking about wars of nations and social catastrophes; and like Felipe, I think the false Christs or false Messiahs are not exactly false religion in contrast to a true religion but false ideologies, false political solutions, false freedoms that humanity has been deceived about."

I: "All that about earthquakes can also be interpreted as the tremors of society, not necessarily like the Managua earthquake (although these natural catastrophes can also have great social consequences). In general, he's saying that there'll be a lot of suffering in history before the establishing of the kingdom."

FELIPE: "For me this is something very real, because there's talk of hunger everywhere, there's poor

people everywhere, and there's also people struggling everywhere."

I: "The horrors of the Vietnam War have just ended; before that there were two World Wars; and every day we hear of other wars, and there's news of other situations of terror and repression in other places. The interesting thing is that Jesus says 'that's the way it has to be.' He's saying that those contradictions are inevitable, and that there'll have to be a lot of suffering so that peoples can be free. Jesus considers this no more than a painful childbirth in history, and so he says: 'Don't be alarmed.' "

ELVIS: "This is very important, because it's always been believed that this business about the end of the world is that the world is going to be destroyed; but it's the end of the world of exploitation. And it's really going to be a beginning."

I: "A new heaven and a new earth."

*Then you will be put to torture,
and you will be killed,
and everyone will hate you because of me.*

FELIPE: "He says 'everyone,' but I don't think he's referring to those peoples who believe in his cause."

LAUREANO: "When he talks of the world he's referring to the capitalist world."

I said that in the Gospel According to Saint Mark these words of Christ appear with more precision: he says that the persecutions will be in the name of 'the synagogues' and 'the governments.' Religious power and political power. These two powers can be repressive separately and also in alliance. And these two

powers are the ones that tortured him and murdered him.

*At that time many will lose faith
and will hate one another and betray one another.*

NOEL: "All that is being fulfilled."

FELIPE: "All those Christians who don't believe in freedom, who believe in exploitation: they've lost their faith."

ELVIS: "Right here in Solentiname, there are people who've stopped coming to church because they're scared of a Gospel that might get them involved. They've lost their faith. And how many more there must be like that in Nicaragua, in Central America, in the whole world."

OLIVIA: "There are many who are very religious and they don't have faith. Those that don't want to get involved, because they believe salvation is just believing in God, those have lost their faith."

GLORIA: "And because they lost faith is why they've lost love. They hate each other, they deceive each other, they swindle each other, they exploit each other."

DONALD: "And those Christians without faith betray their brothers and sisters, as we've seen in Chile. They betray them, they turn them in to be tortured and killed."

*Many false prophets will appear,
who will deceive many people.
And there will be so much iniquity
that the love of many will grow cold.*

*But the one who goes on steady to the end,
that one will be saved.*

I: "The love of many will grow cold: that prophecy of Christ has been fulfilled in Christianity. Because of so much exploitation of people by each other."

BOSCO: "And the ones who stay steady to the end are the ones who here, or in Chile, or anywhere else, stay steady until they see the coming of liberation. Like the people of Vietnam that stayed steady to the end."

An old man who had come from the Costa Rican border: "Don't you think he's talking of a spiritual liberation?"

FELIPE: "Yes, because love is the Holy Spirit. If you love, you have the Spirit of Love. But if you're evil you'll be acting with an evil spirit. You've got to be careful about using the word 'spiritual.' "

The old man: "Don't you think the false prophets are the evangelical preachers that want to convert people by taking their religion away from them?"

FELIPE: "They're more probably those who are preaching a spiritual love, that is, a purely spiritual kind, up in the air, without any reality."

WILLIAM: "The false prophets are the ones that preach that all you have to do is love God. They're the ones that make people's love grow cold."

I: "And they could just as well be Protestant evangelists as Catholic evangelists, the ones that call themselves Pentecostal."

OLIVIA: "So when we see so much injustice we mustn't think Christ's prophecies about the kingdom have failed, because that also had been prophesied.

He said it had to happen before the kingdom came.”

BOSCO: “He said those prophets would be ‘many.’ And we’re seeing it. All those priests and pastors who defend the rich and preach patience because it’s God’s will to have poor people around.”

TOMAS PEÑA: “Not even if God was unjust.”

The visitor: “Right there in my town a young fellow became an evangelical pastor and he’s been all around preaching the Gospel and now he’s filthy rich.”

*And this good news of the kingdom
will be preached throughout the world,
so that all nations may know of it;
and then the end will come.*

The old visitor: “I notice the Gospel is being preached everywhere. It used to be that a poor person couldn’t read the Gospel because it was forbidden to read the Bible. Now the Gospel’s being preached to everyone, not just to the rich but to everybody, because we’re able to read the Bible and sometimes they even give it away.”

FELIPE: “But you have to keep in mind that there are two Gospels: the one preached by those liars who say they’re talking in the name of God, and it’s to keep the nations oppressed, and the other one, the Gospel of liberation.”

OSCAR: “And that end? That end the Gospel talks about, can it be the end of the world? What will that end be like?”

I: “Notice that it says, ‘This good news of the kingdom.’ It doesn’t say the ‘Gospel,’ which is just a Greek word that means good news. Jesus isn’t saying that evangelists are going to be going around every-

where handing out Bibles. He says that the good news is going to be announced to the poor. And the bad news to the rich: for if it's good for the poor it's bad for the rich. It's not the evangelists, Protestant or Catholic, that give you this news when they give you the Bible. Instead they're saying the world is never going to change and there will always be injustice. And Christ says that all the peoples will receive the news of liberation, and that will be 'the end.' And we're not going to receive a piece of good news so that the world will be destroyed. In Greek the same word 'end' is used to indicate the destruction of something or its perfecting. The end of the world that Jesus talks about is like when the work of an artist is *finished*."

ESPERANZA: "If they were going to rouse everybody's conscience only to put an end to the world, that wouldn't make sense. It would be better to go on the way we are."

LAUREANO: "It's the end of the United States and its representatives throughout the world."

WILLIAM: "And we see that now all the people are receiving this news, not necessarily through the Bible."

OSCAR: "I was asking you that because, even though they've told us a lot about the end of the world, they don't tell us that the world is going to be completed and is going to be perfect. That seemed to me very peculiar. And I said: Well, if they're going to put an end to the world, let them end it right now, because there's no hope."

ADAN: "What he announced that had to come first, starvation, wars, we're seeing it."

ALEJO: "For a long time back."

OSCAR: "It's like a woman in the pains of childbirth.

If the pains are very strong it means she's going to give birth."

WILLIAM: "It's the final pushes."

I: "On the eve of his death, Jesus spoke again of the woman who suffers a lot when she has birth pains, but later she is so happy when her child is born."

NATALIA, the midwife of Solentiname: "Well, you begin that suffering, and another one and another one. But you're happy. Because now you're free. Because you were oppressed. Because to go around like that is to be oppressed."

I: "The earth is a woman who will be set free of her oppression. As Natalia says, she will be liberated."

3.

The Coming of the Son of Man

(Matthew 24:29–36)

*As soon as those days of suffering end,
the sun will darken, the moon will not give its light,
the stars will fall from the sky,
and even the heavenly forces will tremble.*

CARLOS: “Maybe with these images he’s trying to tell us that the world is going to be turned upside down. That everything we’ve lived through up to now is going to change and it will be entirely new.”

I said I agreed with Carlos. Jesus is talking of the great changes that humanity will see, with the images of a cosmic cataclysm. At the time of the Managua earthquake lots of people believed it was the end of the world, because that’s the mistaken idea of an “end of the world” that Christians have had for centuries, through having interpreted literally those apocalyptic images. Jesus isn’t talking about the ruin of the world but the ruin of the status quo. And we have to keep in mind that he says that will happen immediately after the sufferings. He had previously said that humanity would have sufferings such as it never had since the

beginning of the world, and that it wouldn't have them again.

WILLIAM: "I think there's not only going to be a change in humanity but also in nature. We've already seen that the world is changing a lot through people, and it will change much, much more. But above all what's going to change most is people."

CARLOS: "And it's clear that that falling of the stars isn't the end of the world, since in the next verse Jesus says that after that all the nations will see his coming. So there will still be people."

*Then in the sky will be seen the sign of the Son of Man,
and all the nations of the earth will weep,
and they will see the Son of Man coming
in the clouds of the sky with great power and glory.*

I said that Jesus never gave himself the title of Messiah; when he talked about himself he called himself the Son of Man. In Hebrew and Aramaic the Son of Man means simply "the Man," but that's also the name that is given in the Book of Daniel to one sent by God who comes to defeat the empires of the earth that seem to be "beasts." Against the "beasts" is set up someone "with a likeness of man," that is, with a *human face*. Man in the Bible is the image of God, and from that comes the proscription of having other images; and Ezekiel describes the glory of God as a "likeness of man." It seems also that Jesus didn't want to give himself the name of Messiah because to the Jews of his time the Messiah was a leader with political power; on the other hand, in the Book of Daniel the

Son of Man is one who defeats the beasts of political power.

FELIPE: "It seems to me that the Son of Man or Man will gradually appear to the peoples as the struggle for liberation advances. The more the revolution advances, the more Jesus is going to appear. The cataclysms, as you were saying, are the evil society that's slowly destroying itself, and it's then that Jesus begins to appear."

"In the proletariat, in the poor."

DONALD: "He says the nations of the earth are going to weep. It seems to me that if everything is just as always and suddenly there's a change in everything, let's say it's the revolution, then the capitalists are going to weep and shout and rage because they're going to get screwed. It seems to me that's the way it'll be, right?"

I: "The prophets had spoken of that weeping that the nations will do, that is, the governments, but they had also described it as a weeping of conversion. The weeping that Jesus speaks of can be understood that way, and some translations of the Bible say that 'all the nations will beat their breasts.' "

PANCHO: "I think what we're reading here can be understood according to each one's ideas; you understand it this way because you have Communist or socialist ideas, as you call them; but others will understand it another way, and I don't know which side to be on, yours or the other."

FELIPE: "But it's by means of analysis that we can understand the Gospel; if we start reading things without analyzing them we don't understand anything."

PANCHO: "It's because you're talking about a material reality and we have an immortal soul."

I: "We have an immortal soul and an immortal body also. According to Christ our body is going to be resurrected."

FELIPE: "I think so, too, Ernesto: the ones who save their bodies have saved their souls, but the ones who lose their bodies will also lose their souls."

PANCHO: "But what about a person who doesn't believe in the soul?"

I: "What does it matter if someone believes only in material things if material things are going to be resurrected?"

FELIPE: "If they don't intend to be resurrected that's no problem because if they're going to be resurrected they're resurrected even though they don't intend to be."

ELVIS: "It seems to me that resurrection is to be alive in the people."

PANCHO: "Really, some poor guy dies and that's it, bang, and we're left remembering him! But he's done for. He lives in the hearts of the people, but that's not the way you want to live. You want to feel yourself really with others, to breathe the air others are breathing."

OLIVIA: "It depends on the way he died; because if he was somebody that never did anything then he's completely dead, but if he's somebody who identified with the people he's always with us. It's like if Ernesto dies, to us he doesn't die, to us he's always alive."

I: "I shall be breathing with you; I'll be breathing the air that the people breathe. Here Jesus says that all the peoples will see 'the sign of the Son of Man.' In another Gospel he said that the only sign or miracle

that he would make would be 'the sign of Jonah,' who was in the belly of the whale and came out alive. So that sign is resurrection."

*And he will send his angels
so that with loud trumpet blasts
they may gather his chosen ones
from the four winds,
from one end of the world to the other.*

FELIPE: "I think the people were confused thinking that Christ was going to gather his chosen ones to take them to another world, or rather, to heaven, and it's just the opposite: it's to get them to be active in this world, to carry out with them the liberation of the peoples."

I: " 'Angel' in the Bible means messenger; as God has messengers, the Son of Man also has messengers and with them he will gather his chosen ones; so we see that the world is not being destroyed."

ELVIS: "What's going to be destroyed is the capitalist system. There's going to be destruction, but not of the earth. That's what the people have understood as a rain of fire and all those things."

MANUEL: "But hadn't Jesus said earlier that there were few chosen ones? But here he talks about a lot of them, that they come from everywhere, from the four winds."

WILLIAM: "We have to look at the context. Before, he was talking about his own coming, and he was talking to the Jews, telling them that among them there were few chosen. Other times, talking of the end he gives the example of the wheat and the straw, or the good and bad fishes, and he makes it seem that the

chosen ones are very numerous. Now, talking about his second coming he presents the gathering of the chosen ones as a great world event.”

GUSTAVO: “And that trumpet blast, it seems to me it’s like: ‘Proletarians of the world, unite.’ ”

IVAN: “And I think there’ll be lots of them because the dead are also going to be chosen, the ones who haven’t died, who are living as we’ve said here; like in the case of Che, and of all the martyrs, all the ones who have sacrificed themselves for the people.”

I: “The prophets had talked a lot about the fact that in the messianic era there would be gathered all the oppressed Jews who were scattered throughout the world and who would come from the four winds. Jesus refers to that meeting, but now it’s not only for the Jews but for the oppressed from all over the world. The trumpet is an image that he also takes from the Old Testament. God’s interventions in history are like the sounding of trumpets. The prophets, when they announce the fall of the great empires of the enemies, speak of trumpets. Isaiah says that a trumpet will summon all the peoples when the Assyrian kingdom is crushed. So the trumpet is the call to liberation. And Saint Paul makes it clear that there will be several trumpet blasts or different liberations, for he says that ‘with the last trumpet sound the dead will be resurrected.’ ”

*Learn this example from the fig tree:
when its branches are tender and the leaves sprout,
you know that summer is coming.
In the same way, when you see all this,
know that the end is near, at the door.*

FELIX MAYORGA: "Well, the fact is that the coming of Christ is known. He says that when the fig tree has its sprouts, you notice that it's summer, hot, right? Then, when we all love each other, we'll know that Christ is coming."

LAUREANO: "We're all seeing sprouts now. Cuba can be a sprout. China, another one."

I: "And besides there are other sproutings in different parts of the world. Even in Nicaragua there are those sprouts."

MANUEL: "It's beginning to sprout, as Laureano says, when people are struggling for justice."

CARLOS: "I think there have always been people who've struggled for justice, but now it's different, now they're beginning to form groups everywhere, little communities that are already announcing the kingdom of God. And it's very moving to see how these groups are enormously alike without knowing each other."

BOSCO: "Through those sprouts of freedom that are all over the earth, we know that the end is arriving."

FELIPE: "Those sprouts come from the people; and they come especially from young people: with young people humanity is renewing itself everywhere. Maybe that's why Jesus talks about branches that are tender."

OLIVIA: "He says that 'the branches are tender and the leaves sprout.' The leaves sprout because earlier the leaves have fallen. That's how young people renew the ideas of other generations that have died, that apparently have died. The fig tree had dropped its leaves, it was stripped, but inside it had living sap. In youth you see that life sprout that's the life of the leaves that have died; then those leaves revive in other new sproutings."

I: “Young people in different parts of the world are having the same ideas that we have among the young people here in Solentiname. Those are the signs, says Christ. And he gives the example of a fig tree, a plant that bears fruit. Therefore it’s not about the destruction of humanity but about its maturing. And that maturing is love: the image of the fig tree is taken from the Song of Songs, where the lover tells the beloved to rise, for the winter is over, that the rains have stopped, and the flowers appear, the time for singing has come, the cooing of the turtle dove is heard, and the sprouts of the fig tree are blossoming.”

*I tell you the truth, that all this will happen
before the people of this generation die.
Heaven and earth will pass away,
but my words will not pass away.*

I: “These words of Christ are the most mysterious in the Gospel. Could it be that Christ was wrong? Many Bible experts don’t know how to interpret this. But I believe that in the Bible there’s nothing that the people can’t understand.”

ADANCITO: “Maybe there was already beginning to be a change in those people, just a few of them.”

CARLOS: “In the times of the apostles there were already communities starting where they had everything in common, where they lived with love. Those young shoots were already beginning.”

I: “Or perhaps that the end of the world, which we’ve said is the end of the system of injustice, according to Christ was already beginning from that time. So we’re in the end of the world, and we have already been in it for some time.”

OSCAR: "I think we're already seeing that, injustice is being destroyed. We're seeing those changes in lots of places, and the world will have to change. That's what Jesus meant there, the victory over injustice."

MANUEL: "It may be that he meant: 'before the people in this capitalist society die.' Because in those times there was capitalism."

I: "There was exploitation although with another name. And Manuel may be right. It has been observed that the word 'generation,' in the mouth of Jesus, always has the meaning of evil people. Elsewhere he talks of 'this perverse and adulterous generation.' "

OLIVIA: "It seems to me also that as he was the first to suffer and the first liberator, the first one sacrificed for what was to come, then the people were already seeing the beginning of the liberation that he was announcing, because they were seeing his death."

ELVIS: "It seems to me that he was referring to the empire that existed at that time. Soon afterwards, I believe, came the destruction of Jerusalem. So I believe he was referring to those things."

MANUEL: "But then this part wouldn't be valid right now; if he'd said it for that time it would have no validity at the present time because it would be all over."

LAUREANO: "It's because it's being fulfilled part by part."

MANUEL: "Jerusalem was destroyed but capitalism is still in existence."

I: "I think, as Oscar says, that we're seeing the end of injustice. And to those who were listening to him Jesus was probably saying that they were already beginning to see that which we now see more clearly. A few blossoms on the fig tree were beginning to be seen. And, as Olivia says, with his death, that is, with his

resurrection, liberation was beginning to be seen. And also, as Elvis says, this was the fall of the empires: the fall of the empires was beginning and the end of the world was beginning and now we're fully into it."

ELVIS: "Now we're seeing the fall of capitalism. We're right in the process."

WILLIAM: "Every process has transformations. And every process begins with something very small. So the baby develops slowly in it's mother's belly, and then it's born and goes on developing until it gets to be grown-up. And so too the kingdom of liberation was already a fetus from that time on, and was developing."

OSCAR: "I'm intrigued, Ernesto, by these words 'heaven and earth will pass away but my words will not pass away'; it seems to me that Jesus there is talking about a destruction: maybe capitalism and the things that treat us badly, I don't know if he's going to destroy heaven and earth too."

I: "If heaven and earth were going to be destroyed, how then would his word be fulfilled?"

ELVIS: "So it would be useless, the struggle of so many countries and so many people: to struggle just to die."

I: "His word *will* be fulfilled, Jesus says; and his word is the liberation of the oppressed and the triumph of the poor."

*But as for the day and the hour,
no one knows, not even the very angels in heaven,
not even the Son, only the Father knows.*

LAUREANO: "That's what I believe. Yes, the day and the hour when we're going to establish a kingdom of

justice here, we don't know it. Maybe tomorrow, maybe within a year, maybe within ten years. But let's hope it's soon, because we don't want this any more."

PANCHO: "It seems to me that Jesus knew it, but it didn't suit him to tell the people."

OLIVIA: "I think he said that because it was taking so long to raise the consciousness of humanity; he couldn't be sure of anything because he didn't know how the process of humanity was going to be. Because if in a small community like here we're not all conscious, how must it be with all of humanity! That's why he couldn't be sure."

WILLIAM: "Because it's not one day or one hour, it's an infinite number of days and hours, because in each community or each group that becomes conscious, there the day and the hour have arrived; but in others it hasn't happened yet, who knows when it'll come."

I: "It's true that it depends on the will of people. There are people who hasten liberation, the coming of the kingdom; there are others who oppose it and delay it."

OSCAR: "Ernesto, I think Christ says that, about not even the Son knowing, because he really didn't know, because he was born like us. If he'd known, he'd have told the secret to his brothers and sisters, and we'd know it on earth and we wouldn't have started waiting. But what we've got to do on earth isn't waiting but struggling."

I: "This reminds me of what Marx said: You couldn't know when perfect Communism was going to be established. But that scientifically you could know it had to be established, since nature and history tended toward that."

LAUREANO: "Well, if you know when liberation is

going to come, if you know that it's even inside of twenty years: why should you be screwing around?"

I said that a Jesuit, Father Jon Sobrino, has written that Jesus not only didn't know when the kingdom would come (as he says) but besides he was expecting it to come very soon (with an impatience like that of young Laureano). As the kingdom has been delayed all these centuries, we Christians of today are in a different situation from the situation of Jesus. And therefore, he says, we have to make social and political analyses that Jesus didn't make, and following Jesus can't be just blind imitation of Jesus.

MANUEL: "He says we must be vigilant because he'll come like a thief in the night. It seems to me we ought to be getting used right now to the new system, so we won't be surprised. Like what happened in Cuba. Some people, since they didn't know anything about revolution or have any love, they suffered terribly when that change came. They must have felt oppressed because they didn't understand, they weren't prepared. For them the change came like a thief to rob them."

OSCAR: "I think it's going to be soon, here in Nicaragua. It's a triumph that's coming, because all the young people in the country are going to be united against capitalism, and then when they catch on, it'll be too late."

I: "That's the triumph of love, everybody being united, as Oscar says; and that's also the triumph over death, the resurrection that Pancho was talking about earlier. The Son of Man, resurrected, is coming to bring resurrection to all his body, which is all of humanity."

4.

The Wise Virgins

(Matthew 25:1-13)

We commented on the Gospel in the hut, after a lunch of fried fish, tortillas, and an onion salad that Natalia brought.

The kingdom of heaven is like ten girls that came to bring light to a wedding with their lamps, some with enough oil, others without enough.

*As the bridegroom delayed in coming,
they all got sleepy, and they finally went to sleep.*

“This parable refers to the marriage of God with the people. The bridegroom that humanity will have is true love, which is God. But when we say that God is love, we don’t mean it’s any old love, like the love of a couple, that can be selfish. That love means there won’t be any more injustice on earth. That love is the revolution.”

I said that a Latin American theologian (Padre Juan Luis Segundo) says that the word “kingdom” that Jesus used was at that time as explosive as the word “revolution” is today.

"It seems that those girls got tired of waiting and fell asleep. Maybe you can get tired of waiting for the kingdom of love and you say: 'well, it's late in coming,' and you stop waiting for that kingdom."

I said it seemed to me that this parable is addressed especially to Christians. For two thousand years they'd been announcing the coming of the kingdom, and it seemed it was coming at any moment. And it hasn't come yet. It seems as though it's never going to come. The parable says that they all got sleepy and fell asleep. And so it has happened in history: Christianity didn't even go on waiting for that kingdom. But in the parable the girls weren't reproached for having fallen asleep. It seems that, since the bridegroom didn't come, there was nothing to do but go to sleep. What it says is that some had a good supply of oil, and others didn't.

"Take us here in Solentiname: Some are selfish, individualists; others are real comrades, who have love. Some are not going to be prepared when socialism comes, a society of equals, where we'll all be alike. The others are going to be prepared, they're ready right now because they have a community spirit."

"At first I couldn't make any sense out of this parable, but now I see it has a lot to do with our community. Some are negative, you'll never be able to do anything with them. Others are passive too, maybe they went to sleep for a while, but they're prepared. It seems that the revolution isn't coming, but it'll soon be here, and the ones that aren't ready'll be screwed."

Then at about midnight, a shout was heard:

"Here comes the bridegroom!

Go out to receive him!"

ESPERANZA: "It seems like the change is going to be sudden, and very quick, right?"

FELIPE: "At midnight, when it was dark, and quiet, and they were sleepy."

JULIO: "They all began by having oil. That oil is love. The ones that ran out of oil are the Christians that don't have enough love, right? They had some at first, but they didn't have enough for such a long wait."

OSCAR: "Those ten girls are all of us, and just as in that example there were five and five, so also among Christians there are some on the side of justice and others not. And when the bridegroom comes, the ones on the side of injustice are going to look for love right then, but it'll be too late."

OLIVIA: "It'll be too late to look for it, because love can't be learned in a day, you learn love all your life, and you teach it to your children, or else you teach your children selfishness. And people that have grown up with a selfish mentality and that belong to a society that's all selfish, how are they going to change suddenly?"

And the thoughtless ones said to the thoughtful ones:

*"Give us a little of your oil,
because our lamps are going out."*

But the thoughtful ones said:

*"No, because then there won't be enough for us or
for you.*

You'd better go and buy some."

"There are many that always take advantage of other people's work, and those guys, when the king-

dom comes, they won't have anything prepared for that kingdom, and when they see that now everything is happening, they're going to want to take advantage of what the others have achieved. And they'll say: 'Well, can we come in now?' And they won't let them come in. Jesus is telling us we mustn't wait for others to do things, for other people to establish justice and love on earth."

"And I see here, too, that you can't share solidarity with the selfish because then there won't be enough solidarity for everybody. In a revolutionary society the selfish have to be excluded."

*While they were going to buy it, the bridegroom came,
and the girls who were prepared
went in to the wedding with him
and the door was closed.*

"Oil gives light and joy, and that's the way love is. Each person is a lamp, but a person without love is a lamp that's gone out."

"He means that that error, not being ready for the kingdom, is not going to be forgiven. Those girls had the doors closed on them, they weren't forgiven."

"It's clear that the kingdom won't be for everyone. Five were left and five weren't."

TOMAS PEÑA: "Those young ladies that didn't have much fuel didn't go to buy the oil sooner, earlier in the night. If they had time to go, why didn't they go sooner and not wait until the bridegroom came! It's a good thing they closed the door on them."

I: "I suppose that when all of humanity loves one another, then we'll have the wedding of humanity with God, which is love: the marriage of God with the peo-

ple, as it has been said here. But this parable also makes us see that in humanity there are those who love and those who do not love, those who unite humankind and those who divide humankind. Some enter and the others stay outside, and the door closes.”

FELIPE: “The ones who don’t get in are the exploiters, who want to keep us apart.”

LAUREANO: “There are guys who’ve been revolutionaries before, and have even been in a war, and they’ve lost their spirit. And now again there’s warfare in Nicaragua, and all they’re interested in is making dough. It seems to me that those guys also ran out of lamp oil.”

“The Gospel gives the example of some girls, and maybe that’s because this applies mainly to young people: the young people of humanity that keep the oil coming, and the young people that don’t have any more.”

OLIVIA: “The Gospel’s for everybody, old and young. We’ve all got to keep our hope alive, like young people.”

ALEJANDRO: “That’s why an irresponsible young person is unforgivable.”

OSCAR: “The young people whose oil runs out are like they’re old. Their flame is gone, their love is gone. They didn’t have enough love for other people. Their oil runs out, and without oil there’s no light. There’s no light for the feast.”

*Be wakeful, for you don’t know the day
or the hour when the Son of Man will come.*

ESPERANZA: “He means that the change can come at any moment.”

I: “It’s going to be a surprise, according to this, and

when least expected. These words are encouraging, so that we won't lose hope thinking that the kingdom never came."

OLIVIA: "When they talk about these things, especially among us simple people, about how we don't know the day or the hour when Christ is going to come, all they think of is more praying, more obeying of religious rules. They don't think of the revolution, and that's like being asleep, because this religion puts people asleep. And Christ tells us, on the contrary, to be awake, with our consciences wide awake."

"And a lot of people are afraid of that day. When that Managua earthquake came, lots of people thought it was the Last Judgment. And Jesus says it's going to be like a feast."

OSCAR: "It's a great joy, man! In a feast we all get together and we share everything that's there, and we all take part in all the talking and we're all happy; you're full of joy. And when we're all together here, you feel happy, you feel a joy, it's a kingdom that we're all sharing in, it's a little like, like the coming of the bridegroom, I'd say."

I: "The gathering has to be of everyone, and that's why the resurrection is needed. All those that have died will also share in that joy, provided they lived with their lamp oil ready."

LAUREANO: "Now only a few people can afford to have big feasts, with whiskey and fancy things."

I: "Christ said specifically that the rich would be excluded from that kingdom."

LAUREANO: "That's because we're going to close the doors on them."

OLIVIA: "It won't be a feast like those feasts; it'll be more like the feast there is when in a country every

single one eats and every single one has medicine and every single one has clothes. If it was like that here, all Solentiname would be a feast, and all Nicaragua would be a feast because there's going to be love, and because there's going to be everything for everybody. And it's pretty much like that kind of a feast that the kingdom of heaven will be."

OSCAR: "Look: when a rich bastard has a feast, the poor people can't share. But when the people have a feast it's a joy for everybody and even the rich can share in it. It seems to me it'll be like that, like the people's feasts, the one that God offers in the kingdom."

I: "But the humanity that has already died has to share also in that feast; otherwise it would be a very exclusive and very unfair feast, like those of the rich. We'll all have to be alive, resurrected, in that new humanity, and it'll be a humanity that's going to die, because this is the wedding of humanity with God, who is love, the very fountain of life. I've wondered about one thing: why does the bridegroom of this parable get to the feast so late? The appointed time must have been earlier, since the girls who were waiting for him fell asleep. I think it must have been because the feast, for some reason, was delayed. This seems to be trying to tell us that the marriage of God and the people has also had a delay in history. We don't know why, and it will take place later than it was programmed. And that's why we're still in the darkness of the night, sleepy, hungry, cold, waiting for the bride and groom to arrive and for the feast to begin."

5.

The Talents

(Matthew 25:14–30)

The kingdom of heaven is like a rich man that took a long trip and left one servant five talents (about 100,000 pesos), another two, and another one, so they could invest them. On his return the one that received five talents gave back ten to him, the one that received two gave back four. But the one that received one talent said to him:

*“Sir, I knew you were a hard man
who harvests where you didn’t sow
and gathers where you have scattered no grain.*

*For that reason I was afraid
and I hid your money in the ground.
But I give you back what is yours.”*

The master answered him:

*“Evil and lazy servant,
so you knew I harvest where I didn’t sow,
and I gather where I’ve scattered no grain?
Therefore you should have put my money in the
bank,
and when I returned you would have given it back
with interest.”*

WILLIAM: "That's a lousy parable."

I: "Why is it lousy, William?"

WILLIAM: "Because it's about speculating with money: something we all condemn, like putting money out at interest; giving the money to others so they can work and work with it and hand over the profits to the owner of the money."

I: "It's really a very ugly example that Jesus gives of exploitation, of speculation with money, of pure capitalism."

ADAN: "Well, he probably didn't say it. Who knows who said it."

OSCAR: "He talks of the kingdom of heaven or of God, and he says we must all struggle, and that's why he gives the example of the money. But it's really kind of ugly too."

WILLIAM: "Maybe it's what those people could understand best."

FELIPE: "Like here among ourselves we give examples of hens and corn and kidney beans, which are the things we understand best, so it'll be seen clearer, in the people's words. Well that's the way Jesus was talking too. But there he was probably talking to another kind of people, people very stuck on money, and then he talks to them of the kingdom of heaven with the example of a money lender."

WILLIAM: "Who knows? It doesn't say here who he was talking to."

OLIVIA: "To the apostles and to us."

WILLIAM: "In this instance, I mean."

OLIVIA: "In this instance he's talking to us too. He's talking here about a work that he's left to us, not to one but to many, and we'll all have to account for what we do for others. It's much more to do a thing in common than to make money, because if you work for a

community or a country, well then it's capital that's being produced: being conscientious, seeing that the wealth is distributed, that there's medicine for everyone, in short, it's a lot of capital that's being distributed. And that obligation isn't just for one or two or three of us but for every one of us, until we act in accordance with that Gospel, with that very Gospel, all of us."

OSCAR: "Man, money's what we condemn, but it's only when you earn it by abusing your sister or brother. When you give it, not take it away, you shouldn't be cursed or condemned."

WILLIAM: "Well, I don't know. Besides, the example is lousier because of what the servant says who hid the money: that he was a hard master, that he gathered where he hadn't put anything, that he harvested and didn't sow."

TERESITA, his wife: "At that time there were only masters and servants, right? He had to talk like that so they'd understand. At that time all the servants had to be working with the master's talents or money, and that's why he had to give that example."

I: "He was seeing the exploitation there was in the society of his time, and that's going on now—much worse with the banks and finances of today."

WILLIAM: "There's the bank, there's a bank there!"

I: "And it's a condemnation of this system. He says that's the way the kingdom of heaven is, only the opposite: the rich man that devotes himself just to multiply his money is like the man that buried the talent he'd been given and didn't make it produce. Because money is to be given, it's not to be put away; nor is it to be multiplied, because that's not doing anything with it."

PANCHO: "It seems to me this is clearly spiritual. You always refer every passage of the Gospel to the rich and the exploiters and money, but here Jesus is talking of money only in the form of a parable and he isn't referring to money: these coins or talents are the wisdom that God gives. Some people may have received a lot of it, like the talents of an engineer, a lawyer."

FELIPE: "That wisdom that you mention and money amount to the same thing: money brings that wisdom, and the wisdom brings money."

A girl asked Pancho: "Somebody who's received a lot of money, a millionaire, what should he do with his money?"

PANCHO: "Not try to steal, pay fair salaries."

ELVIS: "That would be to keep the money buried and not multiply it; to multiply it would be to give it to the people, to the people that it's been taken from, for it used to belong to the people. So to return it in his case would be to make good use of the money."

PANCHO: "That would be a person who maybe has stolen. Many can make money with their work, earning just profits."

ADAN, his brother: "What happens is that when you've got it, even though you earned it easy, that money's already being used to exploit. Any deal you make is exploitation because it's with somebody else's labor."

OSCAR: "I see that that man had to go away, and he wanted his money to increase, the way he saw it. And he looked for others who were exploiters like him, and he gave them money so they'd exploit the people and earn more and get double what he was leaving them. So they were all equal as exploiters. They were exploit-

ing the people. But the guy that didn't get much, one talent, he didn't cooperate with them. He was conscientious, because he didn't have the strength to exploit his brothers and sisters. That's the way I understand it. Then the boss got sore when he comes and hands back the same as what he'd been given. We've got to work, we can't goof off, but we're not going to exploit like those were doing."

LAUREANO: "But it's a parable, man, it's got a different meaning."

PANCHO: "Well, it's because the word of God is a word of wisdom, and Jesus never made a mistake in giving these examples. And if we begin to think of 'exploitation,' 'the rich man,' 'who is robbing the poor man' and all that (that's all we have on our minds), then we don't understand the example. He wasn't talking about those things. Well, now, there's others that hide behind the Bible to rob all of humanity. And Christ didn't want to tell them that; he wanted to show them what was spiritual, the word of God."

I: "See, Oscar, here Christ gives the example of an exploiter, and his employees were exploiters too; and he wants them to multiply his money. And Christ says that's the way God acts with us."

OSCAR: "Oh, well, what God wants *us* to multiply is love!"

MYRIAM: "Love is what God has given to all of us, in different quantities."

OSCAR: "I see it now: the ones that have loved humanity a lot have also received a lot of love, and they duplicated it."

GLORIA: "Some have received more and others less, but everybody ought to double what they have."

OLIVIA, her mother: "The one who's practiced justice, which is the same as love, is the one who's multi-

plied. The other one, the one that didn't do anything, is the egotist. The parable doesn't tell that some folks received money to increase money: it's us; the money is us. It tells that you have to give up what you have and work for others."

DOÑA ADELITA, a little old lady with a very faint voice: "That's the business. The one that has done the most good works has done the most business."

OSCAR: "That's what this Gospel's saying, but maybe the rich don't understand it, and then what they do is screw you. They start to argue with you, hell, a poor jerk that doesn't understand."

I: "In Cuba they call workers that have cut a lot of sugarcane for the people millionaire cutters; they're millionaires not in money but in service and work. And that's the kind of capitalists and millionaires that Christ says we must be in the kingdom of heaven. Don't you think that's the way it ought to be interpreted?"

FELIPE: "And those are the accounts he keeps. And he says he's going to be tough in keeping accounts. The guy that didn't produce anything, it seems to me, he can be the religious man who just begins praying and singing junk and he hasn't done anything for the good of the world. And he's afraid to get mixed up in the revolution because he thinks it'll turn out bad, that maybe it's a sin."

I: "Christ says that just as exploiters multiply money, so we revolutionaries must multiply love."

WILLIAM: "And love is money; love is also wealth well distributed: the two things are related."

I: "And money would be good, as Oscar says, then, if we use it as we ought to, distribute it, and then that's the way love is multiplied."

LAUREANO: "As I see it the kingdom is society and

the ones that have received most are the ones that have the most responsibilities. In the case of Cuba, for instance, Fidel is multiplying the talent well. Here it's just the opposite, because here the government may be busy multiplying the talents, but not for the people, so not for the kingdom."

"The situation here is worse than the man in the parable. That guy was condemned because he didn't use the talent that he'd been given: he didn't do good, he didn't do evil. These guys use all the resources, but they use them for evil."

FELIPE: "He gives the example of a guy that buried his money, because that's what the capitalists do with capital. They're like that one that didn't use it even for himself or for anybody; he just put it away."

"In society there are people who have big jobs, and they multiply, but they don't share it. Maybe they have love just among themselves, but they don't share it with the people. In Cuba, Fidel, *he* multiplies and shares it."

LAUREANO: "It's working for others. He calls him there just a master; a master can be all of society."

I: "But that master is also God who has given humanity all the riches of the earth to multiply. To multiply for him, for love, which is the same as saying, as Laureano says, for all of society. And he's going to be a hard man when he asks for an accounting."

WILLIAM: "But the bad servant accuses him of harvesting where he didn't sow. It's a terrible image; he makes him out a monster."

I: "As the miser is relentless in demanding his money, God is relentless with love."

WILLIAM: "As a matter of fact, if he asks for an

accounting it's because love sowed it. Perhaps that one didn't realize what had been sown, and that's why he says that."

TERESITA: "That's an excuse by the servant who didn't do anything. People who don't do anything for other people always have that excuse: that love is very hard."

FELIPE: "Freedom, love, for the exploiter is a monster."

*And he said: "Take away his talent,
and give it to the one who has ten.
Because the one who has
will be given more and will have extra;
but the one who has nothing
will lose what little he has."*

I: "Isn't that unfair?"

LAUREANO: "If it was money, sure."

PANCHO: "That's what I'm saying! He wasn't talking in material terms, he was talking in spiritual terms. Because it wouldn't be fair for me to take away from a guy that has only ten pesos and give them to a guy that has ten thousand. That wouldn't be fair; Christ didn't say that. And yet the rich exploiter reasons that way."

I: "That's what happens with money. Those who have the most earn most and those who have little lose even the little they have. Capitalism makes the rich get richer and the poor get poorer. The bank takes away your lands or forces you to sell when you can't pay the bank. But the same bank loans to the big land-owners so they can buy those lands. Just as now many in Solentiname are having to sell their small properties to the great landholding company that's interfering

here. Christ says the same thing will happen in the kingdom of heaven, with love."

OSCAR: "I agree. The guy that's selfish, don't let him have anything, because he's not doing anything, he just lives for himself. There he's talking about the ones that are selfish. The guy that just lives for himself. He doesn't love even himself because he doesn't mind losing his soul."

I: "Those who have the most love will become richer and those who have very little are going to be left poorer, says Christ."

OSCAR: "In that sense the thing is fine, because it's okay to take from a guy that only has a little and give it to someone that's deserving. But the truth is that this Gospel is a little involved with the question of money."

I: "He gives the example of capitalistic exploitation to make us see that the same thing happens with love as with money. But as I say, it's the reverse because the one that has money and keeps it selfishly is the one that has no love."

TOMAS: "He has love, but it's love for money."

OSCAR: "See, Ernesto, it's all clear here, all that you're saying, but notice, I find that in lots of people, you know, the Gospel is very fashionable, everybody reads the Bible now; if unfortunately somebody comes along who is quite, let's say, interested in money, and unfortunately he starts to read this Gospel, and understands it in his own way, these words are going to make him worse than before."

FELIPE: "Well, he couldn't be stupid enough not to notice that it's an example."

OSCAR: "Well, if they understood it there wouldn't be any rich people."

FELIPE: "Well, rich people don't even notice things like that.

OSCAR: "Well, I'm saying then, that if unfortunately they read it there, they think it's a defense of them."

LAUREANO: "But don't they see that this isn't being said for them but for us? Doesn't it say that you have to give to the one that has? And the rich man, what does he have? Why the money doesn't belong to him, it belongs to all of you."

ALEJO: "Of course, this example is one of money that's been given and that doesn't belong to them. They're supposed to multiply it and give it back multiplied. It's not for them to sit on it."

LAUREANO: "Well, in another Gospel it says it's easier for a camel to pass through the eye of a needle. And if he's making them rich it's so they won't be saved."

OSCAR: "I think it's clear up to a point, even an ignorant guy can understand it, because he's talking directly. But the other idea is a little more confused so it's difficult for us to solve the problem."

I: "The command that God gave to man and woman when God created them was: grow and multiply. That's the law of love: be fruitful and multiply. It is proper to life to multiply oneself."

WILLIAM: "What's unnatural is for money to multiply itself, creating more money all by itself."

I: "And God doesn't want us to give him back nature just as we've receive it; we must give it back to him re-created and transformed. And finally we see that anyone who won't take risks in order to change the world is condemned to solitude, is separated from humanity."

*And that useless servant,
throw him into outer darkness,
where he will weep and gnash his teeth.*

OSCAR: "That's the one who has no love even for himself."

TOMAS: "The weeping is from fury, and he gnashes his teeth because he's furious."

OSCAR: "Maybe he's a criminal, a murderer that will kill us all. We've got to get rid of him."

6.

The Last Judgment

(Matthew 25:31–46)

*When the Son of Man comes as king,
surrounded by all his angels,
he will sit on his throne of glory.
People from all nations will gather before him,
and he will separate them some from others,
as the shepherd separates the sheep from the goats.*

I: "I've just come from Managua, where I was summoned, as you know, to be interrogated by the Military Court that is investigating the activities of the FSLN [Sandinista National Liberation Front], and there I quoted to the judges this very passage, telling them that in the end God was going to judge everyone. But now that we have read the text I realize that Jesus doesn't say that God is going to judge but that he himself is going to judge."

FELIPE: "He says it will be when he comes as king, that is, when the kingdom is established, and since we know that the kingdom will be here on earth, the judgment will then be here on earth."

WILLIAM: "And it's not that he's going to come on a

cloud; you mustn't take this literally; it's society itself that he's going to judge."

ALEJANDRO: "And the judgment consists in a selection from society, a separation of the good and the evil."

WILLIAM: "It's a selection that in fact is already going on, whenever a people becomes free. The evil ones leave and the ones that want to work for others and build the new society, they stay there."

I told them what I heard in Cuba from my friend the Catholic writer, Fina García Marruz: when the Revolution triumphed it was like being at the Last Judgment, for everything that had been secret came out into the light and you found out who had been with the people and who had been against the people and you rewarded some and punished others. And I said that the Judgment begins right now, as the Resurrection also, according to Christ, begins right now. But the complete Judgment, of "all the nations" as it says here, will not come until the kingdom is established on all the earth. And it seems to me that the Son of Man will not come as an individual, as he did the first time; he will be a collective Christ, he will come as a society, or rather a new species, the New Person. Father Charadin says that just as for the first coming of Christ it was necessary for the individual human being to have reached a certain degree of evolution, for his second coming it's going to be necessary for all of society to have reached a certain special degree of evolution.

FELIPE: "Let's say the people will be king."

*Then the king will say to those on his right hand:
"Come, you blessed by my Father;*

*receive the kingdom prepared for you
since God made the world.
For I was hungry and you fed me;
I was thirsty and you gave me drink;
I wandered as a foreigner and you sheltered me.
I lacked clothing and you gave it to me;
I was ill and you visited me;
I was in prison and you came to see me."*

WILLIAM: "Those who are on his right are the left for us. Those who are on his left, that he later curses, are the right."

ALEJANDRO: "There's the danger that the things that Christ names here will be understood as simple traditional charity, and I don't think that's the meaning."

GIGI, our friend from Peru: "At times in an unjust system there's been no alternative to that traditional charity. It's clear that authentic Christian charity is collectivized charity: a whole system where injustice no longer exists. Both of them are charity, but the latter is already the beginning of the kingdom."

I: "I also believe that we can't distinguish between charity and revolution, for they're the same thing. Camilo Torres used to say that revolution is *effective* charity. And he explained it by saying that only with it could there be effective carrying out of works of mercy in society as a whole: to feed the hungry, give drink to the thirsty, clothe the naked, teach the ignorant, etc. In the past the saints, when a just society wasn't possible because of the means of production that were then in force (slavery, feudalism, or capitalism), what they did was to practice charity individually or through a small group: a religious society that

they founded. But now Camilo Torres' effective charity is possible."

WILLIAM: "In Cuba everybody's been fed and given clothing, adequate housing, medical care, education. I think that when Christ spoke of these things, which are a person's basic necessities and the first ones that have to be considered, he was thinking, more than of traditional charity, of revolutionary charity: effective charity."

GIGI: "Yes, maybe he was talking for history and for the present instead of for people of his own time. Before, you couldn't do anything except what Francis of Assisi did. That was the maximum effectiveness; now there are other possibilities. One very important thing that I find in this Gospel is that it's an announcement of the definitive triumph of love, of justice, of the new society, and the defeat of capitalism."

FRANCISCO: "Its elimination."

FELIPE: "I see that when Christ spoke of the Last Judgment he didn't speak of religion, prayers, ritual: he spoke only of social needs."

ALEJANDRO: "Let's make no mistake about that: there are religious people who think they are good people because they give aid, alms, old shoes. That's not what Christ demands in this Gospel; it's a total change in the social system."

WILLIAM: "Christ speaks of visiting the sick; that's the only thing you could do at that time. Now he would have talked of clinics, free medical service, hygienic conditions, preventive medicine."

OLIVIA: "And being in prison? He just says 'I was in prison.' To be in prison is very wretched; being tortured in jail, the way they torture those Christs now, is much worse."

Someone from the opposite shore: "But somebody said that prayers are bad."

I: "What Felipe said was that in this Last Judgment no attention is paid to whether they prayed."

FELIPE: "They don't even pay attention to whether they had faith."

I: "More than that: those who are saved appear here as though they had no faith in Christ."

Then those who turned out to be righteous will say:

"Lord, when did we see you hungry and feed you?"

And the king will answer them:

"I tell you truly that everything you did

for one of these my brothers,

however humble they may be,

you did it for me."

The man from the opposite shore: "So religion is good for nothing?"

ELVIS: "If religion helps me to help my neighbor, then it's useful. If it makes me ignore my neighbor's needs, it's of no use."

OLIVIA: "When you go and see to it that a sick person doesn't die, that's prayer."

ALEJANDRO: "Going back to that final part: the identification is very clear. 'What you did with these . . . these are me.' We're always believing that Jesus Christ is a distant person, different from the people. And it seems to me very important, as it's been important to me for a long time: that even if a person is a snob, that person is God, no matter who. God identifies himself with human beings; God makes no distinction. And that's what makes revolutionary love spring up."

NATALIA: "God identifies with the needy. With the poor. With the humble."

ALEJANDRO: "With everybody that's screwed."

I: "With everybody that's screwed, as Alejandro says. I was saying before that that Son of Man would be a collective Christ, a society; and now I'm surer of it because of what Alejandro has said: Christ is the society of the poor, the proletariat, as we say today. And this people is the one that's going to judge."

ALEJANDRO: "That's right; he's going to judge those who were good to him and those who were evil."

OLIVIA: "So we're not going to have Christ coming from heaven to sit on a throne surrounded by his angels. It's the people that are going to do justice. The people are going to say: we were undernourished, barefoot, sick, landless, in the Model Prison."

FELIPE: "The people's angels, I think, are all the ones that have helped liberation."

I: "In the Bible, angels are God's messengers, or God's employees, and it seems to me that Felipe has given a good biblical interpretation. When Christ says he will come surrounded by angels he is presenting himself as God, for in the Bible only God is surrounded by angels; but he is also presenting himself as the people, for when he speaks in the first person ('I was hungry . . . I was in prison') it is the people that's speaking. So he's trying to tell us that the people is God. And so when I told them in the Military Court that God was going to judge everyone, I could have said that the people was going to judge everyone."

ALEJANDRO: "The tortured ones, the starving, the ones from the wretched districts like Acahualinca, they're the ones who can best understand injustices."

The ones who are suffering them, who are God. That's very simple, isn't it?"

JULIO: "That means that here it's up to the exploited ones to put themselves in God's place, who they really are, and say to the rich: I was thirsty and you did not give me water. And so the exploited ones will have to say those words."

ALEJANDRO: "And who else is going to say them?"

GIGI: "But now it's the people in the new society who are going to be the judge. When the people have power."

I: "When the Revolution spreads to the whole planet. 'People of all nations' means all of humanity. Right now we can't, right now we're being judged by them. There is that Military Court. And with that Court they're putting a lot of people in jail: to be able to go on keeping the people hungry, without clothes, without medicine, without houses."

WILLIAM: "In Christianity there's been a lot of preaching that Jesus 'is hidden' in the poor, and this has helped to maintain the difference between Jesus and the poor."

I: "And it's curious: those who were good to Jesus, he says they didn't do it for religious motives, and they didn't do it for him; they did it just to help their neighbor. It seems to me that this applies to all revolutions: none of them has been religious or Christian (at times they've been anti-religious and anti-Christian instead) and the revolutionaries didn't know they were doing it for God. I think that here Jesus is keeping the revolutionaries in mind. And foreseeing that all revolutions would be atheistic."

ALEJANDRO: "That's uncomfortable."

I: "Why?"

ALEJANDRO: "As we'd said before the people as a whole is Jesus. And now it's turning out that what they did for the people they did for Jesus. So in the long run is there a distinction between the people and Jesus?"

I: "He doesn't make the distinction; it's the others that make it. From the first he says, 'they fed *me* . . . they gave *me* clothing'; he's saying that he is the poor. But he's surrounded by angels, and he's also God. This reminds me of a parable that Mao tells, the one of the 'Old Madman who Moved a Mountain.' It's an old Chinese parable, of an old man that insisted stubbornly on moving a mountain, and he succeeded: because God rewarded his effort and moved it for him. And Mao says: 'The same thing will happen with us if we persist obstinately, but in reality, for us, God is the masses.' This seems to be pure atheism. But I think that Christ is doing something similar, when he tells us about the Last Judgment and puts the people in God's place; for in the whole biblical tradition God was going to make the Last Judgment."

GIGI: "And the oppressors didn't know either that it was Christ they were oppressing. They thought Christ was one thing and the people was another."

MANUEL: "That's what people have always thought."

GIGI: "Some didn't believe in him and yet they were good to him in their neighbors. Others believed in him and they weren't good to him in their neighbors."

WILLIAM: "And it seems to me he's showing that the damned were people who fulfilled their religious duties. But they were making a distinction between Christ and the neighbors."

GIGI (smiling): "This is a kind of atheistic parable."

*Then the king will say to those on his left:
"Get away from me, you damned ones;
go to the eternal fire prepared for the devil and his
angels.
For I was hungry and you did not feed me."*

LAUREANO: "They're probably cursing those bastards that are dead there: 'Son of a bitch!' But they're not going to be resurrected."

I: "And isn't there going to be any punishment for those who lived only among riches and pleasures, just having a good life, without any punishment here?"

ALEJANDRO: "The fact is that the life of the rich isn't at all a pleasant life; the life of the rich, shit! It's miserable. The worst part is that with their money they're making poor people miserable too."

WILLIAM: "There are rich people's lives that are delightful. I don't envy them, but I recognize it; why kid ourselves, why say they live bad if they live well."

ALEJANDRO: "All those rich families in the movies. What goes on between father and daughter, son and mother; they have horrible lives. Yes, those have been damned all their lives."

I: "But here we're talking about an eternal punishment."

LAUREANO: "It means that they're going to be suffering."

MANUEL: "Their punishment, a punishment forever, is having been what they were."

OSCAR: "The eternal fire, it seems to me, is the torture of selfishness."

I: "If saved humanity will be eternally united, those who separate from it will be eternally separated. The first ones Jesus calls 'the blessed of my Father.' The

second ones he just calls 'cursed.' He doesn't call them 'the cursed of my Father'; it's because God doesn't curse anyone. They have cursed themselves."

OSCAR: "Those of us who believe ourselves to be religious can be under a curse. Maybe somebody came to me hungry and I didn't help that person at that moment; and maybe I say, I'm religious. For me religion is worthless! What's worthwhile is loving. And it's not just because I'm religious that I'm going to be saved."

I: "And those who are saved, Christ is telling them they'll receive the kingdom that God prepared for them. On the other hand those who are damned, he doesn't tell them they'll go to the eternal fire that God prepared for them but that God prepared for the devil and his angels. And it's also interesting that Christ says the kingdom was prepared from 'the beginning of the world.' The fact is that evolution has had an aim from the beginning: the establishment of that kingdom of love, on this planet and on all the millions of inhabited planets that there must be in the universe."

GIGI: "I believe we'll survive as a collective consciousness of humanity, if we've been good. If not, we can't be part of that consciousness."

"And do you think there's a heaven?"

GIGI: "Heaven is this earth."

I: "And it can also be the heaven above, that we all see: the starry sky. This can even be explained with Marxist philosophy, called dialectical materialism, which says that matter is eternal. It has existed and it will exist forever; not the slightest particle can ever be destroyed. And I say: if material is eternal, there is also an eternal life, and an eternal consciousness. And

when we die, we can go to form part of that universal consciousness, depending on the degree of evolution that we have reached; or else we can remain eternally separated. And it seems to me that we can understand the resurrection of our bodies this way: that since we're part of the consciousness of the universe, our bodies will be the whole universe."

GIGI: "And it's very clear what Jesus says here: that it's those who love ('I was hungry and you fed me') who are going to have eternal life. Those who have loved him, which is the people. Or have loved the people, which is him. (It's all the same.)"

WILLIAM: "Those who establish justice on earth. That's why he finished by saying that 'The just will go to eternal life.' "

I: "Those who are saved he twice calls 'the just.' In the Bible the 'unjust' are those who rob orphans and widows, those who are responsible for there being poor, who get rich at the expense of others, take away lands, commit fraud, are bloody and cruel, in short, they are the oppressors. The 'just' are the opposite of all that. 'Just' is equal to revolutionaries. And 'Judgment' in the Bible, as José Porfirio Miranda explains very well, means liberation or the establishment of revolutionary justice. The Book of 'Judges' deals with liberating chieftains of Israel, none of whom performed a judicial function in the modern sense. In the Bible it says that God 'judges the orphans and the indigent,' and that means that he saves them, not that he takes them to a Military Court. And Yahweh the 'Judge' in the Bible is not a neutral judge who's going to judge rich and poor equally; he's the avenger of the poor. All the liberating actions of God in the history of

Israel were called 'God's justices.' But the people were again oppressed, and they were hoping for a final, definitive liberation, a judgment after which there would be no need for any other judgment, a Last Judgment. And that's the one that Jesus has described for us."

7.

The Rich Young Man

(Luke 18:18-30)

One of the leaders asked him:

*"Good Master, what must I do
to inherit eternal life?"*

I: "One of the leaders means one of the ruling class. When he describes this scene, Matthew just says he was a young man. So he was a young man from the upper classes; a rich young man."

Jesus said to him: "Why do you call me good?

*There is only one who is good, and that one is
God."*

MANUEL: "It seems he's forgetting that he is God and he doesn't want to be called good. Because he says only God is good. So it's in company with the Father and the Holy Spirit that he's good, that is, in unity. It seems that a single person isn't good; a person is good only in unity."

OLIVIA: "But I think too that he tells him this be-

cause the young man appeared before him as good. He was a somebody, that rich young man, and he came to present himself as a good young man. He came with brow raised high, the shameless one, to say that he obeyed the commandments; and Jesus doesn't want to be called Good Master because he sees that he's saying it because he's calling himself good. To the young man, he and the Master are equally important persons, and they are both good."

ALEJANDRO, Olivia's son: "But what Manuel says opened a whole new field to me. He revealed something I'd never seen: that Jesus is good only in his union with God; nobody can be good alone (unless they go off into the mountain, to be in a cave). We are good only in society. We are good united in society, and that means united to God, love. And a single person not helped by the others isn't good; that seems to me very profound."

I: It seems to me also that for that upper-class young man there were good teachers in Israel, and Jesus is telling him that no teacher is good for anything. The only teachings he should follow were those of God, love."

"You know the commandments:

*'Do not commit adultery; do not kill;
do not steal; do not tell lies about anyone;
respect your father and your mother.' "*

The man said: "All this I have obeyed since I was a child."

I: "It's curious: Jesus tells him that he has to obey the commandments; and when he names the com-

mandments, he names only those about love your neighbor. He doesn't mention the commandment about love of God."

FELIPE: "It would seem that to Jesus those are the only commandments. And the young man thought he was obeying them, and he wasn't, because he was lacking the most important thing: sharing."

JULIO: "He thought he wasn't stealing and wasn't killing and wasn't lying, and he was a rich man!"

Young ADAN: "Of course, he was exploiting and stealing and he didn't realize it."

When Jesus heard this he said to him:

"One thing is lacking:

sell everything you have

and give it to the poor,

and then you will have riches in heaven;

then come and follow me."

But when the man heard this,

he became very sad, because he was very rich.

MANUEL: "I think probably that rich man wasn't stealing. If he had been, Jesus Christ would have reproached him for it, because he was no fool. He would have said to him: You did too steal. But let's suppose the man was honest; he's telling him that he must get rid of selfishness, that he had respected all the commandments but he still had all that wealth and even though he'd got it honestly, he must give it up."

ALEJANDRO: "There's no wealth honestly acquired."

MANUEL: "But just suppose the man has acquired his wealth honestly."

ALEJANDRO: "No, it's only by stealing that you acquire wealth. They always steal."

MANUEL: "Or inherited."

ALEJANDRO: "Then they've inherited from somebody who stole."

OLIVIA: "God gave the earth to everybody equally; if anybody has anything that others don't have, they must have stolen it some way."

FELIPE: "Yes, I think that from the moment he tells him to go sell his wealth and divide it up, it's because he didn't come by it honestly. Of course he won't say: you've stolen this, go divide it up. It's a way of saying to him: don't go around stealing."

I: "According to the law he hadn't stolen. But Christ is a subversive and he converts wealth into a crime. This rich man, who surely had inherited the wealth because he was young, wanted also, as he says, 'to inherit eternal life.' But Christ tells him that the two wealths are opposed to each other."

OSCAR: "The boy had told him that he obeyed everything, but when Jesus told him to give everything back, he didn't like that, so he still couldn't enjoy the kingdom of God because he wouldn't give up what he had."

ELVIS: "It means that if a poor young man has obeyed all the commandments, he's okay, right?"

OSCAR: "It seems that it's easier for the poor man. As long as he does all that, well, he can win the kingdom of heaven. Because what can he give if he's got nothing? So I think Jesus is taking these shots at the rich. Because he could carry out all the commandments but it won't do him a bit of good because he won't let go of what he's got."

ELVIS: "But also if a poor young man doesn't practice love he's just like the rich man."

OSCAR: "But I say it's still easier for him."

JULIO: "I see one thing: he doesn't say to give alms or to share a lot; he says give it all."

FATHER JOSE ANTONIO, a Peruvian priest who is visiting us: "Just before I came here, a workman said to me, in a bus, while we were crossing through the ruins of Managua: 'Here there was great injustice and it's a good thing all this has been destroyed. I think everything God does is very good, lovely, and that the evil in the world is done by people.' And on coming here I have seen the splendid work of God, these islands, and also a beautiful work of people, the unity of this community. I believe the rich young man was seeking this, that he didn't find it, love, in riches. Love is the only thing that gives us happiness. Jesus had told him he must put aside all that was preventing him from loving. He had wanted to enter the kingdom, but he still wanted to be rich, and that's why he was sad."

I: "He was a good young man. The Gospel According to Saint Mark says that Jesus stood looking at him fondly when he said that he had obeyed all the commandments since childhood. But he had that drawback, that he was very rich. Jesus offered him happiness, but he preferred riches, and he was left saddened."

When he saw him sad, Jesus said:

"How hard it is for the rich to enter the kingdom of God!

It is easier for a camel to pass through a needle's eye than for a rich man to enter the kingdom of God."

PANCHO: "The young man was presuming that he had obeyed everything. Jesus let him talk, but afterwards he put him to the test and he didn't measure up. When Jesus told him to share, he didn't like it. Then Jesus said how hard it is for a rich man to enter."

OSCAR: "He was good, but he didn't feel satisfied in spite of being good. And that's why he had to ask Christ what was lacking for him to feel satisfied. And he never expected it was going to be his wealth. He thought he was going to ask him to do something else. But when he heard the answer he became sad, because he wasn't expecting that."

FELIPE: "But I also do believe what Pancho says, that that guy wanted to show he was a very religious man, a good Christian. But when Christ told him that, he got sad because he saw he really wasn't obeying everything, that he couldn't be a Christian."

"I want you to tell me: a rich man can't get into the kingdom of heaven?"

OSCAR: "It seems to me he can't."

ADAN: "He cannot."

LAUREANO: "And that bastard wasn't obeying the commandments. Because a son of a bitch that has plenty of money and doesn't give it to the needy isn't obeying the commandments."

GLORIA: "We saw in the parable of the rich man and the beggar that the rich man was condemned just because he was rich: because in the parable it didn't say he was exactly an evil rich man."

LAUREANO: "All by itself the word "rich" means a rich bastard."

OSCAR: "And this young man, what he really loved was his money. What Laureano says is true, it's obvious; he wasn't obeying anything!"

I: "The very fact that this young man was rich while others were poor meant that Israel was breaking the law of God, because God in the desert had given to the people the precept that among them there should be no poor people and therefore that there shouldn't be rich people."

MYRIAM: "And nowadays, there's a lot like that, who think they're obeying the commandments."

OSCAR: "A lot? The world is full of them!"

ADAN: "It seems to me that what Jesus said about the rich screwed them; he left them absolutely finished: outside the kingdom. He sent them to the kingdom of death, you might say."

FELIPE: "The rich, upper-class people, it'll be hard for them to be with the revolution. That's the way I see all that about the camel and the needle's eye. The bourgeoisie can't enter the kingdom of God."

MYRIAM: "How hard it is for a rich man who doesn't want to help others with his money to have love!"

Those who heard him said:

"Then who can be saved?"

Jesus said to them:

"What men cannot do

God can do."

LAUREANO: "I think that he was trying to tell them that one person can't make another person change, but God can make that person change."

FELIPE: "It seems to me that he's also showing them that there are two kinds of actions: God's action and human action. People with their own human ideologies can't do this, share what they have. But with God's ideology they can indeed do it."

OLIVIA: "Even the rich can be saved, if they share, but not if they don't. And it's God who through a miracle can make the rich share and also be saved."

LAUREANO: "I think God's been sleeping a lot, because God ought to have made them share."

I: "Through the history of Christianity there have been rich who have abandoned everything to follow Christ; many great saints were former rich people. Saint Anthony the Abbot was a young Egyptian millionaire who had inherited enormous estates, and at the age of twenty he went into a church at the moment when the priest was reading this Gospel phrase that we've just seen: 'Sell all you have and give it to the poor.' And he did that at once. But it's true that such cases are exceptional, and as Laureano says, it would seem as though God has been asleep. But Christ himself has said the rich can be saved only through a miracle. That's why we have to create a system in which the wealth is shared, so that in all of society we can fulfill what Jesus asks here of the rich young man. Or rather, so that there won't be any more rich young men and so that everyone can enter the kingdom of heaven."

ALEJANDRO: "No more rich young men, and also no more wretched young men."

I: "There won't be any poor people to distribute the wealth to, because with it all distributed there won't be rich and poor. That's the kingdom of God. And for a rich man, being rich, to enter that kingdom is like for a camel to enter the needle's eye, because in that kingdom there can't be injustice or inequality."

Peter said to him: "Lord, we have abandoned what we had, to follow you."

He answered: "I tell you truly that anyone who leaves home or parents or brothers or wife or children for the kingdom of God will receive much more in this world and in the future world: eternal life."

ALEJANDRO: "We see that the poor also have things that they can abandon: home, parents, brothers, wife, children, those are riches that the poor can give up."

FATHER JOSE ANTONIO: "But that giving up means to receive more of that very wealth, from now on, in adoration to life in the future kingdom, which is a life that does not die."

JULIO: "He tells us to put selfishness aside. Because there are also poor people who don't want to give up anything; and there are people who say that communism or the change 'is going to take what I have away from me.' How can they take away from me if I barely have an acre to live on! That must be for people who have five hundred or a thousand acres, people who own half of Nicaragua, and they're the ones who'll have to give it to the poor."

OLIVIA: "Yes, we poor can also be selfish and just hang on to the four hens we have."

LAUREANO: "The little hawkers who have their little stalls, the ones that sell in the street, they have a horror of change because somebody's going to take away from them what they sell in the street. It's pure ignorance. They don't know that afterwards they won't need to go around selling like idiots crying their wares in the street."

ADAN: "Maybe nobody's shown them the Gospel."

8.

The Curing of a Blind Man

(Luke 18:35-43)

We were in Papaturro, a village near the Costa Rican border, reached by a river on the banks of which there are always monkeys and lots of water birds. The little church is in a cocoa grove, and as it was very hot inside we had our commentary outside under the cocoa trees.

We read that the blind man was begging at the roadside. He asked what the racket was, and they told him that Jesus of Nazareth was passing by. He shouted:

“Jesus, Son of David, have pity on me!”

I: “At the time of Christ, they had begun to give the Messiah the title of Son of David. Some writings of the period have been preserved, the Psalms of Solomon, which announced that the Son of David would free Israel from all the enemies that oppressed it, would drive all sinners out of the country, would also destroy all immoral nations, would establish justice throughout the world, and would rule over a great people.”

OLIVIA: “I bet that blind man already heard the

news that Jesus was around there, and he was probably anxiously waiting for him, and when he heard all that hubbub, all those people walking along there, he thought maybe that's it. And when they told him it was Jesus, he shouted because he wanted to see and because of his faith in Jesus as a liberator."

"That 'have pity on me,' only a person can say it who feels very humiliated, very poor. He was begging beside the road. There are rich people that are blind but this was a blind beggar."

"When he calls him Son of David he's calling him leader of the people. He's being subversive."

"Sure, like suppose we get to a city, San Carlos, for example, and we shout, 'Hurray for President So-and-So,' who's not the president, right?"

"To have him called Son of David wouldn't be very pleasing to some people."

"And here it says they shut him up."

*Those who were at the front of the group scolded
him*

to make him stop,

but he cried even louder:

"Son of David, have pity on me!"

"Like somebody that'd be shouting 'Hurray for Che Guevara!' "

"He really wasn't afraid of death."

I: "They've told him that the one who was passing by is Jesus of Nazareth. Nazareth was an insignificant town. It seems they called him 'Nazarene' as a kind of nickname."

"Like saying Solentiname."

I: "They've told him that Jesus the Nazarene is pass-

ing by, but he doesn't call him that; he shouts 'Son of David.' "

"Maybe the ones that shut him up were friends of Jesus, his followers, who were kind of hiding him. That's why they said: 'Shut up, don't shout, don't say the leader is here, the messiah.' "

I: "It had been prophesied that the messiah was going to come to give sight to the blind, to make the deaf hear, to cure the sick, to free the captives. and this blind man, by begging Jesus to give him sight, is also proclaiming him messiah."

Then Jesus stopped and had the blind man brought to him.

When he was close, Jesus asked him:

"What do you want me to do for you?"

LAUREANO: "That sure was a dumb question."

OLIVIA: "It was to test his faith and confidence. He already knew that's what he was going to ask of him, that he had so much faith he was going to ask him for sight."

"But do you think Jesus knew that?"

ELVIS: "If he'd known it he wouldn't have asked."

I: "The man hadn't said what he wanted. He only asked him to have pity on him."

LAUREANO: "Yes, but if a blind man is there begging and he says 'Have pity on me,' it's either so they'll give him money or sight."

I: "Well, it could be that he was begging for alms."

LAUREANO: "Oh, no, because they announced that the Son of David was going to give sight to the blind and health to the lame and all that."

I: "Well, then, we see that he knew about Jesus. Be-

cause he could have been just asking for alms. 'A little help for me.' "

LAUREANO: "No, he was asking for eyes, not for anything else."

The blind man answered:

"Lord, I want to see again."

Jesus said to him: "See!

You are cured because you believed."

"Along there where Jesus was going maybe there were other blind people, or other beggars, blind or not, and Jesus didn't do a thing for them. They weren't asking him for anything, they didn't believe in him."

"And that's what happens to all us poor. We're always in trouble and we don't all have faith that he's the liberator of the poor."

"The people is a blind man begging for alms at the edge of a road."

"And when he asks for freedom they tell him to shut up because they can really screw him."

At that moment the blind man could see

and he followed Jesus praising God.

And all the people that saw this,

they also praised God.

"This shows the faith he had, because he followed him praising God."

I: "And why God? The one that cured him was Jesus."

LAUREANO: "He knew it was all the same."

"It seems to me that following Jesus like it says here

is like following the revolution. At that time Jesus was the man of the revolution; he was the head of it.”

I: “It says he went praising God. That meant he was proclaiming that God had sent the messiah.”

ALEJANDRO: “Ah, you’re right! I hadn’t thought of that.”

I: “He was praising God for having sent the messiah. ‘Praising God’ and ‘blessing God’ and ‘giving thanks to God,’ which are all the same, in the Bible mean proclaiming freedom from oppression. This is not praising God as the charismatics do.”

“And all the others opened their eyes too, and they saw what they hadn’t seen before, that Jesus was the messiah, the Son of David, because that man revealed it to them. Because it says the rest of them also praised God with him.”

“So it seems that all those people turned subversives.”

“That blind man changed into a leader, and he made us see that any one of us can be a leader, because he was the one that made the other people praise God.”

I: “That blind man at the side of the road probably had heard about Jesus. He’d been told deeds or parables of Jesus, and he already believed in him; he believed he was the messiah, the national liberator. And according to the Gospel, that’s having faith: believing that Jesus is the messiah. That man was proclaiming him king. It’s curious that at other times Jesus doesn’t allow people to call him messiah, but here he does allow it. At other times, after a cure, he tells them not to speak of it, but not here. It’s because he’s about to have his triumphal entry into Jerusalem. This cure happened in Jericho, near Jerusalem. It was going to be his triumphal entry, and his death.”

ALEJANDRO: "And coming back to what was said before, about praising God: it's like praising God through the revolution."

FELIPE: "But if we don't believe in that, if we believe there'll always be selfishness, then we can't change things."

9.

Zacchaeus

(Luke 19:1-10)

We read the story of the rich publican who wanted to see Jesus when he entered Jericho.

*But he couldn't see him
because there were many people
and Zacchaeus was a short man.
Then he went ahead of them and climbed a sycamore
near where Jesus had to pass.*

TOMAS PEÑA: "It seems to me that rich guy didn't have any false pride. When he saw Jesus was going to pass by there, he climbed right up to look at him. Even though he was an important guy, he shinnied up a trunk like a kid; he didn't mind looking silly. He didn't look like a rich man up there, just like a youngster that's going to see something that interests him."

"Maybe because he was short he was humble."

"He could have told the people 'Stand back' with that pride rich people usually have and he could have

gone to where Jesus was. But he was satisfied just to look at him."

OSCAR: "I think that because he was rich everybody respected him, right? But when Jesus showed up there, the rich man felt tiny, he felt . . . like he was repenting, I don't know. He didn't feel proud or conceited; he realized that what he was doing to other people he shouldn't be doing. That's why he felt so tiny facing Jesus."

BOSCO: "Maybe he was afraid too that Jesus would be mad at him because he was rich, and Jesus was against the rich and he knew it."

*When Jesus passed by there,
he looked up and said:
"Zacchaeus, you come right down
because today I've got to stay at your house."*

FELIPE: "But even though he was rich he liked Jesus and he was very glad to take him home, even knowing that Jesus was talking against the rich."

ALEJANDRO: "Other times we've seen Jesus against the rich, but here we see he wasn't a prejudiced man or a fanatic. He chooses to stay in a rich man's house without getting an invitation. He invites himself. Even when there were plenty of other places where he could stay, because there were swarms of people welcoming him."

OLIVIA: "At least Jesus saw he was a rich man who could be humble, and so he was a rich man that could be saved. If Jesus hadn't gone to where he was, that man would have gone on being rich. He would just have looked at him, been content to see Jesus passing by from up in a tree. But Jesus wants to save him."

*When they saw this,
everyone began to criticize,
saying Jesus had gone to stay with a sinner.*

TOMAS: "People didn't understand or even know what Jesus was looking for. They didn't know his mystery. He was coming to save sinners, not to destroy them. That guy that was on the edge of the pit, he came to pull him back and set him on the good road."

FELIPE: "They thought he'd gone to stay there so he could have a good time. They probably said: Why didn't he stay with a poor family, with Christians?"

I: "They don't criticize that he's gone to stay with a rich man but that he's gone to stay with a sinner. This rich man belonged to the class that were then called 'publicans,' people who weren't religious and who were despised by the Pharisees even though they were rich. You have to keep in mind that in that society, which wasn't capitalistic, the ruling class wasn't people that just had money, like Zacchaeus, but people that belonged to a religious caste (which had money as well). The scandal is that Jesus has gone to stay with someone who isn't religious, and it seems that's why Jesus went to his house."

*Then Zacchaeus stood up and told the Lord:
"Look, Lord, I'm going to give away half of all I
have
and if I've robbed and deceived anybody,
I'll give it back fourfold."*

"It sounds like he'd done some stealing."

"Of course he had; if he hadn't he wouldn't have been rich."

OLIVIA: "This would be the end of his capital, because everything he had must have been stolen."

I: "He must have been left with nothing, as Olivia says. At first he only intended to give half of what he had, which according to him was honestly earned, and give back four times what he'd stolen. But afterwards he'd gradually realized that everything he had was stolen."

Jesus said to him:

*"Today salvation has come to this house,
since this man is also a descendant of Abraham."*

TOMAS: "He'd brought him back into the family, right? He'd been off to one side, but Jesus brought him back into the family."

I: "This fellow, though he was a Jew, the others didn't think he belonged to the chosen people because he wasn't religious."

OSCAR: "And those people that believed themselves religious and went around criticizing, don't you think they were bigger thieves than that little shrimp?"

I: "Absolutely, because Jesus says of the others that they'd be robbing widows and orphans while they prayed on and on. And he tells them that publicans and whores will get into the kingdom of heaven ahead of them. (He doesn't say 'prostitutes' but 'whores.' The Greek word *'porne'* that he uses is equivalent to our word 'whores'.)"

ALEJANDRO: "Now we see it: pious people aren't revolutionary."

OLIVIA: "It seems like private property is what's holding back the kingdom of heaven. That private property, individual property, is what's stopping the

kingdom of heaven from reaching people. And taking a good look at it, it seems to me that, if there's any way to do it, they ought to close down the churches. Because look, with this false gospel that they're preaching, people think the sacraments are the whole thing. So a rich guy takes communion and goes out and he's done his duty. And the more churches there are open and the more preaching, or more lying, it seems to me, in the churches, the more delays there'll be in the coming of the kingdom of love."

I: "What you say is quite right. Churches ought to be closed down unless they preach freedom in them. In China, for example, they've had to close the churches because they were getting in the way of liberation. They weren't preaching the true Gospel in them, this salvation that Christ talks about here in Zacchaeus' house, the salvation of the rich that consists of dividing up their capital."

WILLIAM: "And when Jesus says: 'Today salvation has come to this house,' it's as if he'd said: 'Today the revolution has come to this house.'"

DONALD: "Now he's got to do just the opposite of what he was doing before. Before he was finding ways to increase his money. Now he's doing the opposite."

*For the Son of Man came to seek
and to save what was lost.*

WILLIAM: "It's interesting that he says 'what' and it's because he's referring not only to people but also to things, to wealth. What's in the hands of a few and lost to the majority. Christ has come to liberate the wealth, making it be shared, and naturally people too will be liberated."

DONALD: "And with a liberating Gospel it's interesting that more churches will be opened."

MANUEL: "But there's so many rich, filthy rich, that are very religious, and they think they've welcomed Jesus into their homes, and they don't do anything like what this Zacchaeus is doing, they don't divide up anything."

TOMAS: "Jesus hasn't been in their houses. There's nothing for him to do there. They're off to the side."

I: "Here we have an example of what the Gospel calls a conversion, which means a change (this translation of ours aptly calls it 'change of attitude'). Change of attitude or conversion is the same as revolution. It can't be only the individual, it has to be society too, and it can't be only society without being a change in individuals too. Anything else? If you agree, we'll stop here."

10.

The Resurrection of Lazarus

(John 11:17-44)

Jesus said to her:

"Your brother will live again."

And Martha said:

*"I know that he will rise up
in the resurrection of the dead on the last day."*

Then Jesus said to her:

"I am the resurrection and the life.

*He who believes in me,
even though he is dead, will live;
and he who is alive, and believes in me,
will never die. Do you believe this?"*

BOSCO: "Maybe she wasn't happy about the last day, because the last day was a long way off."

FELIPE: "It seems to me that Martha was thinking the way the old people have thought, our ancestors; at least that's what they used to tell me. They believed a lot in a last judgment in which everybody was going to be resuscitated, the caskets would be opened, I don't know how. It seems as though this Martha was thinking of that. But I think he's telling her it's not like that

at all. He appears, I'd say, more modern. He's telling her something very revolutionary there. He's telling her that with him the resurrection has arrived, and there's no point in waiting for that last judgment. He tells her that if he was a good man, even though he died, he hasn't died. And so anyone else who died, if they were good, then they haven't died. He tells her, then, to forget about the last day; what's important is doing good."

I: "He says that all who believe in him even though they die will live. He is incarnate love upon the earth, and one who believes in him is one who believes in his message of love; and this is not a resurrection on a last day, but it's beginning right now, as Felipe says."

FRANCISCO: "To believe his teaching is to practice it, because anybody who doesn't practice it doesn't believe it."

WILLIAM: "He says those who have died will live and those who are alive will never die. I believe the two things are the same: for you to die and to go on living. But the first, about the dead, is for us to be consoled about the deaths of those we love, and the second, about the living, is for us not to be afflicted about our own death."

ALEJANDRO: "I see that he says he's the resurrection and the life, as if they're two different things. And they really are two different things. Resurrection is a momentary event, and life is eternal, life is evolution: it's a process that doesn't end."

BOSCO: "But Lazarus must have died after he was resuscitated."

WILLIAM: "Of course he did."

I: "He means that he's talking of another resurrection when he tells Martha that he is the resurrection

and the life. We see that she wasn't happy with the idea that her brother would rise up on the last day; she wouldn't be very happy with the idea that her brother would rise up to die again in a few years, and that he'd have to be resurrected after all on the last day. Jesus is telling her something very daring, something that would scandalize any religious person: the last judgment is the doctrine that I bring for society; I am the last day."

FELIPE: "It's as if he said to her: Child, stop believing in fairy tales."

PANCHO: "Who knows? Maybe she didn't believe much in the last day either."

OLIVIA: "He's talking about an eternal life, for physically we all have to die. But to live eternally you have to die the momentary sleep of death. But though you have to die you don't have to be enslaved by death, you can live eternally. The way your life is is the way your death will be. Jesus, then, is talking of eternal life, that the sleep of death is to live forever; that we're like a plant: that the seeds first have to be sown to bear fruit. Then Jesus is talking to her of a life that maybe she can't even imagine, that she's going to live forever. At that moment she only has the grief of not seeing her brother; that's why she's sad."

BOSCO: "That's what happened with Sandino and Che, who believed in the same communism as Jesus believed in, and though they died they're not dead."

WILLIAM: "And when he says that all those who believe in him, even though they die, will live, I think instead that it's because they die that they will live. Just like the grain of wheat. And to die is to die from a bullet, and it's also to give up your life for other people and to live for other people. And then, the ones who believe in him, because they die, they will live."

I: "It seems to me that that physical death that Olivia talks about we might call individual death. The individual dies but we go on living joined to humanity, which is joined to Christ. Each person dies but humanity is destined to live forever, as the body cells die each moment but the body goes on living. And so we die as cells, but we can go on living with a superindividual life which is the life of the organism, if there is love in us: because love is what keeps that organism alive. And that organism is the body of Christ, which has eternal life."

WILLIAM: "I remember a sentence of Fidel, in one of the last speeches of his that I heard. He says that imperialisms will pass away but the revolution is eternal."

I: "The revolution, which is the unity of humanity, remains; and that is the life that Christ talks about. And in another speech Fidel has said that individuals can disappear but the people endure, the people have eternal life. And he adds that the motto 'Homeland or Death!' means that it doesn't matter if you die as long as your people live."

*When Jesus saw the weeping of Mary
and of the Jews that were with her
he was very sad and his heart was troubled,
and he asked them:
"Where did you bury him?"
And they said to him: "Lord, come and see."
And Jesus wept.*

OSCAR: "I think he wept there not for the death of Lazarus but because they didn't have faith in him, in the resurrection."

DONALD: "He was sad because he had feelings and,

like any one of us, when he sees somebody crying, he cries. When he saw the grief of the family, he was moved to the point of crying."

Somebody asked Oscar: "And you don't cry when you see a friend crying because his brother died?"

He answered: "I cry because I don't have the power that he had, to say to him: Get up out of there, come out of that tomb."

I: "Well, here it says that when he saw the weeping he was saddened. It may be that it's as Donald says, that he wept for the death of a friend, but at the same time it may be a little like Oscar says, because he saw that we're always going to weep even though he brings resurrection; that even though the dead will live, for us there always exists the reality of death. There are some ancient Gospel manuscripts that don't say that Jesus was saddened but that he was angered, and there are biblical scholars who maintain that that was probably the original version, because it is stronger, and it's more likely that a copyist 'corrected' angered to saddened, which seems more logical than the reverse."

OSCAR: "That's what I say: that he got angry because they didn't believe in the resurrection."

DONALD: "Or he got angry with death."

I: "Or maybe both. But whether it was sadness or anger that he felt, the fact is that afterwards, at the tomb, he wept. In spite of his being the resurrection and the life."

FELIPE: "And we, when we see a companion die, even though we know he'll live forever, we have to weep for him."

ALEJANDRO: "An example occurs to me: you take a *madroño* trunk and use it as a beam in a house. It doesn't blossom, but it's useful for something else. It

can't bear the white flowers that it used to bear in the woods because it died from that world, but it's going to be of use in another world. And for the tree that change is painful; transformation is always painful."

WILLIAM: "Like when Che died, people wept for him, but his death was going to serve its purpose."

ALEJANDRO: "Here we have many church beams that are from *madroño* trees that used to bear flowers in December, and now they don't, but now they're all painted and they'll last for many years. Human beings are different, they produce more, but they're the same in that the transformation is always painful."

WILLIAM: "That can be a poem."

I: "It's very poetic because it's very true."

WILLIAM: "When Che died Fidel wept; but in that speech where he wept, he was saying that Che hadn't died."

"He was a seed fallen to the ground. Che dead is more dangerous than Che alive."

FELIPE: "Because now he's not just Che."

WILLIAM: "And his death, by God, cast his shadow over the whole world!"

FELIPE: "Now Che dead isn't just Che; his spirit exists in many Ches."

BOSCO: "There's a bunch of Ches, thousands of Ches."

Jesus said to her:

*"Didn't I tell you that if you believe
you will see the glory of God?"*

I: "In the Bible the glory of God is the triumph of God over the oppressors. It's like saying the libera-

tion. When they crossed the Red Sea, freeing themselves from Egypt, the Bible says they saw the glory of God. The glory of God is any victory of justice over injustice. And in the Bible that glory of God is God himself, it's his appearance in history, because the God of the Bible is essentially liberation."

ESPERANZA: "Ernesto, it seems to me it's like if now someone is talking to someone else about the change, for example, and the other one says: 'Oh, but when will it ever come?' We have to have faith, then, that Christ told the woman: 'Didn't I tell you that if you believe you'll see the glory of God?' Many people say: When'll that be? But there are others who manage to have faith and to believe, and so then they work for that. You have to have faith even if you can't see clearly."

I: "And we can say that the glory of God is change, is revolution. And Jesus is telling Martha that, if she believes, she's going to see that glory in the resurrection of her brother, a symbol of the resurrection of humanity."

ADAN: "We have been dead. The people have been dead. And now we're beginning to live."

FELIPE: "The way I was seeing it is that Lazarus comes to life. This is an example to let people see. It seems to me that now we can see we're exploited, pushed aside by an unjust society. But we can also see that this is going to change right away, like Lazarus who rose up, and there he was stinking in that cave and then they took him out and he came out resuscitated. I think this is something symbolic, but it's going to be a reality in society through the faith of all of us who believe in new ideas. This faith will make it happen."

Then they took away the stone.

And Jesus looked toward heaven and said:

*"Father, I thank you because you have
listened to me.*

I know that you always listen to me,

*but I say it for the good of these people here,
so that they will believe that you have sent me."*

FELIPE: "That means that if Jesus had been with people who had understood him clearly he wouldn't have had to be praying or any of that stuff."

BOSCO: "And he wouldn't have had to resurrect Lazarus so they'd believe in the resurrection of humanity."

LAUREANO: "And I think he also said that so they'd see that he doesn't have to depend on himself, that he's not just one person."

I: "That thanksgiving he prays aloud so that the people will hear it, not so that God will hear it, as he explains right here. We, too. Our thanksgiving in the Mass (Eucharist means 'thanksgiving'), we say it for ourselves; God doesn't need words, but we need those words."

After saying this, he cried:

"Lazarus, come out of there!"

And the dead man came out

with his hands and feet tied with bandages

and his face wrapped in a shroud.

Jesus said to them:

"Untie him and let him go."

FELIPE: "That's what Jesus was going to do with humanity, untie it from its bonds."

OLIVIA: "Each country that gets liberated is being resuscitated."

OSCAR: "He had to do that to show that death doesn't destroy people when they love. When you die they bury you and they don't see you alive anywhere. And so he had to do that, giving them a sample, really, when he took him out of that cave: death can't harm you if you have love."

MANUEL: "They used to bury people in caves then."

FELIPE: "The cover was a rock, it wasn't a glass cover."

I: "Death is like a bond, and Jesus has shown that he has come to untie humanity from those bonds of death. And that's what he is doing *now*, to those who believe in him. But for twenty centuries Christians have gone on believing like Martha: that the resurrection won't come until 'the last day.' "

"And why would it be that, like it says here, when Jesus arrived, Martha said to Mary *secretly*: 'The Master is here and calls you'? "

WILLIAM: "It must be because he was going around in secret. Earlier it was told that when Jesus was going to appear at Lazarus' house, Thomas said: 'Well, let's go and die with him.' "

OLIVIA: "He risks his life to resurrect Lazarus. And from that time on they were looking how to kill him."

"And also this can be an image of what he came to do in the world, to give his life so we could all be resurrected with him. All of us with him."

I: "Resurrection is all of humanity together, and resurrection, as Oscar says, is made by love. This reminds me of a poem by the Peruvian poet César Vallejo: he says that a fighter died and a man came and said to him: 'Don't die, I love you so much!' But the corpse

stayed dead. And two men came and they said to him: 'Don't leave us! Come back to life!' But the corpse stayed dead. And twenty people came, a hundred, a thousand, five hundred thousand crying: 'So much love, with no power against death!' But the corpse stayed dead. Millions of people surrounded him, with a common plea: 'Stay with us, brother!' But the corpse stayed dead. Then all the people on earth surrounded him; the sad, disturbed corpse saw them; he got up slowly, embraced the first person and began to walk."

Several people said it was a very beautiful poem.
And we stopped there.

11.

The Alabaster Bottle

(Matthew 26:6-13)

It was in Bethany. When they were sitting at the table a girl approached Jesus and poured perfume on his head.

When the disciples saw this, they were angry and they began to say: "Why this waste? This could have been sold for much money to help the poor."

WILLIAM: "Maybe they were thinking she was bewitching him."

OSCAR: "If they'd sold it, it would have gone to only a small number of the poor, and the poor of the world are countless. On the other hand, when she offered it to Jesus, she was giving it, in his person, to all the poor. That made it clear it was Jesus we believe in. And believing in Jesus makes us concerned about other people, and we'll even get to create a society where there'll be no poor. Because if we're Christians there shouldn't be any poor."

I: "John, in telling this, says that the one who was

criticizing was Judas, and he says that Judas said it because he was in charge of the money and that he was a 'thief.' And he also adds that Judas calculated that it was worth about 300 *denarii* (which is about 1,000 pesos)."

OLIVIA: "It would seem that the one who said that said it sincerely, but it was hypocrisy, because he wasn't going to give it to the poor. Just like now, what an abundance of things there are, and the poor don't even get a whiff of anything."

WILLIAM: "Everything should really have been given to the poor, not just that perfume, so there was no reason for criticism."

GLORIA: "Maybe if she'd poured the perfume on herself nobody would have criticized her."

TERESITA: "It's possible that he'd done her some favor, some miracle, and the only way she found of thanking him was to perfume him."

I: "It seems that this girl, that John in his version calls Mary, is the same Mary Magdalene out of whom Jesus cast seven devils."

ALEJANDRO: "An expensive prostitute, it seems she was, one of the expensive ones."

WILLIAM: "Yes, because she was carrying a very precious bottle."

ALEJANDRO: "Possibly she saw herself as a slave, an exploited one, and saw in him her liberation."

TERESITA: "But why does she have to have been middle class? She could have been a poor prostitute, a working girl."

WILLIAM: "But all that perfume. And the bottle. The alabaster bottle!"

I: "The alabaster bottle was sealed, and it had to be broken to use the perfume. The perfume could be used

only once. And the Gospel says the whole house was filled with the fragrance of nard. It's believed that nard was an ointment that came from India."

TERESITA: "Maybe a smuggler paid her with that."

MARIA: "Jesus was a poor man, too, and he too deserved to have the perfume poured on him."

I: "And worse off than poor, for they were going to kill him two days later. In the passage before this, Jesus said that it was two days to Passover. And in the following passage it's told that Judas went away from there to make the bargain to sell him."

A student from Managua: "The Magdalene was used to that perfumed life, and things like that, and so she's being grateful according to her way of life. She's accustomed to a life of perfumes, jewels, carousing. And she pours perfume on him because that's the life she led, she thinks that's logical."

WILLIAM: "She's accustomed to squander everything on the man she loves. And she doesn't have that economical mentality of the others. She squanders it right there. And she's not making economical calculations, like Judas."

DONALD: "The criticism must have been because that perfume was one of the most costly, but for her it was still cheap to spend it on Jesus, because of what Jesus had done for her earlier. She wasn't paying even a quarter of what she owed him."

JOSE, Maria's husband, who works in the San José Bank: "But Jesus hasn't forgotten the poor, because notice that in the following verse he says they will always have the poor among them. He means that if they want to help the poor they can be helping them a lot, later. They'll have the opportunity to give everything to the poor."

Jesus heard this and said to them:

"Why do you bother this woman?"

This thing that she has done is a good thing.

*The poor you will always have among you,
but you will not always have me."*

BOSCO: "That's stupid."

LAUREANO: "That's a pretty weak answer because to say you're always going to have the poor is pretty silly."

I: "But isn't it true that we've always had them?"

LAUREANO: "But we're not always *going* to have them."

WILLIAM: "This is a phrase much used by reactionaries to say there'll always have to be poor people, because Christ said so. The world can't change, because according to Jesus there'll always have to be rich and poor."

I: "He doesn't say there'll always be poor. Let's read it again."

MYRIAM reads: "The poor you will always have among you."

WILLIAM: "And the 'always'? How must we interpret that 'always'?"

I: "Very simply. As long as there are poor, they will always be among us, we shall not be separated from them. Because the Christian community must be with the poor."

WILLIAM: "But there's that 'always.' Are there always going to be poor people? That's what disturbs me."

I: "He says they are never going to be separated from the poor. That's not the same as saying there'll never stop being poor people. As long as there are

poor, they'll always have them at their side, and among them."

TOMAS PEÑA: "When there's no more poor they won't."

A student: "I've got it! He says 'among you.' He's referring to *them*, to his disciples, but that doesn't mean there'll never fail to be poor; he's not talking to all of humanity."

LAUREANO: "Well, it *was* the disciples that he was saying that to. The disciples always have to be among the poor; they couldn't be among the rich."

TOMAS PEÑA: "There's lots of ways of being poor: a poor person can be somebody with an arm missing. A poor person is somebody born stupid, or an orphan child, without parents. These will be in the community. There'll always be people like that in need, but of course if we're Christians they won't be poor, in poverty; if they're among us, that is, we won't let them perish."

NATALIA: "Like what's happened in Cuba, where they treat the orphan children with enormous affection, and the insane, the old folks, the crippled, the widows. They're all cared for."

OLIVIA: "It could also be that he was telling them instead, it seems to me, that there wouldn't be rich people, that everybody had to become poor. That there must be only poor people. That's what socialism claims. The revolution isn't so we'll all be rich but so we'll all be poor, so there'll be enough for everybody. Not disastrous poor but comfortable poor, tidy, clean, with medicine, with human dignity."

"Or is it maybe that since there'll always be progress there'll always be new needs and there'll always be people that are needy? Those would be the poor."

I: "That's what the reactionaries say. That even though there may be a lot of progress in humanity there'll always be a difference between rich and poor. That there'll never be a perfect society, a society all equal."

FELIPE: "It seems that if things are well distributed there can't be any rich; then everybody's poor."

I: "Jesus is referring to the beggars. It's for the beggars that, according to Judas, they should have sold the perfume. And it seems to me that's not a good prophecy of Jesus, and that it contradicts his announcement of the kingdom of heaven, saying that we'd always have beggars with us. I think what he's saying is that he's going away but that in place of him the poor are left. What that woman was doing with him, they'd have to do later with the poor, because he wasn't going to be there any longer, or rather, we were going to have his presence in the poor. But can it be forever that he'll not be there? The Gospel speaks of a second coming. He was going away and he was coming back."

FELIPE: "When there's that society that we dream about, that's when he's coming back, and we'll have him, and there won't be any poor people."

I: "Helpless orphans, people who have to go begging, or that sleep under a tree, or die in the streets the way the consumptives die in Managua, that's what's not going to exist when he comes. People for whom you ought to sell a bottle of perfume if you have one. All this now has disappeared in Cuba, and in all the other socialist countries. What supporters of capitalistic inequality say, that there will always be poor, has already stopped being true in socialist countries."

ELVIS: "Then there'll be no need to sell any bottles

of perfume, and people can use those perfumes, like that alabaster bottle, if they think it's useful to use those perfumes."

MYRIAM: "And pouring perfume on anybody will be the same as pouring it on Christ."

I: "So you can answer these people who defend inequality: there will always be poor people as long as Jesus isn't here. But when there's only equality and justice, and no needy, no beggars, Jesus will be with us again."

WILLIAM: "This passage has also been used to justify big spending for luxury in churches. Because Jesus accepted the pouring of perfume on him. But right here it says that afterwards we'd have to do that with the poor; we couldn't do it to him in church because he wasn't going to be with us in person."

OSCAR: "He wasn't going to be with us in person? He was going to be with us in the person of others."

OLIVIA: "What that woman did was a lesson for us, and a reminder, so that what's spent in great temples that are good for nothing can be better spent on people, on the poor people he left behind. Now we do have to give to the poor, because the poor are present with us. What she had present was Jesus, his person; now we have him present but in the person of the poor."

FELIPE: "Those who now want to spend a lot on church buildings and not on the poor, they're repeating what Judas did in opposing pouring perfume on Jesus. Judas did it because he wanted to get the money, and the people that now want all the spending for the churches, it's for the same reason, because they live off that money. They're thieves."

WILLIAM: "What he's trying to tell them is that they're worrying about something silly, and they're

not worrying about all the perfume that's been poured onto other stupid things."

I: "And that they're going to go on having poor people. And besides, they're not going to do anything for them."

WILLIAM: "He's telling them they don't do a damned thing for the poor."

OLIVIA: "I also see there, in that woman's attitude, the change in her. It seems to me that for that woman the most valuable thing she's found among her possessions is that alabaster. She's changed her attitude and from that day on she's begun to love, and she's given up the best thing she has. It seems to me that it's also a very good lesson for the bourgeoisie, because poor people don't have anything to give, only love; but for people that do have, Magdalene's lesson is very important: give up what you have, and it's no good to be beating your chest and giving lots of charity to a church, and not give what you have to the poor. She looked at Jesus, she saw him humbler than herself, and more deserving to use that alabaster, that fragrance, and she put the perfume on Jesus. It seems to me that she intended to give herself, all of herself, with that perfume. She looked at him: Jesus looked like a poor man, like a proletarian, because he never was in those big mansions with rich clothes or anything; so she saw him with that simplicity and that humility, and he deserved the best there was."

ALEJANDRO: "Besides, he must have needed that cleaning up."

I: "That perfume that they poured on people was like a deodorant, because there was no running water then; people weren't always bathing. And Jesus must have been, we might say, just a little smelly."

*“What this woman has done,
in pouring this perfumed oil on my body,
is to prepare me for my burial.”*

FELIPE: “Maybe because they wouldn’t pour any on him when they killed him.”

I: “He is predicting his violent death, without a normal burial. He really wasn’t embalmed. When the women arrived with ointments on the third day (and this Mary was with them), he was no longer there. And could it not be that she was doing this on purpose, foreseeing what was soon going to happen to him, and Jesus understood her purpose? Because in the previous passage Jesus had told his friends that it was two days until Passover, and that he was going to be delivered up to the Romans.”

*In truth I tell you,
that wherever this good news
is announced throughout the world,
what this woman did will also be told,
so that you may remember her.*

I: “But at the same time he foresees his immediate death, he foresees that his good news about liberation will be announced throughout the whole world. And that whenever his violent death is remembered, with no funeral, like the death of any subversive, they will remember what that woman did, as part of the good news.”

OLIVIA: “It seems to me that the remembering is for us also to do what she did. So that we do it now, not to him anymore, but to the poor. Or to him in the person of the poor. That’s why we must remember her. That woman gave up a luxury. She was used to that kind of

life, to those luxuries. As I see it, when she poured that very expensive perfume on Jesus she was giving up all her luxuries and squanderings and that's why Jesus defended her from the criticism. You ought to see how the bourgeois live and what they spend on perfumes and clothes and on the mansions they live in and on their automobiles. And her example and the lesson that Jesus is giving is that you have to give now to the poor."

"And people like us who don't have perfumes or luxurious things to give because we're poor?"

FELIPE: "We can give other valuable things that we have."

LAUREANO: "We can offer our lives as Jesus did. Then it'll be also for us, that perfume that the woman poured on Jesus."

12.

The Question about Resurrection

(Luke 20:27–40)

The Sadducees, who the Gospel says didn't believe in resurrection, presented Jesus with the problem of the woman who had seven legitimate husbands. Which of them will be her husband at the resurrection?

I said that the Sadducees were the priestly party of the aristocracy, even more conservative than the Pharisees, who were the priestly party of the middle class. It was through their conservatism that they didn't believe in resurrection, for they accepted only the first five Books of the Bible (the Pentateuch), and in them the concept of resurrection does not appear, for it is a late concept in the Bible. Politically they were allied to the Romans, and they were the most strongly opposed to any messianic movement of the people that would endanger their privileges. I said also that as Marcos Joya, Manuel's brother, had just died, today's passage was very opportune, dealing with the problem of resurrection.

Then Jesus answered them:

"In this world men and women marry.

*But those who deserve to reach that other world
and to be resurrected from among the dead,
will not marry there, for they can no longer die."*

OSCAR: "So you get married to die, right?"

ANDREA, his wife: "It seems to me that it's because here we have bodies, there we're going to have just spirits."

I: "For the Jews, and for Christ, there was no distinction between soul and body, as there was for the Greeks, who said that the soul came out from the 'prison' of the body. According to biblical thinking, resurrection, if it existed, had to be complete and material. We might say that they had a materialistic, 'Marxist,' concept of the resurrection. The reason why there won't be marriages, says Jesus, is because they can't die."

OSCAR: "I understand, Ernesto, why here, because of death, there's a wish to marry. It seems that there, since there'll be no more death, there'll be no wish to marry. There'll always be love, right? But no longer with any thought of sex."

I: "In fact, Christ doesn't say there will be no more love but that they won't marry because there will be no need to have children (because there will be no death)."

DON TOMAS PEÑA: "It seems there'll always be love. But having children, like here on earth, it seems to me that won't be seen, right?"

I: "As life dies, ever since life appeared on earth, reproduction had to be invented so we could maintain ourselves. But once there's no death, there's no need for reproduction. We can also say the opposite: there are births because there is death. If life didn't die we wouldn't have been born; and we must die so that

others can be born. Because there is death there has been the enormous evolution of life. Life has been able to evolve from the first cell to the human being through the infinite number of births that there have been. And we too must die so that there will be more evolution of life. But it seems to me that resurrection will be like the last stage of evolution (at some point there has to be a last stage) in which there will no longer be a need for more evolution, and there will be no need for more births. There nobody will be born any more, and therefore there is no more sex, and also because nobody dies any more."

TOMAS PEÑA: "And also because there'll be no evil gossip, it seems to me. Because that does us a lot of harm. Because people say: Look at that man and woman, there they are living together and with a bunch of kids and they don't get married. Isn't that so? And so, then, well, it's better to get married. You say: So people won't talk about me. But there, it seems to me it's different. To live in love, then, that's healthy there."

OLIVIA: "I believe it's because there'll be another marriage, not like the marriages of this world, of two individuals, but a marriage of all humanity with God (who is love)."

FELIPE, Tomás' son: "I want to ask one thing, Ernesto: what will happen to marriage in a totally perfect society?"

I: "If there is still death, there will be reproduction. But I believe it still won't be totally perfect if there is death. And what good would that society be to us if we won't see it because we'll be dead? But Jesus tells us that we'll be living. The reason why that society interests us is that we'll be part of it. For humanity to be all united is a necessary condition for us to be alive. In this translation Jesus speaks of two worlds: this one

and the other one. But in Greek he doesn't speak of two worlds, but of two 'aeons': aeons are epochs or eras of the world, and Jesus speaks of this aeon and of the new aeon."

ESPERANZA: "Why would he say, Ernesto, 'those who deserve to reach that other world'?"

I: "They are the ones who love. They will be alive in the love of the society of the future."

*For they are like angels,
and they are like children of God
through having been resurrected.*

OSCAR: "Does it mean that we who haven't suffered death aren't children of God?"

I: "In the Bible the angels are specially called children of God. I think what he is saying is that we shall be like the angels through having been resurrected, and we shall be more especially children of God then, like Christ himself."

LAUREANO: "He says that those who are resurrected, they're going to be the children of God, those who obeyed God's commandments, and the ones who aren't resurrected, those people died!"

TOMAS: "If you don't lead a crooked life but give your friendship to others, if you love everybody, you're already right now beginning to live the resurrection, then."

OSCAR: "Yes, I agree with that, too, because I'm beginning to think that to be able to rise again you ought to begin to rise now in this life, first. In order to be able to have the hope of resurrection, I say, of God. But if you die in selfishness, what hope do you have!"

ALEJANDRO: "But the death they're talking about

here isn't the death of sin or anything else; it's the death of the body."

I: "Yes, but we're seeing that resurrection is something you begin to have, right in this life, in embryo. Saint Paul says the transformation of our bodies will be like that of a seed into a plant. But Saint Paul also insults members of a group that said that the resurrection 'already happened' (that it was symbolic)."

ALEJANDRO: "And what it says here about that they're going to be like angels; what's 'angels'?"

LAUREANO (laughing): "Well, I've seen some painted ones with wings."

ALEJANDRO: "Oh, well, those aren't the ones being talked about here. Maybe he's talking about a change of matter. Of course, your body is transformed after you die; it's a natural process. Then, maybe something more perfect comes out, in another form."

I: "I don't know what they are, but I believe we can think of them as forces or powers of the cosmos."

OSCAR: "I think that business about angels that it says there is that maybe you're going to be without sin; you're going to be pure, pure love especially."

CARLOS: "The angels could be other beings who also had their trial on another planet now disappeared and who are now glorified. Because we can't be the only beings, there must be others in other places."

I: "We have no reason to think that a human being is the most perfect being in the universe. In our galaxy there are 250 million suns that can have planets like the earth, and there are billions of galaxies in the firmament. And there are stars that are much older than the sun, and they can have civilizations several million years more advanced than ours. One of the scientists who took part in the launching of Viking II to Mars

has said he believes it's possible that we're receiving messages from beings very superior to ourselves, and that we don't notice them. He even believes it's possible that there are intelligent beings who can live in the midst of interstellar space and even in the heart of the stars. If this were so, those beings would be 'spiritual' for us. In reality we know very little about matter. It's curious that in the Bible angels are called the 'army of heaven' and God is therefore the 'God of the armies.' In the Book of Job it says that when God created the earth all the children of God (the angels) sang with jubilation on the stars of the dawn. In the narrative that Mark writes of this Gospel passage, Jesus tells the Sadducees they have asked him that question about resurrection because 'they do not know the Scriptures or the power of God.' It seems to me he's telling them there that they don't know the possibilities there are in the cosmos. The fact is that, according to the Bible, there are beings superior to us, and Jesus says that resurrection will be to be like them. The Sadducees didn't believe in angels, either. Perhaps that's exactly why Jesus mentions them, to make them see that one thing has something to do with the other."

*Even Moses himself,
in the passage about the burning bush,
makes us see that the dead come to life.
There he says that the Lord is the God
of Abraham, of Isaac, and of Jacob.
But God is the God not of the dead but of the living;
since for him all are the living.*

DONALD: "Well, they had died but they went on living."

ELVIS: "It occurs to me that the ones that God says are the living are the ones who lived for the people, and they were living in the people. Like Camilo Torres or Che Guevara, who still live, they are a living strength in the people."

TOMAS: "Well, for God they are living. It seems to me that they're living, or rather that God keeps them alive, because of all they've done, all they've saved. And God sees them very clearly."

OSCAR: "It's great news that the dead are alive."

TOMAS: "They haven't ended, because since God loves them, and is remembering them, they're alive for God. As we were just saying (it's a comparison), I remember when William was here. I always remember him, and I say: he'll also be thinking of us off there."

I: "As Tomás says, we remember William and Tere-sita who are in Peru, and then they are present in us. Something similar happens with the resurrected, but it's not because people remember them but because they are living in God's thought: they are present in the consciousness of the universe."

CARLOS: "Abraham, Isaac, and Jacob had been given a promise. And if they were dead, how could their promise be fulfilled?"

I: "And those names represent all of humanity that has died waiting for the promise of total revolution. Now Jesus is quoting from a book in which the Sadducees did indeed believe. At first sight, Jesus' reasoning seems illogical; it seems that Jesus is only clutching one little word: that God didn't say 'I was' but 'I am the God of Abraham.' He might have found more serious arguments; maybe he's kidding them a little. But it also seems to me that Jesus' reasoning is more profound: that since the Patriarchs were friends of God,

they go on being God's friends, and then they're alive. Also, Yahweh told Moses (when Yahweh appeared for the first time in history) to tell the people that Yahweh was the God of their forebears, of their past, of their history; Jesus is now saying that the people of the past continue to live, because the God of history is also the God of the future. To be alive for God is to be alive for the future."

OSCAR: "We mustn't be afraid of death, then, because death is nothing."

DONTOMAS: "It seems to me that I'm afraid of sickness. Even though I'm not sick, but a comrade is, and he is seriously ill, and I'm thinking about him: Poor So-and-So, I say."

FELIPE: "What's important is for us to love in this life so that we can live in that love which is the life of God."

OSCAR: "Of course we mustn't fear death. But we must love. Because if I'm going to die without love, if I'm isolated from everybody, from the people, of course I have to fear death. But if I'm here and we're trying to find out how to join together in love, why should I be afraid of death?"

I: "We save ourselves like that, together, united, in a unity that's the betrothal of humanity with God, as Olivia has said. And we'll be a single organism in which there will no longer be a woman who has lost seven husbands, or husbands who have lost their wives, or single men or single women. We shall be a single body that gets betrothed."

Then some teachers of the law said to him:

"Well said, Master."

And they did not dare to ask him any other questions.

All were silent. Then TOMAS said: "Anybody got anything else to say?"

Nobody else had a comment. I concluded by saying: "It's clear that even the teachers of the law were happy at the answer that Jesus gave to the Sadducees. They were very unpopular. They were the priestly nobility, the rich families. In the first books of the Bible, which were for them the only ones, it was thought that the dead existed like shadows in Sheol, but they weren't living. Since to the Jews a person was not composed of body and soul but of body and life infused by God, the dead were separated from Yahweh, and Yahweh wasn't concerned with the dead. Therefore the blessings of God consisted of a long life heaped with riches. But later, the people oppressed by the rich, or in exile, began to think differently. It was especially during the guerrilla fighting of the Maccabees that faith in resurrection appears clearly. The guerrilla fighters are sure that those who die for freedom will go on living. The Sadducees, then, because they were rich and reactionary, did not believe in resurrection, only in the enjoyment of their riches. I recently read an interview with a Marxist atheist in which he said that the belief in the resurrection of the dead is very revolutionary and anyone who believes in anything as daring as that has no reason to doubt any other transformation that humanity can have."

13.

The Most Important Commandment

(Mark 12:28-34)

*Then came also one of the teachers of the law,
who had heard them discussing,
and as he knew that Jesus had answered them well,
he asked him: "Which is the first of all the com-
mandments?"*

1: "The teachers of the law, also called doctors of the law, or scribes, almost always appear in the Gospels as evil people. They are frequently compared with the Pharisees. They were like the theologians or the moralists; and with the priests they were the religious leaders. (In the Gospels there is mention of a scribe who wanted to follow Jesus, but that isn't said of any priest.) This teacher, it seems that he approached with good intentions because he saw that Jesus, in the discussion on the resurrection that he had with the Sadducees, a very conservative, aristocratic, and priestly group, had 'answered them well.' This scribe's question, about which commandment is most important,

was of great interest, for the Jews had more than six hundred religious commandments.”

Jesus answered:

“The first commandment of all is:

‘Listen, Israel,

the Lord our God is the only Lord.

So love the Lord your God with all your heart,

with all your soul, with all your mind,

and with all your strength.’

This is the first commandment.

And the second is like it, and it is:

‘Love your neighbor as yourself.’

There is no other commandment

more important than these.”

ELVIS: “To love the poor, the oppressed, is to be loving God. And that is the commandment we must obey.”

I: “But why does he talk, then, about loving God? He could just have said love your neighbor.”

ELVIS: “Well, God is your neighbor; God’s the people.”

FELIPE: “I think he’s saying that you have to love your neighbor like you love God.”

I: “Yes, but in any case he talks about loving God. And he considers it so important that he puts it together with love of neighbor, and even ahead of it.”

We thought awhile. Then I said: “God appears before the people of Israel freeing them from the slavery of Egypt. And he gives them some laws so that they would be a just society and so that they wouldn’t oppress one another as they were formerly oppressed by the Egyptians. And he wants the people to be faithful

to him and not to recognize other gods of other societies, which do not represent any liberation. So to love him is to love liberation and justice and that's the same thing as to love your neighbor. To love God, then, is to love love. And therefore it's logical that the second commandment should be very similar to the first one. I also note that phrase that God is 'the only Lord': I see that that commandment is not to have other gods, not to have idols. The commandment is that there is no other God than love. And that is why we must love God with all our hearts, with all our souls, with all our minds, with all our strength. And the second commandment is the same, because if it weren't the same, with what love are you going to love your neighbor if you're loving God with all the love you have?"

FELIPE: "To love your neighbor then is to love God. You can't love God without practicing justice. And you can't love your neighbor without practicing that justice that God commands."

GLORIA: "I think Jesus made him see that if we love God and don't love our neighbor, we're really not loving God."

I: "The two commandments were in the Bible; in the Bible it also said you have to love your neighbor like yourself, including foreigners among your neighbors. What was original in Jesus, and what was very revolutionary and what must have scandalized a lot of people, was joining the two things and saying that one was similar to the other."

ELVIS: "We agree, then, that loving your neighbor is already loving God, right?"

LAUREANO: "Because God is humanity. They are equal. (Some of us believe, then, that they are the

same thing. Or that it's God, that humanity is God.)"

I: "No, I believe that what we should say is that God is love among people. That God does exist, but that God doesn't exist in another way, separated from love among people, as God is usually imagined. God exists, but God exists among us only in that form: as mutual love."

FELIPE: "I think that's why Christ says that to that teacher of the law, because they used to be confused and thought that God was a God separated from the people. That you could commit injustices and then light a bunch of candles to God. At that time they thought God was a personage separated from people."

I went on: "I believe we cannot say that God is people. That would mean that Hitler or Pinochet are God because they are people."

LAUREANO: "Humanity loving each other and united, that's what God is. Just societies are the ones that can see God. Not those sons of bitches. Those bastards are outside of God."

ELVIS: "Where there's a community and everybody's united and lives in community, that's the real God, right?"

I: "That's why I said that God is the love that unites people."

ELVIS: "If that's clear, everything's clear."

DOÑA NATALIA, Elvis's mother: "I don't know, but it seems to me that, as I'm a bit ill I can say something crazy. I believe that love between husband and wife is love of God."

I: "Jesus says the second is very much like the first. You can say, then, that those that obey the second, it's as if they're obeying the first. Those who don't love God, for example, because they don't believe in God,

but love their neighbor, according to Christ it's as if they're obeying the first commandment. Since one is similar to the other, it's like saying that it's equal. And he stresses this equality when he says, putting them on the same plane, that 'there is no other commandment more important than these.' I also think that to love God above all things is not to make any thing into God, or not to make a thing of God, and from that comes the ban on making images of God. The only image of God is a human being, according to the Bible. And as God is love, to love God 'above all things' is like loving humans, and therefore the first commandment is like the second."

Then the teacher of the law said:

"Well said, Master.

*It is true what you say that there is only one God,
and that there is no other except God.*

*And that to love God with all one's heart,
with all one's understanding,
with all one's soul and with all one's strength,
and to love one's neighbor as oneself
is worth more than all the sacrifices
and all the offerings that are burned on the altar."*

1: "The teacher of the law repeats what Christ said, with the addition that there is only one God and there is no *other*. Maybe this is a little like what Laureano was saying, that we can't imagine a false God, a God that is not love. God *is* love, justice, and there is no other. And this man adds also something more radical, which Jesus hadn't said: that this love is worth more than religion. That's what he means by the things that he mentions: 'all the sacrifices and all the of-

ferings that are burned on the altar.' He got the idea. And Jesus agrees with him. And another interesting thing: he has understood that love of God and of others is a single thing, when he joins them in a single phrase and says that that is superior to religion."

IVAN: "He's saying that it's better to give your life for the people than to give money to build a temple."

MANUEL: "That's very good. Because what the rich do is give some money to the bishop to build a baptismal font and the people are starving to death."

FELIPE: "That teacher was seeing that those sacrifices and those offerings were false rites, because they were a bunch of exploiters, hypocrites."

I: "But here he's not talking only about false rites but true rites. He says that love is worth more than all religious rites."

MANUEL: "This doesn't mean we should abandon all the rest."

I: "What rest?"

MANUEL: "Well, church and all that."

I: "But isn't that what you were saying?"

MANUEL: "Not about myself, but about others who burn candles."

I: "And is there any value in that?"

MANUEL (laughing): "Maybe God likes smoke."

I: "And this Gospel, what does it say?"

MANUEL: "Well, yes, here it says the opposite. But if I'm really loving my neighbor, I can be doing those things even if they're secondary."

I: "Here it doesn't say you mustn't do them. It says the other is more important."

MANUEL: "Yes, I agree."

FELIPE: "And it's not a sin to fail to do them."

I: "And that you can also have no religion, right? Even when it talks here about 'all the sacrifices and all the offerings that are burned on the altar,' it seems to me that the tone is a little contemptuous."

MARIITA: "Yes, of course, religion must serve for love of our neighbor. That's worth more than anything."

LAUREANO: "Religion is the opium of the people."

Then, when Jesus saw that he had answered wisely, he said to him: "You are not far from the kingdom of God."

MANUEL: "Well, he wasn't far from love; he was getting to love. Maybe he wasn't loving yet, but he was getting there."

OLIVIA: "At other times we've seen that people are saved by people. Whether people are saved depends on their relationships with people. We see it in that business about the Last Judgment: 'For I was hungry and they fed me.' It means then that everything is related to people. Forgetting that is what has harmed us, and that's why there's so much injustice, so much hunger. We've lived through a traditional religion of baptismal fonts, as Manuel says, of candles, and we forget love, which is what can save us. Love of our neighbor is what saves us. And meanwhile there have been people who don't even mention God and they've sacrificed themselves and died for the love of neighbors. It means that that is fundamental and that it's been useless, that religion full of lies that we've had and that they have in many countries."

I: "So Christ shows us here, then, what the kingdom

of heaven is: love among neighbors. And he tells that teacher of the law that he is not far from it, with what he has said."

And no one dared ask him more questions.

OLIVIA: "Maybe because they had understood everything, and they saw that that was an awkward situation for them, and if Jesus went on talking to them the situation would get worse. They didn't want to go on hearing that kind of thing."

I: "They probably didn't like what was being said about sacrifices, offerings, something like what Laureano has said—right?—about religion being the opium of the people, and they didn't want to question him any more."

GUSTAVO, the Colombian: "Yes, I agree with what Laureano says, and they must have been startled at those new ideas, right? That all their rites, the animals they sacrificed, the incense they burned, and all that was valueless. Then they didn't want to ask him any more questions because they were afraid; what Christ was saying was too revolutionary."

I: "And possibly because they didn't know what to answer. He was talking here about the Bible; this was the thought of the Bible, the teacher of the law understood it very well, and the others must have understood. Many Christians also understand this, and they don't like to hear it."

"But we mustn't blame people that live in this traditional religion because this is what they've been taught. I'm thinking of my parents, who are very good people, but they've been taught this and they've known nothing else."

ALEJANDRO: "Many Jews used to go to make their sacrifices to the temple in good faith. Mary and Joseph also took Jesus to the temple, to make those sacrifices, when he got lost on them."

LAUREANO: "Don Tomás hasn't said anything."

Old DON TOMAS: "I was paying attention to what was being said. What you've been saying is very good, and I didn't have anything to say, so I'd better be quiet. (after a pause) As for that business about the offerings: I don't think they had the offerings in those times that we have now. We used to do what we were told; we'd come with candles and this or that and we didn't understand, right? And as our parents taught us that, we had to do what they did. Now we've discovered a new law. I understand all that. I see that the old law that our parents had, we had to follow, because it was the one our parents taught. But now a law has come that is quite different, so now we have to obey another law. Not keep the same one, because that's wrong. That's why we come to church, to Mass. Instead of staying in the hammock listening to the radio. Because we have to listen and seek and see what the new one is like."

I: "In the Bible the opponent of God isn't atheism; it's the idols. The fact that 'there is only one God,' which we've seen here, means that we must not adore idols. And that was because all pagan religions were alienating. Only Yahweh liberates. In Psalm 82 God appears rebuking the gods because they are on the side of the oppressors, because they have not been just to the weak and orphaned, because they do not liberate the poor and the needy. The first commandment, says Christ, is like the second; it really *is* the second. Not to serve other gods means to love your neighbor, because

it means to love only God, and love of God is achieved only through love of your neighbor. And it's a betrayal of the thought of Jesus to try to make two commandments and not one. It's not a question of loving God and loving your neighbor, but rather of loving God-neighbor as a single thing, because God can be loved only in your neighbor. What is said here is that love of God-in-neighbor is worth more than any worship of God."

14.

The Eucharist

(Mark 14:12-25)

We commented on this Gospel at Holy Thursday Mass at about five in the afternoon. With us was a great Nicaraguan composer of popular songs and protest songs, Carlos Mejía Godoy, who was going to perform for the first time his "Peasant Mass," which he had composed here in Solentiname. His presence had brought many people from San Carlos, especially young people. And we knew that some spies had also come.

The disciples asked Jesus where they were going to celebrate the Passover, and he told them:

Go to the city, and there you will find a man who is carrying a jug of water.

Follow him, and wherever he enters, say to the owner of the house:

"The Master says: where is the room in which I am going to have Passover supper with my disciples?"

Then he will show you a great room on the top floor, all ready; prepare for us there.

CARLOS MEJIA GODOY: "Very mysterious. It seems to have been a clandestine supper."

OLIVIA: "It seems he was trying to see that nobody knew where it was going to be, that even the disciples didn't know, above all because he no longer trusted Judas."

I: "Yes. It's clear that he had made an arrangement with a certain person in Jerusalem, who had to be with a jug in a certain place. That was the signal. I suppose that a man with a jug of water would be something unusual, because it was the women who hauled water. The man was to go into a house, and they were to follow him. And the Gospel says that Jesus and his disciples didn't arrive until it was already night. In those days he was already staying in hiding. He attacked the temple and went into hiding again. His hiding place was in the Gethsemane grove. After the supper, at midnight, he returned there. And the treachery of Judas was that he revealed the hiding place."

WILLIAM: "That Eucharist was a clandestine supper, and besides, some of them were armed, as the Gospel says also in another passage. The Passover supper was a commemoration of the Exodus, the liberation of the people, and here Jesus is beginning another Exodus, another liberation. And an authentic Eucharist, as long as there's injustice, has to be more or less underground. Like this one that we're celebrating today."

I explained that Passover was a very ancient feast of *campesinos* and shepherds who were celebrating the renewal of life in the spring. It was something like our Holy Week. The Israelites celebrated it each year in Egypt, where they were slaves. And once a leader, Moses, received from Yahweh the inspiration that they should go to the desert to celebrate Passover. And

they went and did not return. If they had celebrated their Passover, their Holy Week, traditionally, like every year, they would have remained in slavery. History would not have changed and all the peoples on earth would still be enslaved, because the subjective conditions for a revolution would never have occurred. They freed themselves and from that came the freedom that all the peoples of earth enjoy. Everything started from the fact that the people did not return. A historic event took place that broke the mythical cycle that was repeated every year. 'Passover' is a Hebrew word that means 'passage,' 'jump,' 'flight,' that is: liberation. It was the passage to a new land of liberty. And Yahweh made a pact with the people in which the people promised to keep their faith in him, their freedom, to keep themselves free. And Yahweh ordered them to celebrate that feast every year, but in a different way: as the feast of their freedom ("that day will be for you a remembrance"). Each Israelite was expected to feel as though he or she personally came out of Egypt. But this feast was not to be a mere remembrance of the past. It was rather so that they would keep in mind that the same strength that freed them in the past would go on freeing them in the future from other imperialisms and also from internal oppressions, class struggles. Above all at that Passover they announced the coming of a Messiah, the new Moses who would definitively free the people from all oppression. This supper was to sustain the people with its living consciousness of its devotion to freedom. And this is the supper that Jesus is going to have tonight with his disciples. The Passover supper also had a political character. The Jewish authorities were worried when Jesus went up to Jerusalem to celebrate Passover. Pilate lived in Caesarea, but each year he

went up to Jerusalem for Passover, because there might be disturbances. At the Passover supper, when they celebrated the past liberation, naturally they had to talk about politics. At the time of Christ they had to talk about the Roman Empire, about Herod. Just as during Holy Week, which is the continuation of that Passover, we talk of imperialism, of Somoza. The supper, for true Israelites, had a subversive character. But for others the Passover was already nothing but a ritual, a symbolic action, like the first feast of the renewal of nature that was repeated every year without changing history. At this feast Christ did something different, like Moses. He began a new Exodus, and he established a new alliance of the people with the force that freed it from Egypt, for a new liberation.

*While they were eating, he took the bread,
pronounced the thanksgiving and,
after dividing it, gave it to them, saying:*

"Take; this is my body."

*Then he took a goblet and,
after the thanksgiving, gave it to them,
and all drank from it.*

And he said to them:

*"This is my blood which confirms the new pact,
and which is shed for the good of everyone."*

WILLIAM: "It seems to me that when he gave them that communion of bread and wine, the bread that is food and the wine that is joy, telling them it was his body and it was his blood, and 'go on doing this,' it was so that we would repeat also his sacrifice for the cause of the poor. That is, giving his life. This is my body was equivalent to saying this is my life, and the

same with blood. And he adds: 'my blood shed.' That's what he wanted us to repeat, not to repeat a ritual. And they had made a ritual out of the Eucharist."

I: "Right there Jesus wants to put an end to the ritual. Just as the other Passover had also been the abandonment of a ritual, converting a religious celebration into a political act. Passover, which had again become a ritual, is used by Christ for a political, economic, and social liberation of humanity. His intention was not that we should celebrate a Holy Week ritual every year, as we do in Nicaragua, while the people are still not free."

"Man, it seems to me we should put Holy Week to better use. Doing something for the people. So that after Holy Week is over we won't go back to our usual slavery."

I: "The first pact didn't last. The people chosen for liberty became a people of rich and poor. The prophets had announced that a new pact would be established between God and God's people. Pacts in ancient times were sealed with blood. The first pact was sealed with the blood of the paschal lamb. Christ at the supper says that his blood that he is going to shed is the blood of a new pact."

"That pact of God with people is also a pact of people among themselves, because we are left obliged to one another; it's a pact of love among people."

"We're far, far away from that pact in Nicaragua. Just look at the difference between rich and poor."

"What we've got is a contract for the exploitation of people by people."

"He gives us that bread that is his body delivered up by the people and that wine that is his blood shed by

the people, so that we may all be a single body and a single blood, all be a single equality. Some shouldn't be more than others. Because his blood, he shed it for everybody; it's a blood that unites us all, I believe."

"With that bread and that wine he wants to tell us that wherever it is shared he is present."

CARLOS MEJIA GODOY: "When William spoke and mentioned the word 'communion' something occurred to me that I'd never thought of before: that communion isn't only a sacrament. It's also like when we say 'I'm in complete communion with so-and-so's ideas' (an ideological communion). And Christ wanted us really to commune with one another this way; and this communion, this union, will make us afterwards have everything in common."

ALEJANDRO: "But those who are preventing the union of people, the exploiters, can't participate in this Eucharist."

DONALD: "The supporters of this system have kept the old rituals, with the Holy Weeks. You've got to fast. You can't eat meat from a hairy animal. In many places, not only in Nicaragua, throughout Latin America, they've kept these rituals, and they don't break out of the system, the system is always eating into us."

I: "The feast is celebrated on the same date in the lunar month on which the Israelites celebrated it before leaving Egypt, according to a very ancient tradition, but the bad part is that it's still celebrated with the same spirit: it's an annual symbolic resurrection while the people continue in slavery. In Cuba the celebration of the victory of Playa Girón, April 19, coincides roughly with Holy Week, which is the full moon of the spring equinox. This annoys many Catholics

because they think the revolution is trying to replace one celebration by another. The first time I went to Cuba it coincided exactly with Good Friday, which had annoyed them even more, because all the school-children were celebrating Girón and not Good Friday. But I thought there was no cause for annoyance in that; they too were celebrating a passage, a passover: the exodus from capitalism. But they were celebrating a real liberation, while the reactionary Catholics who lost nothing at Playa Girón were celebrating a ritual liberation.”

“Celebrating Easter with the old ritualism is like saying that we’ve returned to Egypt again.”

OLIVIA: “At this supper Jesus had washed the feet of the disciples to show that there shouldn’t be classes, but this has become nothing more than a ceremony of Holy Week, when in the cathedrals the bishops wash the feet of twelve ‘apostles.’ People don’t understand that Jesus didn’t want to teach us a ceremony. While some people have huge feasts and waste food, others go to bed maybe half starved. There are so many, many people in the country who go to bed with no supper or little supper, and maybe little lunch as well. And in society there are some who are lords and others who are servants who wait on them.”

TOMAS PEÑA: “It’s not that everybody’s going to become a lord but that we all must serve each other, be servants of each other. Because the disciple can’t be greater than the Master and the Master became a servant.”

FELIPE: “Until everybody in the country is the same.”

ESPERANZA: “The bishops wash feet, and the priests, too, and they let big things happen, big injus-

tices, big exploitations, and they're always washing feet. Well, at least here we're changing all that, at least we're looking for something else. At least now they say to you: 'Hey! Where you going, daddy? You going to Solentiname? What you going to do there?' At least here it's something else."

I: "As we were saying before, the oppressors can't take part in this communion, those who have grabbed the goods that belong to everyone. Saint Paul reproached the Corinthians that in their banquets some ate a great deal and others went hungry. What the Church did was to suppress the banquets because it couldn't suppress the class divisions. That's why Father Camilo Torres was so right when he said that only with the revolution could we have a valid Eucharist. The first Christians called the Eucharist by the Greek word *Koinonia*, which is the same word with which they named the community of goods that they had. And it's because communion and Communism are the same thing. From the most ancient times the Greeks had talked of Communism and they gave it the name that the Christians used afterwards to say 'communion': *Koinonia*."

WILLIAM: "Which sounds like 'company.' But now the word 'company' (and we already have one here in Solentiname) means just the opposite."

GIANANTONIO (a young Italian who is spending awhile with us): "I believe the logical consequence of the Eucharist is that people have everything in common. Until they live in communion they can't celebrate the true Eucharist that Christ began."

I: "Camilo Torres said that was why he stopped saying Mass."

FATHER JAIME (a Salesian priest, a visitor from Col-

ombia): "Continuing what William was saying, which interests me very much because I hadn't heard it before, that Christ's intention was not that we should repeat a ritual: I see the Eucharist as a new kind of society. It seems to me that what has happened to the history of Christianity is the same as what happened to the history of humanity, according to Marx. That humanity at the beginning was communal, people helped one another, they held everything in common. The same with the first Christians. But Christianity later had to pass through the same stages as the rest of humanity: slavery, feudalism, capitalism. In some parts of America we haven't got beyond feudal society. In my country, for example, we find some priests who live like feudal lords, others like despots. But now there are many of us who understand that we must rebel against these oppressions of the Church, and we are trying to make the Church, with the rest of society, pass on to a new stage, socialism. But it has to be done clandestinely. What you are doing here can't be done in Managua's cathedral. In a simple, poor, peasants' chapel, where the people feel the injustice that has been committed against them by making use of religion, people can understand the true sense of the Eucharist: that it is mutual aid, it is solidarity, it is liberation. I was very impressed by what William had said, which I had really never heard in that way."

FELIPE: "The Church is very rich, as Comrade Jaime says, but the members of the Church, we get poorer and poorer; the old people are even beggars."

OLD TOMAS: "They're taking everything away from the people, even the land. There's very little land left for us."

"The land now belongs to the feudal lords."

YOUNG MYRIAM: "Just the opposite of communion."

DON JULIO: "Right here they're buying the land and people are leaving Solentiname."

ALEXANDER: "Yes, it's good to expose all that taking away of land. You can take away land without buying it. And another way is by buying it. Because this system pressures people to sell, at prices that the *campesinos* think are good but the buyers know are low. And that's a kind of taking away from you. They can buy it for a hundred or a hundred and fifty pesos an acre; but that's practically stealing it. The bank pressures the *campesinos* who are in debt to sell, and the same bank makes loans to the rich so they can buy."

BOSCO: "It's a well-planned robbery."

OLIVIA: "And what I see is that that institution of the Eucharist compromises everybody that takes communion. Although many believe that just by eating the host they're saving their souls, what's important is to realize the injustice that exists, and the exploitation. And that's why I've said it would be better to close the city churches, because they're no good, those big Masses, and those big communions: they make the people blinder, more asleep. Religion puts people to sleep. You go up to take communion and to take a candle and you feel tranquil, and injustice doesn't matter, you don't see it; all you saw was that you did your duty by praying, with your eyes closed, with all that seriousness. And the injustices, we don't see them; we don't see the deaths, the infant mortality, the lack of medicines, malnutrition, and all that. And that communion, that taking of wine and bread is to make

people even blinder, the poor as well as the rich. Because even the poor say that it's 'God's will.' "

I: "There can be no communion as long as there are social classes, because you can't unite social classes, exploiters and exploited."

The manager of the National Bank of San Carlos: "I don't know, Father, to what extent it is true what they say that religion is the opium of the people. But the truth is that the priests have gradually instilled into the people that they must be patient because afterwards they're going to enjoy the kingdom of heaven up there. Why don't we make the kingdom happen right here? Instead of waiting for something that maybe doesn't exist. That's why young people have drawn away a little from religion. Nowadays there are priests like you who have more advanced ideas and who are orienting the people toward liberation; that's different, that's something new. But it used to be that the priests were always on the side of those who had the power."

OLIVIA: "It's just like what the gentleman, the comrade, says, that it's been the leaders of the Church who are responsible for this conformity in the people. They've done this to get on the good side of the powerful, as he says, so they can get gifts, so they can receive good things. And besides they put fear into us. I remember when the priests used to come here: they were hard on people that didn't have anything; they'd come and scold them hard. Then everybody was filled with fear, taking communion to get saved, to be able to get to heaven. But in the Gospel it's clearly shown that the kingdom of God we're going to form is right here on earth; so we're seeing that this is different from the big

lies they were making us believe: shut your mouth, you've got to be patient for heaven, wait till heaven. The kingdom is going to be made by us alone, and if we don't free ourselves we're not going to that heaven even if we're poor."

I: "In the following verse there's mention of the kingdom of heaven. Those in Solentiname who have time to be studying the Gospel are very sure that the kingdom of heaven is the kingdom of God established on earth. It's a kingdom in the future, but it's not a kingdom way off yonder. After he gave them the wine to drink, Jesus mentioned that kingdom."

*I tell you truly, you will not drink the product of the
grape again
until you drink the new wine in the kingdom of
God.*

OLIVIA: "The kingdom of love, which is in this life."

I: "I wonder what it means that he isn't going to drink wine until then."

MARIITA: "It's like if we said we wouldn't take a drink until liberation comes. Only until the revolution triumphs, only until everything has changed, will he have celebrations again."

GIANANTONIO: "And that day he *will* celebrate with us."

I: "It seems that he's saying that only then will the true feast come. And why does he speak of *new* wine?"

WILLIAM: "Very odd. Because, without knowing much about wine, I know that old wine is tastier."

CARLOS MEJIA GODOY: "Or can it be the wine from a new harvest, from a new grape, can that be the new

wine? A different wine; the new wine of a new person."

I: "The Bible always insists on the *new*, because the Bible is revolutionary: we hear of a new person, new skies and a new earth, a new Jerusalem, a new canticle, a God that will make everything new, a new alliance, a new wine. All this means change, revolution, or, as we also say now, a new order."

The bank manager: "This new society will take about a thousand years to arrive. Because if the change is very peaceful, I don't think anyone will want to give up interests that have cost so much. That's the way the world is. No matter how much religion there may be, you leave the church and you forget everything."

IVAN: "I think the Eucharist is to hasten that change."

FELIPE: "And the hastening depends on the people, the people do it."

WILLIAM: "Besides, the so-called interests are more costly to those who produce them than to the ones who call themselves owners."

CARLOS MEJIA GODOY: "With regard to what he was saying, that people forget, or that we forget: we're talking about a permanent communion and not about a church ritual. It's the continuous, daily communion everywhere, in the factory, in the office, wherever one may be earning a living. That's the true communion that's going to produce the change."

I: "All the products of the earth and of human work have to come from everybody for us to have a new society and for us to drink that new wine."

OLIVIA: "Referring to what he was saying about the ones who don't want to give up what has cost them

so much: in fact, what they have hasn't cost them, it has cost the poor; and the ones it has cost are the ones it should be divided among. Because if I'm rich, all I do is give orders, exploit!"

The bank manager: "Well, I wasn't referring to what is dishonestly acquired but to what is honestly acquired."

OLIVIA: "But almost nobody has anything honestly acquired."

The manager: "People often take advantage of power to get enormous lands. They cost them almost nothing."

OLIVIA: "Notice that the ones that work hardest are the laborers and the farm hands, the peasants, because they're the working class and we're the ones that don't have a place to sleep. The peasants go to work for the rich from sunrise to sunset and they don't even have a change of clothes, and the ones that are sitting at home are wearing good clothes, eating good food, with good cars and good homes. So it's us oppressed who've got to worry about that kingdom, so the sharing will come now. And those who are sitting down think they're working but they're only giving orders, exploiting those out in the field under the sun broiling, broiling; or in the factory. So it's us poor people who've got to worry about getting free all together."

Alejandro's friend ALICIA, who works in a Managua office: "I think we ourselves have to start, we who are oppressed, because it's no use if four of us start to struggle and all the rest are asleep; if we're going to do anything, let's all get together, because we're talking about communion. It's a unity of everybody, and this new alliance has to be mainly laborers and farm-hands."

"What Jesus says there about wine is like the announcement of a final feast where we'll enjoy happiness, love, everything."

I: "Christ won't drink the new wine with us until there is communion among everybody, until there is perfect communism, *Koinonia*."

OSCAR: "Man, that calls for a lot of faith."

I: "Why?"

OSCAR: "Why, if you say, all right, eat me here, this is my body, how am I going to eat you if you're alive! If you offer me a hunk of bread there, I need a lot of faith. Really, because I believe in you. If I take it, it's because I believe in you. There you have to prove if you have faith. It's fine to say: Eat of this. This is my body. So it was a loaf of bread. And afterwards he offers them wine: This is my blood."

OLIVIA: "The fact is that the disciples had faith in him, right? And I believe every Christian has to have that same faith, and see that all nature is a communion with God because all things are made by God. If we're going to eat a banana, there is the love of God represented in that banana. And with much more reason if he gives it to us with his own hands."

OSCAR: "Man, I think all of us here ought to say what we feel. I felt at that moment when I heard the words of Christ: Take, for this is my body. 'Crap, how am I going to eat him in that hunk of bread?' I don't think he got mad at me. He must have noticed that I understood him, that I'm no fool. If I have faith in him, I have to fill myself with him like that, to gradually get myself equal to him and to gradually have a tremendous love for humanity."

MARIITA: "He also said we'd see him in our neighbor, especially in the poor, in the people. He said 'The poor are me.' And for that too you need a

great faith. There are people that say God is like this or like that. But they can't see him in their neighbor. Those are the people that some of you were talking about who believe that Christ is in the host that they eat and they don't believe in the Christ that's us."

15.

Supper Talk I

(John 13:31–35)

This time the composer Carlos Mejía Godoy was with us. And a large group came again to the Mass from San Carlos when they heard that he was here.

After Judas left, Jesus said:

*“Now is revealed the glory of the Son of Man,
and the glory of God is revealed in him.”*

I: “Judas had just stood up, and the Passion is going to begin. Jesus is on the eve of his death, and he knows it.”

ALEJANDRO: “But where did Judas go to? This Judas is the one that went out to do the betraying?”

I said he was. ALEJANDRO went on: “It seems to me that when there’s betrayal and persecution of a group it’s because it’s doing something, right? When people begin to attack an action, and to betray it, it’s because it’s producing results, it’s beginning to show its value, this work, beginning to be glorious. But I don’t think my commentary is good enough.”

CHEPE: "I think he's telling them they can be frank now because the Judas, the spy, is gone."

I: "But it's curious that he says that now his glory begins to be revealed, and the glory will be his death."

CARLOS MEJIA GODOY: "As I see it, the ones who were persecuting him, and had forced Judas to betray him, thought that when they killed him it would be all over. And he was conscious that it would not be all over. And that was the glory that they were going to see: that he went on living. Because he is living in the people is why the people are gathered here."

DONALD: "Now his glory is revealed, he says, at the hour when his death is approaching, and in fact those were going to be the most important moments of his life, because they were going to be his delivering himself up to the world. With this he was going to show his love."

ELVIS: "That's the glory of all those who deliver themselves up to others and die for their people. It's also the glory of the guerrilla fighter."

*And if the Son of Man reveals the glory of God,
then God will reveal his glory,
and he will do it soon.*

MANUEL: "Gosh! The glory of God is love, and Christ is showing his love for the world by dying on the Cross. It's the triumph of love, also."

I, adding to Manuel: "God is love, and Christ will show that love with his death, and that love raises him up."

DONALD: "As I see it, when a people, for example, Nicaragua or any other oppressed people, emerges

from oppression and frees itself, then the glory of God will be revealed. And it's something that will be revealed more and more each day in Latin America, the glory of God, the freedom of people, when there is no more oppression, no class distinctions."

FERNANDO, my Jesuit brother: "We know that God is love and social justice, and the glory of God, as you say, is when love and justice triumph on earth. And Christ, on going to his death, is conscious that he is going to his glory, because with it begins the freedom of people."

*My children, I shall not be with you for long.
You are going to look for me,
but just as I told the Jews
so I tell you now:
You will not be able to go where I am going.*

OSCAR: "He knew that humanity still wasn't going to be united, there was still going to be a lot of exploitation. And as long as there's injustices, inequalities, Jesus isn't with his disciples because they're divided. He surely knew that some day there'd be a society without exploitation or injustice, and that then he was going to be with us again."

MARIA: "They didn't have his love, and therefore they couldn't follow him. The enemies couldn't follow him there any more to kill him, and the disciples couldn't follow him either to his glory. Afterwards they would be able to follow him, but for the moment he goes by himself."

ALEJANDRO: "That's a bit contradictory, isn't it, that he was dead and they were looking for him?"

Would they be looking for his ideas? No, because they knew the ideas very well. What sense was there in looking for somebody who was already dead? I think he says they're going to be divided, without his presence, which is union."

"He's going to God and we can't follow him there. Could he also be saying there's no heaven, that we have to seek salvation just here on earth?"

I: "I don't think so, because a little later he says that in the same place where he is his disciples are also going to be. There's plenty of room there for all of us, and if this weren't true he would have told us. We know that the kingdom of heaven isn't in the sky, but Jesus also tells us that he has come to free us from death, and that's why he speaks of glory when he speaks of his death, of the revelation of the glory of God in his death. In the Old Testament the 'glory of God' is the same as the 'liberating victory of God,' and so when Jesus here speaks of his death, he's talking about a liberation of God."

ELVIS: "It seems to me that he's telling them that personally they're not going to find him, but that the earth will be liberated from all its injustices, and that we will bring about that liberation, and love will be established, and then indeed we shall have him again."

I: "That's very good, and let's see the words that Jesus says to his disciples just after he has told them that they couldn't follow him."

*I give you this new commandment:
that you shall love one another.*

DONALD: "Well, he means that we'll find him there."

My brother FERNANDO: "We can't go where he goes, but we can find him that way, by loving one another; in this way he will indeed be present. He is saying goodbye to them, and on giving them that new commandment he is telling them, telling us, that we must look for him not where he is going but in communal love. 'Look for me where you are going to find me: love one another.' Because there's a danger in wanting to look for him in the sky, and he's saying to them: 'You are going to look for me, and I give you this new commandment.' "

ELVIS: "As long as we have a divided society, as long as there are class distinctions, he's not there. And they're going to be looking for him without finding him. But if we obey the new commandment, then we've got him with us."

I asked why he calls it a new commandment.

"Because it didn't exist before."

I said that it certainly existed in the Bible: "Love your neighbor as you love yourself." And that commandment summed up all the Law, according to Christ.

LAUREANO: "I think it was just in theory and wasn't practiced. Now it's a new commandment because it's supposed to be practiced and to change society. It's a commandment that will bring a revolution, and that's the newness."

I: "It's true, with that precept society hadn't been transformed, slavery hadn't been abolished, injustices and cruelties had continued. This will be something different, not just a religious precept as the Jews saw it but a new social reality. On calling it 'a new commandment,' Jesus is saying that his commandment is a new command to love."

FELIPE: "Ernesto, it seems to me that he's telling us to forget all the old things of the ancient religion and all the commandments that were in the Bible. That there ought to be only one religion, the religion of love."

OLIVIA: "I think that when Jesus gave that new message of love there was a lack of love just as there's a lack now at present. In the Scriptures God appeared as love, and those Scriptures have existed all our lives; everybody reads them and nobody has followed them. It seems to me that he came to bring that commandment of love and justice and equality for the second time. Because I think that since the Creation God has been love, and because God loved us God put on earth the community of humanity, but people have always destroyed that love through selfishness, through self-interest, money, and all that; they've destroyed that love. That's why Christ came to die, and to give us again that new commandment, to see if people can now really bring about that love."

I: "There were changes in society and revolutions from then on and that's why that commandment of love that Jesus brought was new, even though love is as old as the creation of the world, as Olivia says. That's just what Saint John says in his first Epistle: that's the ancient commandment that we've had from the beginning, but it's like new 'because the darkness is passing and the true light is now shining.' "

ALEJANDRO: "And those words 'Love one another,' doesn't that mean that if you love you must demand that the others love you, you must demand love?"

I: "And that may also be the newness, what Alejandro points out. Because the commandment in the Bible was only to love your neighbor. And the saints,

they've always been doing that throughout history. But now the commandment is of a new social order; you're going to love the others and you're going to be loved by the others, and everybody's going to love everybody. Isn't that what you mean, Alejandro?"

He answered: "Yes. It's not just to say: 'Love the others.' It's that 'Love each other' means 'Love and ask for love.' The other precept is conformist."

Just as I love you, you must love one another.

I: "He speaks again of 'one another,' which means that love is mutual, or rather that it belongs to everyone, and he doesn't tell us that just as he loves us we must love but that just as he loves us we must have mutual love. God's love of us, that's the love that exists among us."

YOUNG MYRIAM: "They all have to be equal. That's the new society that he's planning."

MARIO AVILA, A Salvadoran composer: "It's a new love with which people were going to love one another, the love that Christ brought and with which he loved humankind. And that's why he says it's a new commandment, to love one another as he loves us. He is the union between us, the mutual love that there will be among us, the collective love that there's going to be in the society of the future, that's the love that he has for us."

FERNANDO: "We shall all love with Christ's love, and we shall all be loved by others with Christ's love: a love that leads one even to give his life for others."

ELVIS: "And those who have already died for others in the struggle for freedom, those have already loved others with Christ's love."

*If you love one another,
everyone will know that you are my disciples.*

FELIPE: "Wherever a group is organized that loves one another like that, a society, it's clear that those people are disciples of Jesus. And where there isn't a society organized with that mutual love, there are no disciples."

FERNANDO: "There you'd have the situation we talked about earlier: they'd look for him but they wouldn't find him. They'd be separated from Jesus."

I: "But would it be important to Jesus that everyone would notice that they are his disciples?"

LAUREANO: "It would seem like boasting."

FELIPE: "It seems that people can understand, through the deeds of this community, that we have learned from him, that we are doing what he taught (he taught not only with words but also with his example, and above all by dying). And we have learned from him as the disciple has learned from the teacher, that is, we are acting like him. Like a master carpenter, like José Arana who knows how to make a good boat, and he has an assistant; and when we see that the assistant can also now make a good boat, we see that he learned from his teacher."

LAUREANO: "It seems he said that as a guarantee that it was going to be true. Because it could be that somebody goes around saying they love their neighbor and probably it's just to screw their neighbor. But if you practice love you're not talking nonsense; you're talking about a reality."

I: "You have to keep in mind who Jesus Christ is in order to understand what it means to be his disciple."

FELIPE: "He's the liberator; and then it'll be known

that we are the followers of the liberator, that we too are liberators."

I: "We must also remember that he is the incarnate Word of God, according to the prologue of this same Gospel of Saint John."

LAUREANO: "It's because through Jesus God expressed the love he had for humanity; it was then the word of God."

I: "And when God expresses this love to us God's also telling us, by means of the divine word, Jesus, that we must love one another. The word of God is the word of love, because God is love. God's word is the commandment of love. Christ is that word, which has come to communicate to us the love for one another. He incarnates the commandment that we must love one another. And to love one another means to put in practice his word, to be his disciples."

MANUEL: "It's damned tough to love when some jerk is maybe hating me, or is talking about me, and I've got to be loving him."

FERNANDO: "Well, that other guy is also receiving the same commandment. It's not just for you; it's for the other guy too. When everybody obeys that commandment, then we're going to know, says Christ, that we're disciples of the one who has brought the teaching of love. That's going to be his glory, our love, and the glory of God revealed in him."

MARIO: "When there's no injustice, no slavery, that's when we'll see his glory and God's glory: the glory of love."

I asked if there was anything more to add. They said there wasn't. They asked Mejía Godoy and Mario Avila to sing their songs.

16.

Supper Talk II

(John 14:1-14)

We continue at supper.

*Do not be so worried. Have faith in God
and have faith in me also.*

*In my Father's house there are many mansions;
if it were not so, I would have told you.*

So I go to prepare a place for you.

GLORIA: "Heaven is a united humanity."

MANUEL: "Is that the just society that's going to be?"

FELIPE: "This seems to me a little involved, all those places. It sounds like the afterlife, doesn't it?"

OLIVIA: "Yes, because he says he's going to prepare a place for them yonder, now that he's going to die; and that if there isn't anything there he'd have said frankly that there isn't anything."

WILLIAM: "I think this is involved too; I'm a little confused like Felipe. Because we had understood that the kingdom was going to be created in this life; and

the Father's house, it seems to me, has to be human society."

I: "It seems clear to me that Jesus is talking here of a humanity after death. Or at least we'll be included in that just society, if we are in it, even after death. We're not being confused. Where he is going is to his resurrection. He's saying this very clearly."

ALEJANDRO: "He says we're going to live together in a house. The Father's house is a family house. Humanity is going to gather in a single family."

I: "Humanity will be united in a common soul. That is the Father's house. He says the house is very large, because it's for all of humanity, all races, all civilizations, and all the ages. And perhaps also all the planets in the universe. Perhaps the Father's house is the whole universe, and that's why Jesus says there are many mansions, or living places, or apartments. And as Jesus always had a very revolutionary attitude with respect to traditional religion, he tells them that if it weren't necessary to think of another life, in a survival after death, he would have been the first one to tell us. And he tells the disciples that they now know which is the place and which is the way."

Thomas said:

*"Lord, we don't know where you are going.
How are we going to know the way?"*

Jesus answered him:

"I am the way, the truth, and the life."

I: "Three very different things that don't seem to have anything in common."

OSCAR: "It seems that we were lost and he came to show us the way. The way is his message, love, to arrive at the Father's house."

REBECA, his mother: "And he also came to show what the truth is. The truth is the opposite of deception, of exploitation. So the truth is love."

MARCELINO, Rebeca's husband and the stepfather of Oscar: "And life is the same thing as love, because love produces life, while injustice produces death, crime."

WILLIAM: "That can be proven statistically: among the poor there is a lower life expectancy than among the rich, and among poor countries lower than among rich countries. That's taking life from the poor."

I: "And in the Bible truth and justice (or liberation) appear as the same thing. Saint Paul speaks of those who oppress *truth* with *injustice*."

OSCAR: "It seems as though they were confused, too, as though they didn't understand; but it seems that if we understand love, then we've already begun to be in a community, in the Lord's house. It's not necessary to be all together as we're together here, because there are many places to be together as we are here talking about what interests us, which is love."

*If you knew me you would also know my Father;
and you really do know him and you have seen him.*

OLIVIA: "To know Jesus is to know the people. If you know his revolutionary message, you know the Father; if not, no matter how religious you are, you don't know God."

FELIPE: "He's telling them to unite and that this

love is God; that they already know him because they know his teaching of love and God is love.”

Philip said to him:

*“Lord, show us the Father,
that is all we want.”*

Jesus answered him:

*“Philip, I have been with you all so long,
and you still do not know me?*

He who sees me sees the Father.”

I: “Philip was confused. And no wonder. It seems that Jesus is talking at the same time about two opposite things about the Father’s house: one is in the afterlife, and the other is that seeing him is seeing the Father, in this life.”

“But we can’t see Christ as his disciples saw him. How can we see God?”

IVAN: “We see Christ here. In others. And anyone who sees him like that sees the Father.”

ELVIS: “You might say that in the poor you see the Father.”

I: “Saint John says that no one has seen God, but he doesn’t say it in the sense that no one has seen God in this life and that God can be seen only in the other life, but in the sense that no one has seen God because God can’t be seen, because God doesn’t exist as people imagine. God does exist, but in another way. Saint John adds right after: ‘but if we love one another God exists in us.’ ”

*The Father, who lives in me,
is he who does his own work.*

I: "He often speaks about doing his Father's work. He gives as an example a workman's son who learns his father's trade, as the carpenter José Arand learned carpentry from his father Angel. We may ask ourselves what was that trade that Jesus learned."

ALEJANDRO: "His Father's trade is construction."

I: "Yes, the same trade as that of his other father, Joseph. The Gospel doesn't exactly say that Joseph was a carpenter. It uses the Greek word *tecnos* (from which the word 'technician' comes). *Tecnos* means maker, constructor, worker in general (at that time there was no specialized labor). The work of his Father was also that same work of *tecnos* of the universe. Here he tells us that the Father that lives in him is the one who is carrying out his own work. In another passage he had told us that God had not rested since the six days of the creation, as the Bible says, but that he kept on working always."

LAUREANO: "If God is love, love is always working to get people to love each other."

I: "God created the universe, and created it through love, or through evolution, which is the same thing; by means of the cohesive force that unites atoms, molecules, cells, animals, people, and societies. The Father has never stopped working because the universe has always gone on creating itself, through evolution. But with his Son now the work is different; we're coming into a new stage of evolution. Evolution now begins to be conscious and directed by people."

FELIPE: "His work is to teach love. That love that he brought is God who is acting in him, doing his work. The work is the liberation of humanity."

OSCAR: "Ernesto, I think the Father works through his Son, and Christ does that work through each per-

son, through each one of us. For me, that's the fight for liberation, as Felipe says, and if we fight we can win, and that will be the resurrection, or better the transformation of life, because we'll have defeated everything that is now oppressing the unfortunate. Many have died in that struggle and it's because Christ was working in those people."

DONALD: "The teaching that Jesus brought, that he is the poor man and that anyone who sees the poor sees God: that is the work of God. And Christ was leaving the world because that work was going to stay on earth so that we could continue it. Wherever anybody works for humankind, for a more just society, wherever anybody works for the Revolution, there the work of the Father is being done. Creation is being continued. The world is being made better than he left it to us so we could improve it."

*Believe me that I am in the Father
and that the Father is in me;
or if not, at least believe me for what I do.*

DONALD: "That if they don't believe in him, that he is united to God, let them believe in what he does. What he does is unite people, and bring justice to the earth. Let them believe in the revolution. That's enough."

FELIPE: "Well, that's believing in him."

*Truly I tell you, he who believes in me,
he also will do the things that I do,
and things even greater,
for I go to where the Father is.*

BOSCO: "Perhaps it's the perfect society."

ALEJANDRO: "The work that he does is the same as the Father does: the revolution. And we'll make that greater than what Jesus could have made it."

WILLIAM: "He says it's because he's going to the Father; that's why we could do things greater than he. Because he was only coming to start the liberation, and we should continue it, and the liberation will gradually get greater and greater."

DON TOMAS: "Suppose that we're left alone here, without Ernesto, and suppose we manage to establish justice that we didn't manage to do when he was here. And things they just talk about doing now, then they put them in practice. That's the way it seems to me."

OLIVIA: "When in a country where people that didn't use to eat are eating, and people that didn't use to have medicines now have them, as is the case in Cuba, that's where love is being built up, and the work of the Son is being done, which he learned from his Father; but it's being done through people, because it's not going to come from the sky."

*And all that you ask in my name, I will do it,
so that the Son may reveal the glory of the Father.*

NATALIA: "You have to change your attitude."

OLIVIA: "To ask in his name isn't to say prayers mentioning his name, like so many who pray and are rich and exploiters. Specifically, here in Nicaragua I think that to ask in his name is not to pray but to act."

NATALIA: "You have to change your attitude. Because if you don't change your attitude, no matter how much you pray, you don't accomplish anything."

OLIVIA: "It's changing ourselves to change society,

and changing society to change ourselves. And I think those people who are changing society in other places, doing marvels for the people, are doing it in the name of Christ though they may be atheists. God doesn't mean anything to them, Christ doesn't mean a thing to them, but the people mean a lot to them, and so what they do they do in the name of Christ and in the name of God, because Christ and the Father are one, and so are Christ and the poor. And that's the glory of the Father, to have love happen on earth."

I: "That's very true, what Olivia says. In the Bible there's a lot of talk about the 'glory of God,' but Christians no longer know what that means. 'Glory of God' is the same as 'justice.' It's the fulfillment of justice on earth and the elimination of the unjust. In other words: it's the kingdom of God. When the people were liberated in Egypt, they were shown the 'glory of God' in a cloud; and each time there was a new liberation, it was a new manifestation of the glory of God. In the Psalms, the oppressed and the poor often ask God for their liberation, it was a new manifestation of the glory of God. In the Psalms, the oppressed and the poor often ask God for their liberation, telling him to show his 'glory.' The Prophets say that the peoples will see the *justice* and the *glory* of God (as if they were the same thing). The glory of God is also identified with peace just as justice is identified with peace. And when Christ is born, there is that song of the angels: 'glory to God' and 'peace to human-kind' (as if they were the same thing). And that is the glory of the Father that Jesus says he will reveal when we ask in his name."

MANUEL: "He says 'all that you ask in my name'; so we have to pray too."

OLIVIA: "But he says let it be 'in his name'; and 'in his name' is loving your neighbor, 'in his name' is freeing the people from oppression, and that's what they're doing, the people that are changing society in those atheist countries; and that prayer produces miracles, like the miracles that we're seeing there."

The MANUEL from San Carlos: "The hunger strikes and the protests that are being held in the Managua churches are a better prayer than what they used to have in those churches. That's asking in the name of Jesus Christ for a quart of milk not to cost more than a peso. Because that's too much for it to cost."

OSCAR: "We must act in the name of the leader of a group, as soon as he has gone. It's just the same. We've got a Che Guevara and so many others who've died for justice, for the kingdom of God, and we must fight in their name, in the name of what they did, which is the same as Christ did, and even greater, even better, because maybe Christ didn't get to do that."

I: "Before, he said that the Father acts in him. Now he says he acts in the disciples, who will be able to do greater things than he can."

OSCAR: "It seems to me that if a person fights for that same thing and then goes away, and we go on acting in the name of what that person's done and taught, it seems to me we're acting in the name of Christ, and we're doing the same thing he did, which was the Father's work."

I: "Continuing the Father's work, which is the fulfilling of love on earth."

OSCAR: "I used to think that the name was worthless, doing something 'in the name of Christ,' and now I see what it means. It seems that if you fight for the freedom of a group, and then you go away, and others

carry on your fight, they're doing it in your name. Why, man, going back to what Tomás says: if you've been fighting for something and you've taught us and you go away and we're going to fight in your name, it's the same thing; any of us who are here, we're going to accomplish something that Christ didn't accomplish, but it's being accomplished now through us."

I: "He is the way to arrive at the Father's house, at the house of the unity of all people, where all humanity will live together and never die. That's why he said from the beginning: don't worry, have faith."

OSCAR: "It seems that the body will die, but human beings won't die, and the body doesn't matter."

I: "The individual dies but we go on living, and it's not that we go on living without a body but with a body in common, which is the body of Christ, all of humanity, unified. Since the individual body dies, he speaks of taking us to the Father's house, which means a collective life, after the individual death. If at the end death should triumph over life, reaction would have triumphed over the revolution. Anything more?"

17.

Supper Talk III

(John 14:15-31)

*If you love me, obey my commandments.
And I will beg the Father to send you another de-
fender,
to be with you always: the spirit of truth.*

I: "We are still at the Last Supper. Jesus says that if we love him we must obey his commandments. We know that they are only one, the new commandment. But why would he say that if we love him we have to love one another?"

FELIPE: "It seems that he and we are the same thing."

I: "Yes, he is love incarnate, he himself is the new commandment; to love his message of love is to love one another."

"You can also say the reverse: to love people is to love him."

"But to love people is to love the oppressed; it's not to love the exploiters."

OLIVIA: "It seems quite mysterious that he's going to beg the Father to send another. But the other is his

own illumination, because love has really been seen very little; it wasn't evident in those times. And so it was as if he were saying: 'I'm going to send you love, which is what there's none of in the world, unity.' That is, himself; because who else was he going to send except himself, in spirit."

I: "He and the Father are the same thing; the Father, who is love, sent us Jesus, love incarnate, and now he's going to send us the spirit of love, that is, the spirit of the teachings of Jesus, which is also himself."

OSCAR: "It seems as though love existed before, right? But the Father saw that love, without the help of the Holy Spirit, could die, and that it was necessary to send that other one to illumine and give strength to each person, so they'll feel love. And that's why he sent the Spirit. But we Christians must always be careful to ask the Spirit to illumine us or something like that, because if we don't we're left as we used to be before. Because love, it seems, is not a matter of just feeling love, because lots of us say 'I'm in love,' and maybe we're screwing our neighbors."

I: "But it's curious: he doesn't call him the Spirit of love but the Spirit of truth."

OSCAR: "Hell! It's like if I tell a woman I love her and I don't love her. I'm not telling her the truth. There it's not the Spirit of love talking but a completely false love."

FELIPE: "Because Christians often have a love that's just talk, and those who aren't Christians are the ones that make love a reality; they are acting the truth; because even though they don't talk about love or Christianity or theories of that sort, they're really the ones that are following the truth, practicing the truth."

OSCAR: "Of course, they speak with love."

FELIPE: "They speak with love but they don't talk about love."

I: "In the Old Testament the Holy Spirit is the spirit of Yahweh, which is the same as saying the spirit of justice and liberation. He's the one who spoke through the prophets proclaiming the truth."

RAUL: "That's the spirit that's offered to us if we love each other. If we don't love each other. . . ."

*Those who are worldly cannot receive him,
because they do not see him or know him;
but you know him, because he is with you
and he will always remain with you.*

"The spirit of God or the spirit of justice is the spirit of struggle that is present in the people. It's class consciousness. It's also the spirit of Jesus Christ. And the worldly ones, that is, the oppressors, don't see him or know him."

"If it's the spirit of truth it's the spirit of justice. Because exploitation and deception are the same thing."

GUSTAVO, the Colombian: "I think that truth, the whole truth, is always revolutionary. Then the spirit of truth is something that moves things to change, to cast down the oppressor's lie, to impose the truth of the oppressed."

I: "When Christ came to the world it was full of falsehoods, myths, deceptions, because it was full of injustice. The Gospel of Saint John somewhere else identifies truth with love."

GUSTAVO: "The stuff in this Gospel seems to me very inspiring; for it gives the assurance that when the physical presence of Christ is not in the midst of his

followers, that is, the oppressed, they are always left with the truth, which is on their side.”

RAUL: “It seems to me that when Christ says he’s going to send someone else, we may think he was referring to Marx.”

GUSTAVO: “I believe that in every epoch humanity has had its liberations, and it has got closer and closer to a kingdom of love. It’s the spirit of truth that has always guided people in that search for definitive liberation.”

RAUL: “And it has acted in Marx, right? I’m not saying he’s physically the Holy Spirit. But here he says very clearly: ‘Those who are worldly cannot receive him.’ It’s perfectly clear. The bourgeois are never going to receive Marx.”

I: “In the Gospel of Saint John ‘the world’ is the same as the system, unjust society, the status quo. Those who belong to the system, says Christ, cannot receive that spirit.”

*On that day you will realize
that I am in my Father,
and you are in me, and I am with you.*

TOMAS: “We are all together.”

FELIPE: “The Father is love, and Jesus is the love that has come to us, so that we can love each other and be united in love.”

*He who knows and obeys my commandments
shows that he really loves me.
And my Father will love the one who loves me,
and I too will love him and will reveal myself to
him.*

FELIPE: "The one that loves is the one that practices the truth, the one that commits no injustice. And God is truth; love is truth."

OSCAR: "Well, what happens is that many of us, most people in the world, know the truth but we don't practice it, obey it. So I think that's why there are wars between lies and truth."

"There're people who know the truth but they don't obey it out of fear. They obey the lie, they obey the government. If we obey Christ we have to disobey the commandments of these authorities."

Judas (not the Iscariot) said to him:

"Lord, why are you going to reveal yourself to us and not to the world?"

Jesus answered:

"He who loves me heeds what I say;

and my Father will love him

and my Father and I will come to live with him.

He who does not love me,

does not heed

what I say."

ELVIS: "The worldly ones of that time were rejecting him, and then he wasn't revealing himself to those people; he doesn't go on talking with them. He's revealing himself to the oppressed people; he reveals himself to the people who, in the long run, will understand him."

BOSCO: "That's what happens now with revolutionaries. Revolutionaries aren't going to reveal themselves to the world, to the government, to the police; they're going to reveal themselves to the oppressed, those who are interested in making things change."

I: "We may say that the revolution is not revealed to those who are exploiting; they can not discover the revolution. According to the answer that Jesus gives, those who don't follow his commands (to love) will not be able to understand him."

FELIPE: "Ernesto, I also believe the worldly ones aren't going to understand him, aren't going to try to understand him in the first place because they have no needs, because they've got everything. The message is for the others, for them to realize that they are oppressed by a class and find out for themselves how to liberate themselves."

GUSTAVO: "He's making a class distinction. The ones who are with the world, with the system, he won't reveal himself to them."

OLIVIA: "It seems to me he said that phrase because he knows the harshness that money brings, how hard it is to get loose of riches in order to love, and then he was assuring us that it was the oppressed class that's going to understand him. But there are also people that never accept a revolution and don't understand it even though they are without money."

*The Holy Spirit, the defender,
that my Father will send you in my name,
will teach it all to you,
and will make you remember all I have said to you.*

ELVIS: "They'll be leaders who will come from the people."

IVAN: "Che, for example, came to help us to remember."

I: "All the revolutionary inspiration that there's been in the world is this spirit, and he's reminding us of

what Jesus has said, what's in this book that we're commenting on and that has often been forgotten. Jesus knew that what he said was going to be forgotten, and that it was going to be necessary for the revolutionary spirit to come to remind us of it."

*I leave you peace, I give you my peace.
I do not give what the world gives.*

I: "The Jews used to greet one another with the word 'shalom' (peace), and Jesus here is saying farewell. But the word 'shalom,' which appears very frequently in the Bible, means much more than our word 'peace.' 'Shalom' is not only the absence of war; it's also harmony and happiness. It's to enjoy peace in the abundance of material goods, and in harmony with neighbors. It gives the idea of song and dance, and it's above all the happiness of a people free of all oppression. This peace isn't the opposite of war, because during war there can also be 'shalom' in a people that is united; the opposite of it is rather social injustice or oppression. It had been announced that the Messiah would bring a permanent peace. When Jesus was born the empire was at peace in the so-called Pax Romana, but he says his peace is not the peace of the world."

BOSCO: "The peace of the United States."

"Or the peace of Nicaragua; the peace they say we've had for forty years."

FELIPE: "That's a false peace, the peace of oppression. We can be really at peace only when we have all our goods in common; otherwise we're divided into classes and we're fighting."

I: "Among the Jews 'shalom' was the harmony of the united community, and it was something similar to

the words 'communion' and 'communism.' In an early age people had been at peace among themselves and at peace with all of nature. The Messiah would establish a new reign of peace; all peoples would be at peace; even the animals would be at peace among themselves; cosmic harmony would be established, and humanity would become again at peace with God."

*You have heard me say that I am leaving,
and that I shall come to be with you again.
If you really loved me,
you would have been glad to know
that I am going to my Father;
because he is greater than I.*

ALEJANDRO: "This has a lot of application for us, to encourage us to a more serious commitment. Because you're always afraid, mainly afraid to die, but you think you're going to end, that death is everything. This is very important as much for your family as for you."

"Yes, you mustn't be afraid of death, for there's resurrection. He goes away and returns. But where is he going? To heaven? What's heaven?"

I: "In the Bible, 'heaven' is not a place outside the world, as it was later understood. God was the creator of heaven as well as of the earth, and God was in heaven as well as on the earth. It was said that heaven was the throne of God and the earth the platform at his feet. There's a passage where Christ says that the earth is as sacred as heaven. ('Do not swear by heaven, because it is the throne of God, nor by the earth, which is the platform at his feet.') And Jesus here

doesn't say that he's going to heaven but that he's going to the Father. And he also says he'll be coming back from there."

ELVIS: "It's like many revolutionaries who have died for the revolution but they're alive in the people."

I: "Alive in the people, but with a real life. To be resurrected doesn't mean that you're on a poster."

*I will not talk much longer with you,
because the prince of this world is coming,
although he has no power over me.*

ELVIS: "He's referring to the kings there were at that time and that were nothing but falsehood and lies; and that's just what Satan is: lies, deceit, injustice. He's referring to all that."

I: "It's true. Satan means simply the adversary. And Jesus is identifying him with the political power of that society, with the system. He doesn't say that the devil is the prince of the cosmos but of slave society. Soon afterwards he will say before Pilate that his kingdom is not of 'this world.' "

FELIPE: "And he's saying that he's going to be killed by the prince of this system. It's a very revolutionary way of talking about the system, saying that Satan is its governor. Like saying now that he's the president."

"It's good to get this clear, because people have very extravagant ideas about the devil, common people, that is. A little while ago, on the San Juan River, a lady was talking to me about the devil. In Managua, she says to me, there's an office that the devil has, and it's visited by the ones that have a pact with the devil. I asked her: 'And do you know which office it is?' 'No,' she said, 'because only those who have a pact with the

devil know that.' 'Could it be one that's up on a hill?' I asked. 'No, what a thing to say; that's where the president lives!' she answered."

LAUREANO: "It's a miracle that lady didn't report you."

"We're afraid the devil will jump out at us, and we don't realize that we have him right here. He's not out on the highways jumping out at people, he's running the country. And if I exploit my sister or brother, well, I'm a devil among you. And it's very hard to make *campesinos* who are being exploited understand this. We don't realize that we're sick, and that our children don't have enough to eat, and they don't have any capacity for love, don't have schools. Imagine having no schools, no schools in Solentiname! And so many children without schools is a sin, because there's enough money in capitalism. And so much exploitation. And we have no schools for the children; that's the worst thing the devil has done."

"I don't think there's anyone here who doesn't understand that we're exploited; the trouble is that nobody knows the solution for this."

"There's a solution in this book; but you have to begin by knowing that the devil is not a ghost, but a reality, and that he governs us."

"The fact is that exploitation ranges from the biggest to the littlest. If it were only the president, the government, it wouldn't be too bad; but it ranges from one to another, and another, and another."

I: "Until it reaches the most downtrodden people who don't exploit anybody; instead, they get exploited by everybody."

OSCAR: "The exploiters are the ones that are obeying the king of the world."

*Thus it has to be so that the world
will know that I love the Father
and that I do what he commanded me.
Rise up. Let us go away from here.*

OLIVIA: "By bringing that message he was obeying love."

FELIPE: "The only way to show that you love is to free yourself from your own life. That way you can change the world, the system."

OSCAR: "As I see it, when he told them there 'Rise up and let's go away from here,' I find, you know, that he wants to give them the message: let's not be sleeping, let's not be letting the guys in charge be in charge of us. That's why he says: 'Rise up and let's go away from here.' If we have the power to change reality, let's not stick around here just talking."

18.

Supper Talk IV

(John 15:1-13)

*I am the true vine,
and my Father is the vine grower.
If one of my branches bears no fruit,
he cuts it off.*

FELIPE: "I see that most of us call ourselves Christians or Catholics or Evangelicals, but there are many who are separated from the Gospels, from the true plant. Those are the branches that are going to be cut off, the ones that don't come together as Christ wishes."

OSCAR: "Those are the ones that, according to the Gospel, are cut off. They must be cut off immediately. Any exploiter of human beings will have to be eliminated from society."

I: "But what attracts my attention is that Jesus says they are branches of him. Notice that he says there are branches of him that don't bear fruit."

FELIX: "But everyone who's on earth is a branch of him, don't you see? When you don't have mercy on others, when you don't love your neighbor, then you're a branch that bears no fruit. The loveless ones will be eliminated from the face of the earth."

I: "So we see two things: that we are branches of Jesus Christ; and that there are branches that are bad that will have to be cut off."

*And he prunes the branches that bear fruit,
so that they bear more fruit.*

FELIPE: "That's good."

I: "Why is it good?"

FELIPE: "He means that those who love, he'll make them have more love."

MARCELINO: "Maybe they weren't rotten branches but green branches that needed pruning."

"The pruning must be the suffering that falls to our lot."

"Sacrifice in the revolution, then."

"That pruning is also when the revolutionaries are removed. When they kill them, many more are re-born. They used to produce good fruit, but with their deaths they produce much more."

I: "There can be no revolution without grief. And it seems to me that Jesus is saying there are two kinds of suffering in humanity: the cutting off of those who are useless, and the pruning of those who produce so that they will produce more."

"In every socialist system there is also the cutting off of bad branches, and the pruning of the good ones."

*Remain united to me,
as I remain united to you.
A branch cannot produce fruit by itself,
if it does not remain united to the plant;
in the same way you cannot produce fruit
if you do not remain united to me.*

“To be united to Christ is to be united to others. To be united to your community. By means of a small community you’re united to a larger community, as the small branches are united with other bigger ones. And all the branches together are Christ.”

“The branches don’t bear fruit unless they’re united to the whole plant, but the plant without the branches doesn’t yield anything. Grapes come from the branches, right?”

“I think that pruning the bad branches, that ought to be done by people themselves, through society’s justice. Here it says that the Father is the one that does it, but it seems to me that he does it through people.”

“You have to be united because if you stay by yourself you’re kicked off the plant.”

“Solitude is selfishness.”

“The only way to bear fruit is through love; that’s why he says we can’t do anything without him. And what we’re going to bear is just that: love.”

“He’s saying he is everybody and that we’ll be united with him by being united with everybody.”

*I am the vine, and you are the branches.
He who remains united with me,
and I with him, bears much fruit.*

“And what will the fruit be?”

“Wine.”

I: “And wine in the Scripture is always a symbol of happiness and love. So it is the plant of love. And the pruning of grief is so that humanity may produce more love.”

“There’s going to be a lot of wine, but in order to have a lot of wine a lot of branches will have to be

destroyed. He says this a little before his death, and he must have his death on his mind, and the deaths of so many martyrs, his followers.”

“It’s also very fair that one part of humanity is going to be cut off; so that there’ll be no injustice in humanity, and no criminals. People who aren’t in favor of unity, those are the ones torn off the plant.”

*If you remain united to me,
and do not forget my teachings,
ask what you wish, and it will be given to you.*

“Gosh! I think when we’re all united (and that’s being united with Christ, because he is the plant, the people), there’s no need to ask for anything.”

OSCAR: “His teaching, which he tells us not to forget, is that we must all be equal and not have one greater than others. Then we can ask for whatever we want. But what are we going to want? Why, the good of everyone because we’re no longer selfish. And so that will be given to us, because it won’t be true that then I’m not going to need anything.”

I: “And later he says the Father will give us everything we ask in his name. In his name means in his spirit. It’s the same thing he said before, to ask, being united in accordance with his teachings (which are the teachings of equality, as Oscar has said). I think we shouldn’t overlook what Jesus says in the Gospel about prayer, as if it were nonsense; I believe in prayer. So why can we obtain whatever we want? Because with Jesus we are united with God, Love, the author of the universe, author of evolution, and of the revolution, which is the same thing.”

*I love you, just as my Father loves me;
continue, then, in the love that I have for you.*

OSCAR: "Ernesto, we talk a lot about love at every Mass, but love isn't just something you say with your lips. I don't know, but I understand it that way, that love shouldn't just be talk; love must be unity. I see a cow looking for the other cows, a duck wants to be with the other ducks, a fish always goes with the rest of the fish. And how much more for humanity, we ought to be all together, united."

I: "Love is equality, as Oscar said, and Jesus says that when he tells us to love one another with the love he has for the Father, which is the love for the infinite equality of the Trinity. He says that he loves us with that love, and that we must live in that love, that is: in community, as he is with the Father."

*If you obey my commandments,
you will continue in this love that I have for you,
as I obey the commandments of my Father
and continue in the love he has for me.*

I: "He says he obeys the commandments of his Father, and that we must obey his commandments. But they are not different commandments. When he does what the Father commands he continues in love, and when we do what he commands we continue in love, because what he commands and what the Father commands are love."

OLIVIA: "It seems that they are the same commandment, because the Father ordered Christ to give his life for us, and Christ orders us to do the same thing that his Father ordered him to do: give his life for others."

I: "And right here he explains what is his commandment (and his Father's)."

*My commandment is this:
love one another as I love you.*

OSCAR: "I'm going to say just one thing: nowadays people just think about themselves and all the others aren't worth a damn. If we want to be like Christ, a revolutionary, we have got to sincerely forget about ourselves. And I think we can do it, be the same as him, because he was the son of a woman from here on earth. Mary can be any one of these women right here. Any one of them can also be a saint, a Mary, too, just like her, and from any one of them he can be born, if we follow his teachings. We have Che Guevara as an example, and not only him, but many who have died; those are the ones that carried out the teachings that Christ came to preach."

ANDREA, his wife: "It's words you have to use to make the biblical changes, not violence."

LAUREANO: "When Jesus went to drive out the Pharisees that were selling and changing money in the temple, he drove them out with a rope."

PANCHO: "Yes, if anybody had opposed him or tried to kill him, maybe he would have killed them; but there was no need to kill anybody, they all ran away from him."

"Now they don't run away; instead they attack, and then you have to do what the Christians do, who go up into the mountains. But they don't go seeking any advantage for themselves, they go to kill, which is using violence with love. It's not as if you were going to kill in order to seize a rich person's goods."

WILLIAM: "It's revolutionary violence."

OSCAR: "But I think love can also kill: if some bastard is raising hell, and I see that he's ruining everybody, I'll kill him because I don't believe it's a sin."

I: "For example, if you have to protect your children."

GLORIA: "Out of love."

OSCAR: "Yes, because if I see them ruining my kids and I kill, it's out of love. Yes, because Christ talks like that with parables. Because how do we know he wouldn't have done the same, defending love."

OLIVIA: "Notice, now, that evil is a sin, and Christ was called the Lamb of God who takes away the sins of the world, and in some way or other you've got to take away the sins of the world so that love can reign, so that peace can reign. So it has to be, however it happens, so that love will triumph, because the others are killing good people for the fun of it."

OSCAR: "How many guys are fighting for a new society and they kill them like dogs, guys that everybody ought to help, and they kill them like dogs. Those bastards do deserve to be cut off the grape plant which is Christ. I'll kill anybody that opposes me, just because I'm defending my love, and that's what he came to teach, and if I fall, well, I fall out of love."

LAUREANO: "Whenever guerrilla fighters have been struggling for justice they've treated their prisoners very well, often better than their own fighters; for example, taking care of the wounded and giving them medicines that maybe afterwards they were going to need for themselves."

OSCAR: "Why do they do that? Because they really carry out what Christ came to teach. But if they fall into the hands of those bastards who knows what'll happen to them."

OLIVIA: "From the beginning of the world good

people have been dying at the hands of evil people.”

PANCHO: “Notice that the guys that are fighting for justice don’t want to kill anybody. They’d like to make the change on a friendly basis, but they can’t. And before thinking of killing, they’ve decided to offer their lives.”

*The greatest love that you can have
is to give your life for your friends.*

FELIPE: “He says for your friends; he doesn’t say for everybody, for people that are bastards.”

WILLIAM: “I don’t think it has such a limited sense, referring only to your close friends. I think it refers to all of humanity.”

I: “He’s talking about giving your life for those you love, but you can love even people you don’t know.”

“Che said you had to feel any injustice committed anywhere in the world as if it was on your own flesh, and he died for people that didn’t know him.”

“They didn’t even imagine he existed.”

“But he really loved them because he died for them.”

ELVIS: “I can understand that your friends can be people you don’t know; all exploited people can be friends. But for exploiters to be friends, that’s crap.”

BOSCO: “Revolutionaries are even dying for people that aren’t born. For all of humanity.”

WILLIAM: “And even for people who are all screwed up, too. The interesting thing about what we’ve seen is that humanity is a single organism; that’s what Jesus has told us with the country image of the grape plant. And if we’re a single organism, we live only if we’re united to the others, to separate us is to kill us.”

A Guevara girl: “Humanity is the plant of love.”

19.

Supper Talk V

(Luke 22:24–38)

Luke relates a conversation at table that is different from John's. He says that the disciples were arguing about which of them was most important, and Jesus said to them:

*The kings of nations govern them like owners,
and their leaders are called benefactors.
But among you it must not be that way.*

"This hasn't changed yet among us. Here we have a man who treats us like slaves, and who is called Benefactor."

"And also Honorable, Father of the Country, Leader of the Second Independence, and who knows what else."

"Here Jesus is talking about a total change."

"Jesus wanted a regime completely opposite to the one there was then and also the one we have now."

"Does that mean we have to change it as soon as possible?"

"Of course. It's a regime that hasn't changed a bit."

“I’m forty-eight or -nine and I don’t remember any other one.”

I: “At that time the Roman emperor was called ‘Benefactor of the whole globe of the earth.’ Christ is clearly talking here against the Roman empire, and against all kings, and even against all authority. The society that he wants is the perfect communist society in which there will be no such thing as a state.”

“Fidel has always said it’s dangerous in a revolution for a single man to have much authority, that a revolution cannot revolve around one man, that we mustn’t make a man into a god. And he’s taking steps to distribute the power that he’s been given, so that all the power will belong to the people.”

I: “At the beginning of a revolution it’s necessary to have leaders, but afterwards they have to disappear. When I was in Chile a monk who belonged to MIR [Revolutionary Leftist Movement] told me that when Christ said to Pilate, ‘I am king,’ he was telling him that the people is king. The revolutionary leaders are precursors of the people, as John the Baptist was of Christ. Every revolutionary leader ought to say about the people what John the Baptist said about Christ: ‘It is well that I decrease so that he may increase.’ ”

“And why were they arguing about who was most important? It’s because at that supper they were talking about the kingdom; they were arguing about who would have most power. They didn’t know it was a kingdom in reverse: a revolution.”

*On the contrary, the one who is most important
among you
must become like the youngest;
and the one who commands
must become like the servant.*

FELIPE: "And what'll it be like, the youngest? Will the one who commands be like that one that Christ wants?"

LAUREANO: "You have to know what the young people were like at that time. Why, they were like slaves. They were slaves to their parents. That's the reason for the comparison with the young."

ALEJANDRO: "It's putting yourself at the disposal of others. When there are several adults and one young person, the young person is always doing the errands and taking orders from everybody."

OLIVIA: "A day will come when to rule in Nicaragua will mean to be good for all the people."

ALEJANDRO: "He doesn't say nobody ought to rule; he says to rule ought to be to serve."

I: "And the young are also the most revolutionary."

FELIPE: "I like what Jesus says, that the bosses ought to be like the young. He's telling us young people to go on being what we are. And also for the old to be young."

LAUREANO: "I'd just like to point out that if we want to be important we have to serve each other."

*Who, then, is most important,
the one who is sitting at the table,
or the one who serves?
Isn't it really the one who is at the table?
But I am among you like the one who serves.*

I: "He had washed their feet, which was something that servants did."

"At present, capitalism is the one that's seated, and the poor person is the one that's waiting on tables."

"Then everyone will be equal, nobody will rule others, a society of equality will be created."

"He was coming to change things around. If he had come as a lord, to be waited on, he wouldn't have brought anything new."

"In a community there are always people who are ready to lend their services. Those are the real leaders."

"Fidel has said that in the revolution you don't aspire to command; to command is a responsibility that the community imposes on you."

"It seems to me Jesus is telling them that he is serving them at the table not only because he has washed their feet but also because he has given them his body delivered up for others, and his blood spilt for others, in the Eucharist."

"And it seems to me that it's also because the social change that he brings is like a banquet for the whole earth."

You are the ones that have been with me in my trials.

*Therefore I give you a kingdom,
as my Father gave it to me,
so that you may eat and drink
at my table in my kingdom
and sit on thrones to judge the twelve tribes of
Israel.*

"The leaders of the new people."

"So they're talking of a change there."

"A new society."

"I think he's talking not just to them but to all those who are going to serve, going to follow his example."

"I think everyone who serves is an apostle."

"Well, what he's saying, that everyone should serve

others, is a new social system. A government that operates in accordance with the Gospels, that's the revolution. I see all of Nicaragua changing. The people are going to be different from what they are now."

"But these people are already different, the people in this Solentiname community. Look at how the people of San Carlos are: totally alienated. In their political meetings you're not going to see Solentiname people. Solentiname people, where they meet is here. You're not going to see people from here mixed up in their politicking, not these people. And they say: Well, the Solentiname people didn't come! The long-haired ones didn't show! And they realize that the people from here have freed themselves with this book. They're different people. You can't fool them any longer with the Benefactor, the way you can fool the San Carlos people. These people are already different people."

"Why sure, you can see the evil in their faces. And all their talk is empty; they themselves don't take it seriously."

"Jesus is offering thrones, but those thrones aren't like the ones the kings used to use. They're like the thrones of the young, of the kingdom of love. Of course, having everybody living in unity, that's the throne that Christ promises us. For us all to be equal, for everybody to work for the good of everybody, and not each one for her or himself."

"He promises a great feast; he talks of food and drink (I like the drink part especially). That means an abundance, and joy for everyone. Joy, the feast of humanity."

"It seems to me that that eating and drinking, that abundance and joy of that feast, is a liberated human-

ity where people eat equally, where there's love. Because at present this isn't love, with some on one side and the rich on the other. You can't have a feast for everybody now. Not until all the things on earth belong to everybody can we have the feast that Christ wants on the earth. As long as there's no love, there's no kingdom, there's no feast."

I: "He says they're going to judge the people. In the Bible 'judge' is a liberating chieftain. The judges in the Book of Judges weren't magistrates, they were liberators. It's clear that they imparted justice, but it was by freeing the oppressed from their oppressors. The Last Judgment, we've already seen, is the last liberation. The twelve tribes is the new people, all of humanity."

*"When I sent you out without bag, purse, or shoes,
did you lack anything?"*

They said: "Nothing."

Then he said to them:

*"Well, now, on the other hand,
let him who has a bag take it,
and also a purse;*

*let him who has no sword sell his cloak and buy
one.*

*Because I tell you that what the Scriptures say
must be fulfilled in me:*

'And they numbered him among the evildoers.'

For all that is written about me has to be fulfilled."

Then they said to him:

"Lord, here are two swords."

And he answered: "That is enough."

I: "It's not known exactly what that last phrase of Christ means: 'That is enough.' There are several in-

terpretations. Some translate it as 'It's sufficient,' as if meaning that those two swords were sufficient. But that makes no sense; two swords couldn't be sufficient, and besides he had just told them that each one should have a sword. Others say that the 'That is enough' was said ironically. Others believe that he said: 'Enough!' cutting off the conversation brusquely, displeased because they weren't understanding him, believing that he was talking about material swords. But that doesn't seem logical to me either, because if they weren't understanding him he should have explained himself better. Others think he simply said: 'That's enough talking,' and that seems to me most logical, for they immediately got up from the table and went away."

WILLIAM: "I see there are two disciples who were armed. Swords are used only to kill; they're not like machetes, which are also used for work. Swords, like pistols, are only for killing."

LAUREANO: "It seems to me it's because they were going underground. They couldn't go around in public anymore; the people wouldn't feed them."

I: "He says they are numbering him among the evil-doers, which means among the subversives, among the bandits."

JULIO CASTILLA: "He might mean: there's nothing to do now but take up arms, because they think of us as bandits."

TERESITA: "And if they don't have money let them get it from the bank?"

WILLIAM: "I think Laureano is right: they have to arm themselves; how are they going to keep on fleeing?"

I: "It has always been considered that Jesus is talk-

ing here in a figurative sense, that he is not talking of material swords."

ALEJANDRO: "But he's talking about practical, concrete things, quite real: the purse, the money, the knapsack. Why do the swords have to be spiritual?"

ELVIS: "I see it quite clearly: He's telling them that times have changed. They used to go around stirring up everybody's consciences and they were well received, but now the government won't allow it and they're beginning to persecute them, and they're going to have to go underground and they're going to have to take up arms to defend themselves."

"The cloak was a garment they wore over their clothes, like an overcoat, and they could sell it and still have clothes on."

"There was a tunic and there was a cloak."

"The mantle was more elegant."

"They could have had more than one; if they only had one, they must have walked around stinking."

"I think he could be talking rather of the future. Because a just government was going to need swords to defend itself from the reactionaries, at least for a certain time."

I: "The fact is that there are two swords, and he doesn't tell them that's not the point, that he was talking about spiritual swords."

ALEJANDRO: "And who says he was telling a parable?"

I: "It has been traditionally interpreted that way, down through the centuries. Have you ever heard of Christ ever talking of taking up arms?"

TERESITA: "It's always been said that he was against all violence."

LAUREANO: "The fact is that Peter went around

with a sword, and if Christ didn't tell him to get rid of it, it's because he didn't disapprove of it."

WILLIAM: "And to talk to them of 'swords' at such a moment when they were underground, and some of them were armed, without explaining to them that it was about spiritual swords, that was a little imprudent, wasn't it? There was a chance that the swords would be used, as in fact Peter used his a little later. And at any rate, if Christ was referring to spiritual swords and didn't explain it, we're not to blame if here and now we're interpreting it as we do."

I: "He certainly must have seen the swords; and if he hadn't seen them, they told him they had them, and he didn't say: don't go around with weapons."

LAUREANO: "Swords were like today's machine guns."

WILLIAM: "One of the swords belonged to Peter, and when later he took it out in the olive grove, Jesus said to him: Put it away in its sheath. He didn't say: Throw it away."

"Christ first sent them in peace, to stir up consciences, because he believed at the beginning that the kingdom would be accepted by everybody. Afterwards he realized it wasn't possible because of the class struggle."

"Did he make a mistake?"

"He used a tactic that didn't work, and he changed it for another one."

"At first he said the rich should give up their riches. But it really wasn't just about giving up riches. It was about changing the system of production."

"Which is the same as giving up the riches. But what happened was that they didn't give them up."

I: "It's interesting that at the Last Supper, where the

Eucharist was established, they were armed. That's never been mentioned."

LAUREANO, whose family is Protestant: "Protestants say the sword was the Bible. And that they had two Bibles, not two swords."

I: "Then they would have said: Here we have a sword. Even when they had two copies of the Bible, the Bible is only one."

WILLIAM: "Besides, that was a 'sword' that the enemies had too; the others were also armed with the Bible."

LAUREANO: "Besides, the swords they had were to attack the others; because afterwards Peter floored that guy. With the sword he cut him down."

"I think that Christ, from the time they told him they had two, realized they were lost. At least with the swords they were lost."

"Since they only had two they were screwed."

"Well, I wasn't present when you began to read this, but I'm reading here that it says: 'This that the Scriptures say must be fulfilled in me: And they numbered him among the evildoers.' It means they numbered him among the subversives. Maybe he's saying to them: Now you can carry arms, now we're subversives."

ALEJANDRO: "Two swords were nothing, not even if the twelve of them were armed. But if they'd had two thousand swords, or twelve thousand, they still wouldn't have done anything. They would have waged a traditional war like the others."

BOSCO: "And humanity had to go through stages."

ALEJANDRO: "But now just a few weapons are enough to destroy a regime."

I: "The truth is that at that time with swords you

couldn't establish socialism or communism. There didn't yet exist what Marxism calls the objective conditions. But there *were* the subjective conditions, at least among them."

ALEJANDRO: "He saw he was getting nowhere with armed struggle, and stirring consciences didn't work, and so all he had left to do was die."

WILLIAM: "That doesn't mean that armed struggle is no good."

I: "And his death changed history, and from then on came all the revolutions. All the changes that humanity has had have been due to his message. That has changed the objective conditions and the subjective conditions, and now two swords can accomplish something."

BOSCO: "Why, man! Fidel began the struggle in the Sierra Maestra with only twelve men. You can say that with twelve swords he demolished Batista's tyranny."

I: "Until a day comes when we're not going to need the sword, of course. Lenin says that in the perfect communist society there won't even be any police. Anything more?"

Nobody spoke.

I: "Then let us say with Jesus: That is enough."

BOSCO: "On the walls of Managua you can see that phrase written even with coal, and on the highways of Nicaragua: THAT'S ENOUGH."

I: "That could also be the meaning of Jesus' phrase: THAT'S ENOUGH!"

20.

In the Olive Grove

(Matthew 26:36-56)

This time we had with us as visitors the Costa Rican theatre director Oscar Castillo, the Nicaraguan writer Sergio Ramírez, and the Argentinian novelist Julio Cortázar. At the beginning of the Mass they had stood at the back, near the entrance. After the Gospel had been read I had told them to come closer, because we were going to have what in other places they call a “round table.”

Jesus arrived with his disciples at a place called Gethsemane.

He said to them:

“Sit here while I go ahead to pray.”

1: “He was in hiding there. He was already underground. He had just celebrated Passover secretly in Jerusalem. Judas revealed the place where he was hiding. The Gospel says that the ones who ordered the capture were the priests and the elders of the Jews. ‘Elders’ in those times meant the leaders, who were generally very old. Now, the leaders that we have are

all very old in mind, even though they are young. The soldiers didn't know which one was Jesus; Judas told them he was going to kiss him so they would know who he was."

WILLIAM: "At that time it seems that it was the custom to kiss; it's still the custom in some countries. Or maybe it was a kind of embrace."

LAUREANO: "Like when Somoza embraced Sandino before he killed him. The traitor's embrace. Here it was a traitor's kiss. All the same."

OSCAR CASTILLO, the theatre director: "If other Masses were like this one I'd go every Sunday."

OLIVIA: "This is very important right now, because the authorities are always flattering some people and doing them favors, while they're sentencing others to death. And I think every leader has to be on guard, has to take precautions the way Jesus did."

ESPERANZA: "Judas had already turned into an ear."

I explained to our foreign visitors that in Nicaragua spies are called "ears."

JULIO CORTAZAR: "What a good word! Clear."

I: "We've always had them here. Ears are always coming around."

ESPERANZA: "Judas had already made contact with Security."

SERGIO RAMIREZ: "I'll bet that wasn't the first thing he did."

OSCAR CASTILLO: "If it wasn't the first it was the worst."

*Going a little farther away,
he fell on his face to the ground,
and he prayed saying:*

*“Father, if it is possible,
take from me this cup,
but it is not what I want but what you want
that should be done.”*

I: “Mark says he used the word ‘Abba,’ which in Aramaic means ‘papa,’ the name used by children who are beginning to talk. In the Old Testament God is never called ‘Father.’ On the other hand that’s the only thing Jesus called him; he never used the word ‘God.’ And it seems besides that he only called him ‘Papa,’ he didn’t even call him ‘Father,’ which must have been even more scandalous. It has been established that in the time of Jesus young people and adults could also use that childish expression to call their fathers; as we also frequently call our fathers ‘papa’ or ‘dad’; and they also used to use this for the oldest or most respected ones. On one occasion Jesus told his disciples that they shouldn’t call anyone ‘Papa’ except God.”

GLORIA: “The Papa is love, and that is the only will that he respects. He only wants to love what love loves.”

OLIVIA: “The Father has given that token to the Son, the token of love. Because he wants liberation, and liberation could come only through his death. Society couldn’t be changed, the world couldn’t be changed, made different, without that death. Death horrifies everyone; he felt that horror; he wanted another way out, but there was no other way out.”

I: “Saint Paul in the Epistle to the Hebrews says that this prayer that Jesus said with great cries and tears was heeded. How are we to understand this?”

ESPERANZA: “Because he was resurrected.”

FELIPE: “This prayer of Jesus is the prayer of every revolutionary, even though they don’t address God

and they don't call him papa like Jesus or anything else, but their feeling is the same: they don't want to suffer, but they are ready for torture, death, any kind of death."

We read that later Jesus found them asleep, and he said to Peter:

Be wakeful and pray so that you will not fall into temptation.

LAUREANO: "The temptation to not give his whole self, to want not to die and to remain withdrawn without doing what he had to do."

I: "Jesus was having that temptation, and that's why he was praying."

ALEJANDRO: "And he says it mainly to Peter, because he knew that Peter was the most apt to fall into that temptation, and not to let himself be screwed."

I: "Very true. That temptation Jesus had had in the desert: that of being a triumphant Messiah. Later, when he spoke of going to Jerusalem to die, Peter scolded him telling him not to be a damned fool, and Jesus called him 'Satan,' because he was tempting him. And it seems that now Jesus is having the same temptation again, very strong: not to let himself be killed. And possibly to take up arms."

JULIO CORTAZAR: "Logical. Given the extreme circumstances in which he had placed himself, it was the only alternative left to him."

I: "The will of God is at times incomprehensible. Christ himself didn't understand it here, but he accepted it. The poet Coronel Urtecho has said that in Nicaragua it would seem that Divine Providence was on the side of Somoza."

WILLIAM: "But from the revolutionary point of

view, at times it's good to have an extreme oppression, so there can be a very radical change."

Afterwards they come to arrest him, and Judas kisses him.

Jesus said to him:

"Friend, why do you come?"

TERESITA: "Why would he call him friend?"

SERGIO RAMIREZ: "Because they were comrades."

I: "What's your opinion, Teresita?"

TERESITA: "I'm asking. Can it be that he still considered him a friend?"

SERGIO: "There's a lot of irony here. Because he's betraying him, and they were comrades."

I: "So there are two possibilities: that he said it with affection, or that he said it with irony."

CORTAZAR: "I think he said it with irony, and that it was the harshest thing he could say to him. The proof is that only a few hours later Judas hangs himself."

MANUELITO: "He didn't say to him: 'Son of a bitch.' "

CORTAZAR: "So that he would realize what he had done, it was harsher to call him friend than to insult him. It was harsher."

OSCAR CASTILLO: "Of course. When he called him friend he was calling him a traitor."

SERGIO RAMIREZ (who had recently published *El pensamiento vivo de Sandino, The Living Thought of Sandino*): "When they were taking Sandino to be shot at Somoza's orders, Sandino said: 'But we're friends; I've just had supper with him, he gave me an inscribed photograph.'"

I: "It's now believed that Judas' betrayal was not

really for money, as the Gospel simplistically presents it, but rather because he became disillusioned with Christ. Christ had previously said that he congratulated the one who was not disillusioned with him. And it seems that this was also the reason for Peter's rejecting him. Judas' nickname, Iscariot, seems to have meant 'zealot' (guerrilla fighter). He probably belonged to that movement which believed in armed struggle, but which had the same religious ideology as the Pharisees. The kind of kingdom that Jesus was bringing was not at all to his liking, and he switched sides."

WILLIAM: "The business about the coins could have been symbolic; he wanted the power, but the money, too, because power and money can't be separated."

I: "The thirty silver coins that the Gospel mentions were, in Jesus' time, scarcely a laborer's wages, as we might now say fifteen pesos, so Judas couldn't have betrayed him for that amount. The Gospel is referring to a text of Zechariah where it said that the prophet's price is thirty silver coins, which at that time was the price of a slave. As we might now say, the price of a horse. But what Judas received must have been more, for the Gospel says that with that money they bought a lot near Jerusalem to make a cemetery."

CORTAZAR: "The Evangelist was probably using a metaphor, as we also use it when somebody sells himself to the enemy and we say he sold himself for thirty pieces of silver."

WILLIAM: "But the money also played its part then, although the first reason was disillusion with the revolutionary cause. Everyone who abandons the revolutionary struggle and goes over to the other side receives a prize."

DONALD: "Judas betrayed not only a man, he betrayed a people, his own people."

FELIPE: "The kingdom that he wanted was the kingdom of the capitalists, and he wanted to be a minister in it, and he became disenchanted with Jesus when he saw that his kingdom was the kingdom of the poor."

WILLIAM: "All the betrayals that the church leaders have committed have been like this one of Judas (Judas was also a bishop): because of not believing in the kingdom of Christ, of the poor; because of preferring domination to liberation; and finally, for money also."

OLIVIA: "And the people are then crucified."

FELIPE: "I believe the main cause is always money. Because they prefer money to humanity. The ones who own slaves always own them because they have money; the poor are sold for money; women are forced to sell their bodies for money; even wars are for money. That's why Fidel in Cuba is trying to suppress money and he says the day will come when money won't exist."

OLIVIA: "Money is the blood of the poor."

WILLIAM: "It's true. Why, in Managua there's even a business that sells the blood of the poor."

I: "It belongs to Somoza in partnership with a Cuban. Its raw material is the poor, who sell a pint of plasma for 35 pesos (five dollars). The blood is sent abroad, where they sell it for a much higher price. With the Vietnam War and the other wars the demand is very great. It's said they're going to open branches in other cities. The company makes several million in annual profits."

CORTAZAR: "In liquid gains. It's a vampire's business."

ALEJANDRO: "Judas saw that Jesus was completely against the system. And then he sees that he can't belong to that movement. Jesus was a revolutionary, and Judas was a reactionary."

*One of Jesus' companions drew his sword
and cut off the ear of the servant of the chief priest.*

I: "John says that the companion was Peter. This reminds me of Indalecio Pastora, who was a guerrilla fighter about fifteen years ago, and was operating in this area, on the opposite bank. He would cut an ear off spies and let them go free (maybe that's the origin of the nickname 'ear'). The first time he did it he sent an ear to the government newspaper, and the paper made a great fuss, horrified, presenting him as a monster of cruelty. In fact he was very humanitarian, since he let them go free. Indalecio is a wonderful person; I later became his friend."

ALEJANDRO: "Could it be then that Peter only wanted to cut off an ear and not that he didn't know how to handle the sword?"

OSCAR CASTILLO: "How nice to have all the spies going around with one ear missing."

OSCAR (the one from Solentiname): "I think Peter really went after him but the other guy ducked. Peter was really very violent. Christ walked humbly, and Peter was like any one of us can be, trying to defend someone who's showing us the good way. So let's say, let's take you for an example right now, that they come to screw you, you know you have your disciples, then,

and that we're not capable of letting you get screwed. So then you scold us. That's the way Peter was, very violent. And he wasn't going to stand there with his arms crossed while they were arresting him. And—I've lost track."

WILLIAM: "It was Peter that they called the 'Terrorist.' "

OSCAR: "Sure, man, we can imagine him here, gosh! And even though you scold us because we won't let you get screwed. You say: No! No! No! Don't interfere here! Leave me be! And you scold us, you let yourself be taken away calmly and let them kill you; then you're showing us what love is."

Then Jesus said to him:

"Put your sword in its scabbard.

*Because those who fight with the sword
will die with the sword."*

I: "This phrase, which others translate, 'he who lives by the sword will die by the sword,' has been used to condemn all violence, including revolutionary violence."

FELIPE: "I think he's indicating another method of fighting: that a new society can be created without our killing each other."

"That's a lot of bullshit. How are we going to bring down Somoza except with swords?"

SERGIO RAMIREZ: "I believe Jesus has chosen his way of struggling, which is his death. He doesn't want others to intervene, preventing him from converting his death into a symbol, that death he has been gradually preparing, as a form of action. And following the parallel with Sandino: when Sandino is captured he

says the same thing. Estrada and Umanzor take out pistols to defend themselves, and he tells them not to, to put down their arms, that they mustn't fight at this moment. And I believe that Sandino also has already chosen his death as a way of struggling."

I: "What do you say, Laureano? I see that you don't seem to like this verse."

LAUREANO: "I don't like it."

I: "Should we erase it, then? Up to now we haven't erased any verse of the Gospels."

OSCAR CASTILLO: "Maybe what happened there was that there was no point in fighting because they were ruined. Not only was he going to die but the others too, all for nothing."

CORTAZAR: "Yes, I agree with what Oscar says, that it was a tactical decision that they had to make at that moment so that the disciples would survive; if not, they would have killed them all. It says here that they left Jesus and fled; if they didn't flee at that moment, all this wouldn't exist today."

SERGIO: "They were in a minority there and they'd have got screwed."

FATHER JAIME, the Colombian priest: "I agree about the tactic. And besides I believe we mustn't try to apply each one of the verses of the Gospels to the situation in which we're living, as if the situation were the same, when at times it can be very different. What he says here about the swords is a practical decision. He's simply telling them: Put them aside."

FELIPE: "I wasn't saying that weapons were bad; I was saying that Jesus had shown another way of struggling, the way of love. And this method, revolutionaries can use it even though they're armed. They're really waging a war so there won't be any more wars."

They want a society in which people won't kill each other."

I: "Once I was talking in Berlin, in the University, or rather I was having a dialogue with the public, and among those present was Sergio Ramírez, who is here with us now. And a girl asked me sharply how I could defend armed struggle when Christ had forbidden the use of the sword, and she left the room in anger without waiting for my answer. Before I replied to the public, while they were still translating for me what she had said in German, Sergio Ramírez answered (with a phrase that I have repeated other times, quoting him): 'Christ forbade the sword but not the machine gun.' "

SERGIO: "I don't remember that, but it's very good."

I: "It amused everyone a great deal; but I said that this wasn't a joke but a very theological interpretation. Christ here disapproves of the sword, but not for moral reasons (as Jaime just said) but because it's useless. That doesn't mean that he condemns other weapons, used by other people, in other circumstances. 'He who lives by the sword will die by the sword' means simply: 'if we kill we get killed.' We might also add that the Gospel According to Saint Luke told that at the Last Supper Jesus spoke of enlisting swords, and they told him they had two and he didn't disapprove. And here where they were traveling in hiding there were those two swords, and he knew it. In his version of this passage, Luke also tells that when the police arrived they consulted him: 'Lord, shall we attack with swords?' So it seems that Jesus had not made a clear decision about complete non-violence, at least to his disciples. The fact is that there were just

two swords to confront that squad of guards, and in back of them was the whole Roman Empire. But right here Jesus also gives another reason. Let's read on."

*Don't you know that I could ask my Father,
and he would send me right now
more than twelve legions of angels?
But in that case,
how would the Scriptures be fulfilled
that say that it must happen like this?*

I: "It's rare for Christ to say that he acts in a certain way because it was so prophesied, when the logical thing is to think that it was prophesied because that's the way he was going to do it. Maybe someone can explain it. I have brooded about this at other times and I find no answer to it."

CORTAZAR: "It's a very, very obscure passage that would have to be analyzed in relation to the whole of the Gospels. But it's evident that Jesus' whole life gradually fulfills one after the other all the prophecies that have been made about him; let's say that he is faithful to the prophecies, to a preconceived plan, and so he can't fail to fulfill the last one, which is his death. It would be a contradiction on his part to ask for twelve divisions of angels to come; he can't do it, he doesn't want to do it."

OLIVIA: "I believe that up to a certain point it's like he says, that it had to be fulfilled; but that doesn't mean we should shrug off humanity's problem, that the well-being that ought to be for all of humanity is enjoyed by only a few. We've got to act on our own account."

OSCAR CASTILLO: "I think that is only one more

argument to reinforce the tactical decision that he has made, to convince the Apostles, to tell them: Let things run their course."

SERGIO: "Not that angel business, it seems to me."

OSCAR: "It's a metaphor."

SERGIO: "I think Olivia is right; I think rather that he's telling us that in the struggle we mustn't put all our trust in the angels, that the angels have nothing to do with our struggle for freedom, they're no good."

CORTAZAR: "A very tendentious interpretation, it seems to me."

SERGIO: "He's facing a world situation, the social problem of the earth. Besides I think not even he thought that twelve armies of angels would come, twelve divisions of angels to help him there."

CORTAZAR: "Who knows? At that time angels were very effective, because they frequently intervene in the Bible."

SERGIO: "In the Old Testament, fifteen hundred years before, but not in the New."

CORTAZAR: "I'm not so sure about the New, but in the Old their effectiveness is proven."

SERGIO: "The situation of the Jewish people was different; those military angels of the Old Testament were no longer in existence, and they were occupied by the Romans just as Puerto Rico is occupied, just as Nicaragua was under an army of occupation in 1927. And Christ knew that the Roman legions couldn't fight against legions of angels. It was something that made no sense."

FATHER JAIME: "I find a great similarity with the case of the Colombian priest Camilo Torres, who saw that he had to die to awake the revolutionary consciousness of the people, that that was his fate. He

saw, we might say, that his fate was written. As for the angels, I think we would have to try to say in our present vocabulary what was differently expressed in another way.”

FELIPE: “I think it made no sense to have a bunch of angels come, because if a bunch of angels was going to come they should have come at the beginning. But they wouldn’t have done anything, because what Christ wanted was to raise the consciousness of the people, so they would be conscious of their own slavery. And if the angels came to free them, and they didn’t free themselves, they wouldn’t be free.”

I: “The Jesuit scientist Teilhard de Chardin says that the reason there is grief in the world is evolution, that God couldn’t have created a universe without suffering and without death, since he chose to make it by means of evolution. Marx has also said that humanity was forced to pass through various stages of oppression in its evolution (slavery, feudalism, capitalism). And now I see that Christ is saying the same thing. The angels could have come at the beginning, as Felipe says, but then the Scriptures wouldn’t have been fulfilled, which in today’s language is equivalent to saying that the laws of evolution and of history wouldn’t have been fulfilled.”

SARA: “I want to know why Sandino died. I already know that he died to free a people. But we always stop there.”

SERGIO: “Sandino also knew that he had to die. There’s a phrase of his very much like Christ’s phrase: ‘I never thought I would come out of this war alive, but I have always believed the war was necessary.’ He knew that his death was the only thing that could keep his struggle alive.”

SARA: "But they go on dying."

SERGIO: "Sandino's example is very recent. Christ died two thousand years ago, and they still go on dying. But there is Christianity and Sandinism."

SARA: "But that's where we always wind up!"

I: "Sandino knew he had to die so that certain Scriptures would be fulfilled, and Che knew this, too. And it will still be necessary for some time for others to have to die, until the Scriptures are finally fulfilled. But what's interesting is that these Scriptures have also said that the world will have a definitive liberation from all oppression."

OLIVIA: "Even from death."

CORTAZAR (after a silence): "And after this there is nothing to add."

21.

Jesus Before the Sanhedrin

(Matthew 26:57–68)

*Those who arrested Jesus led him before Caiaphas,
the chief of the priests,
where the teachers of the law and the elders were
gathered.*

BOSCO: “This looks like the Military Court that’s operating in Managua.”

WILLIAM: “In this case it had the same functions.”

I: “The Supreme Court, or Sanhedrin, was composed of three groups: the chief priests and other representatives of the priesthood, the legal experts, or scribes, and the elders, or secular rulers. The three groups are mentioned here, indicating that it was a plenary session. There were seventy-one members. Mark adds that ‘all’ were present. They gathered at night, in an emergency session. They had to make haste, condemning Jesus right in the middle of Pass-over, for fear of a riot, and the session was in Caiaphas’ house, and not in the Sanhedrin building. In the Gospel the story of the trial is very brief, but it was a debate that went on all night. None of Jesus’ disciples

were there, and maybe that's why the narrative is very concise. The disciples found out what was said only by hearsay, through some people who were present. Perhaps some of them defended Jesus, but the Gospel doesn't record this. John says that Jesus was earlier taken to the house of the former high priest, Annas. The historian Josephus says that Annas had the joy of seeing raised to the high priesthood his five sons, his son-in-law Caiaphas, and his grandson. It seems that what occurred in Annas' house was a preliminary interrogation. They probably asked Jesus his name, age, profession or trade. That's the way they begin questioning in the Military Court."

"Maybe he answered the same way as Tomás Borge in the Military Court: 'Profession, revolutionary.' "

*The chief priests, the elders,
and the whole Supreme Court
were seeking some accusation against Jesus,
even though it was false,
to condemn him to death.*

The Costa Rican poet MAYRA JIMENEZ: "Not only here in Nicaragua, as our comrade has pointed out, but in many other countries of Latin America the same thing goes on now. Those who are struggling for freedom are taken before courts. Not to judge them and hear their defense but to condemn them. And as they can't accuse them of wanting the freedom of humankind, they seek false charges. They plant weapons in their houses to say they belong to them."

FELIPE: "At that time Christ was all alone. Now there are many Christs being sentenced in many places."

IVAN: "He gave the example and he now has many followers."

*But they found no evidence,
although many people appeared
and told lies against him.*

I: "Jesus has said so many subversive things, how is it that they couldn't find any evidence?"

FELIPE: "It's just that everything that Jesus said was the truth. Even though he was against them, it was the truth, wasn't it? So they couldn't accuse him."

I: "That's right. He was talking in the same vein as the prophets, as the whole Bible. The whole Old Testament was subversive. That's why they couldn't find any evidence."

WILLIAM: "They made it up afterwards, the way they always do. They make it up on the basis of false testimony or they simply torture the prisoners and make them sign a confession."

I: "They couldn't condemn him for being on the side of the poor or against the rich. So they had to invent something. It says here that many people told lies against him. The Gospel doesn't say what things they said against him, but maybe we can imagine them."

JULIO CASTILLA, a laborer from Juigalpa: "Like it happens here. They accuse them of being Communists. It seems to me they were treating Jesus like a Communist."

TERESITA: "It probably was because they'd made the people believe communism was something bad and that's why they were condemning him."

I: "He had given evidence that would now be an

equivalent of communism. But the Bible was communist too. He was talking about the 'kingdom,' and the prophets had described that kingdom as the perfect communist society. So he was in agreement with all the Bible."

ALEJANDRO: "What they might have said is the same as they're now saying, that he was a bandit."

ADAN: "They could have accused him also of being against Caesar and the imperial authorities, right?"

I: "But that couldn't be a crime for them, at least for the nationalists among them. They accused him of that later before Pilate, but here they were judging him in their religious council and they couldn't accuse him of something that was in agreement with the Bible. They had to accuse him as a criminal, just as when they now want to accuse someone of being a Communist, they accuse that person of being a criminal or a bandit. They want to make people believe, as Tere-sita says, that being a Communist is being a criminal, a murderer, and a bandit. Well, that's probably what they were saying about Jesus, but they had no proof. They may have accused him also of leading an evil life. Earlier in the Gospel we've seen that the Pharisees spoke against him because he went around with sinners and prostitutes. So they probably poked into his private life. But it says here they had no proof."

But finally two false witnesses came forward, and they said:

"This man said:

'I can destroy the temple of God, and raise it again in three days.' "

I: "So they accuse him on account of the temple. He had just taken over the temple, as we saw last Sunday.

He went into the temple in a commando action, and they're probably referring to that in the trial. But they couldn't really accuse him of that, of driving out the merchants. He had done this by citing the Bible prophets. They couldn't accuse him of purifying the temple of those corruptions. So they accuse him of trying to destroy the temple."

FELIPE: "Those people were like many people today who give more importance to a house than to a human being. They were giving a lot of importance to that house, that temple, which is like saying this church, as though that was ruining the people. There are others who are ruining the people and killing people and they don't accuse those people of anything. Let's suppose Jesus wasn't going to destroy that house, but Jesus was opposed to the idea of giving more importance to houses than to people's bodies. Jesus was fighting against that, just like Marx was, who struggled for humanity and not for a house."

I: "Why, yes, and here the witnesses may be telling something of the truth, right? Because they couldn't condemn him for liberating the poor, but they find this crime, that he was against the temple, which for them was the most sacred thing. And they were right about that, because he was against the temple, and the earliest Christians had no temples. Where they were wrong was in saying he was going to destroy it like a terrorist. He put an end to it without any need of setting it on fire."

MAYRA: "He called into question the image of God that they had at that time, and still have, and that serves the system; this is exactly the temple image. All the accusations made in societies of exploitation against the image of Christ are that same one, of wanting to destroy the temple. But temple meaning not

only the religious one but also the temples of banking and power.”

I: “He was really coming to destroy religion. Because when the Samaritan woman asked him which of the two temples was the true one, that of Israel or that of Samaria, he told her neither of the two, that God would be adored in spirit and in truth, that is, people were going truly to love God in a society of love. God as love among people, and no longer the image of God held by the religions, the Jewish and the Samaritan and all the other pagan religions. This they *could* accuse him of. And the words quoted by those witnesses could easily have been said by him when he drove out the merchants.”

OSCAR: “Ernesto, I think they misunderstood, because it seemed to them it was the temple, the church, that Christ said he was going to destroy and rebuild in three days, but it seems to me that what he meant there was that he could build that temple in three days, and it was the whole world. With his death and his resurrection he was going to build it, or rather, that the world was going to change. That’s the way I understand it.”

Then the chief priest rose and said to Jesus:

“Have you no answer?

What is it that they say against you?”

But Jesus said nothing.

I: “Why do you suppose he kept quiet?”

BOSCO: “Hell, because it was true.”

I: “They put him between the devil and the deep blue sea. He couldn’t say: it isn’t true, I do not come to destroy the temple, I am religious.”

BOSCO: “He could have defended himself by saying

that he wasn't coming to destroy the temple as a terrorist, setting fire to it, that he was coming to make a temple out of each person."

I: "The way they accuse us here of terrorism, or that we're fomenting violence in the church, and we answer that we're making the revolution but in another way. We don't defend ourselves like that."

ADAN: "Or maybe that he was against the Jewish religion and against Caesar too, because after all it was serving Caesar too, like the religions of today."

I: "That's true. They made the two accusations, the religious accusation before this court, and the political one before the court of Pilate. It was really the same one, proclaiming himself the messiah, which for them was a religious crime and at the same time a political one, because the messiah had to be the king. Just as against us they can make an accusation at the same time religious and political. They did it to us when the Head of Customs in Managua sent a telegram to all the customs houses in the country forbidding the importing of the first volume of our *The Gospel in Solentiname*, because it was a very harmful book that 'by means of the Gospel tries to preach communism to the people.' "

Then the chief priest said to him:

"In the name of the living God,

I put you under oath to tell the truth.

Tell us if you are the Christ, the Son of God."

Jesus said to him:

"Yes, I am, as you have said."

FELIPE: "He couldn't keep quiet any longer. He couldn't say he wasn't the messiah."

I: "I think that when he was silent about the temple

he was letting them know it was true and that's why Caiaphas asked him if he was the Christ, which in Greek means 'messiah.' The accusation about the temple was an accusation that he was claiming to be the messiah or Son of God."

BOSCO: "He had already accepted his death as one way of fighting, because he knew he had to die, and that's why he didn't avoid that question. He knew that was how far he had come."

I: "And then later he tells Pilate: I'm the king. Before then he hadn't wanted them to call him Christ in public or to proclaim him king."

BOSCO: "Did they give you a Bible to swear on? Did they make you swear when you went to the Military Court?"

I: "You swear but not with the Bible."

WILLIAM: "At first he told them to be quiet for tactical reasons, but now he knows he's already condemned, and those tactics are no good now. That's why he tells them: Yes, I'm the liberator."

NATALIA: "The same thing happened to Christ as happened to Che: he died, but he didn't die; he's always up ahead of us."

I: "He knew that his freedom was going to come after his death and because of his death, like the case of Che that Natalia mentions and of all who die for freedom. The Jews believed that in the messianic era there would be a new temple, a heavenly sanctuary that would descend upon the earth. After declaring that he is the messiah, Jesus continues speaking."

*And I also tell you that you will see
the Son of Man seated at the right hand of Al-
mighty God,
and coming on the clouds of heaven.*

“That means he was going to come as a judge, and judge in the Bible was the same as liberator: one who was coming to liberate the oppressed and take revenge on their oppressors. And the cloud bit is that he’s going to come also as God. The cloud is an image always associated with God in the Bible. And whenever the prophets announced a liberation of the people (and the punishment of their oppressors) they described God as coming among clouds to make a ‘judgment.’ So Jesus is saying that he is the messiah and that he is coming to establish justice on earth. He is also alluding to the Book of Daniel, in which is described the vision of a mysterious person ‘like a son of man,’ who comes among the clouds of heaven to be king of all the earth.”

BOSCO: “You could interpret that coming as all the people now united—right?—who are going to judge the oppressors.”

I: “Yes, for we’ve already commented other times on this second coming, and we’ve seen that it will be the establishing of a just society, and the people themselves will do that.”

FELIPE: “A people now aware and transformed, right? Because a people without awareness can’t do a thing.”

I: “He’s telling them: I’m going to come like a people, like a whole community that will establish the kingdom of God on earth.”

ESPERANZA: “Ernesto, that makes me think of what lots of people say: What can people do, nothing! You’ve got to wait for Christ, for Christ to come and judge. That’s the way lots of people think it will happen and that’s the way we understood it here, at least I did: only when we see him come. And many people stick to that, saying what are guerrilla fighters going

to be able to do, or anyone else? Only Christ will do it.”

MAYRA: “And it occurs to me, Ernesto, that clouds have a lot to do with humidity, and humidity in ancient religions is always identified with fecundity and the origin of everything, and that Christ here is not only projecting himself toward the future but he is also going back into the past and he appears as the beginning of the fecundity of the universe and the origin of everything.”

*Then the chief priest tore his robes
as a sign of indignation, and said:
“This man has blasphemed.
What need have we of more witnesses?”*

I: “In former times the Jews had been accustomed to tear their clothes as a sign of grief. At the time of Christ the Pharisees preserved that custom only in religious matters: they tore their clothes when they heard anything offensive to God. The Last Judgment was reserved to God, and that was the ‘blasphemy.’ Besides, Jesus, who had identified himself with the poor, was at the same time identifying himself with God. And he was saying that the poor person, the working person, was God. And for those who have a different concept of God, this continues to be a blasphemy. That was indeed a very serious crime, to say that God was a worker. Through the Bible they knew that a messiah was going to come. But that this should be the messiah, this person that came to cast doubts on their religion, to take away their privileges, to change the state of affairs, that they could not accept.”

FELIPE: “A lot of people think now too that the rev-

olution is against God, because they identify God with the system.”

*“You have heard his blasphemies,
what do you think?”*

They said: “He is guilty and he must die.”

Then they spat on his face and they struck him.

I: “The ‘what do you think’ means that they now proceeded to the voting. According to Luke the trial didn’t end until some time in the morning. It must have been after the trial ended that they started to beat him.”

MAYRA: “Nowadays when somebody is fighting for the people, they’re also condemned to death. But before that they’re subjected to many humiliations and tortures. There are many techniques for that.”

IVAN: “It’s important, it seems to me, to see the risks they run.”

GLORIA: “It’s tough to be a Christian, because anybody who’s a Christian has to be ready for all that, those tortures. It’s nice to say that I’m a Christian, but as for the rest. . . .”

WILLIAM: “The ones on the Supreme Council were for God, they were for the Bible, but they weren’t for any revolution. Many Christians now are also for those who condemned Jesus, right in the same camp with the Supreme Council. They’re the ones that aren’t for the revolution, the ones that condemn it.”

22.

Peter Denies Jesus

(Matthew 26:69–75)

We were in the meeting hut. We had had a lunch of rice and beans and turtle eggs with chile sauce and slices of fried shark, a shark that the Altamiranos had caught that morning in their nets. A brother of David Tejada was with us. In Nicaragua everybody knows the name of David Tejada, the young man from the Sandinista National Liberation Front who was brutally murdered in prison and then thrown into the boiling lava of the crater of the Masaya volcano.

I introduced David Tejada's brother. And I told how, in a Managua radio studio on a Friday in Lent, I had made a recording, later broadcast on Good Friday, in which I denounced the tortures and crimes that were committed in the jails and I said that while they were all carrying the statue of Christ through the streets in the procession of the Way of the Cross, the living Christ was suffering that Way of the Cross in the jails. Some time later I learned from some reporters that at the very hour in which I was recording those words on that Lenten Friday they were killing David Tejada.

*Meanwhile Peter was sitting out in the courtyard and a servant came up to him and said:
“You also were with Jesus of Galilee.”
But Peter denied it in front of everybody,
saying: “I don’t know what you’re talking about.”*

1: “The ‘meanwhile’ means that while they were judging Jesus inside and afterwards while they were beating him Peter was denying him outside. The Nicaraguan Church was also doing the same thing with David Tejada while they were beating him with rifle butts and with steel chains. Shortly before that my bishop had forbidden me to write political articles and so I later wrote an article entitled “I Am Not Guilty of the Death of David Tejada,” implying that they were accomplices, the ones that could have spoken but kept silent, and I said that, at the washing of hands in the Mass, they could no longer recite the phrase from the Psalms: ‘I shall wash my hands among the innocent.’ ”

“Peter had done a lot of swaggering around. He felt he was pretty brave with the sword but when the moment came to offer up his life, he was a coward.”

“I don’t think he did wrong. It was a strategy.”

“If somebody in the Front is questioned, they don’t confess.”

“Yes, maybe he wasn’t a coward but acted like a revolutionary because if he surrendered there he wouldn’t have carried out what Christ had entrusted to him.”

“It seems to me he’s doing the same as Jesus, who hadn’t wanted to declare in public that he was the Christ, because that was very dangerous. Only at the end did he declare himself the Christ.”

I: "But the Gospel doesn't seem to approve of this denial by Peter, as you approve of it. It says that afterwards he wept bitterly."

"Ernesto, it seems to me the boys are right. Peter denied knowing Jesus so as not to betray his leader. He saw that they'd arrested him, but he thought maybe they weren't going to kill him, and he denied everything so they couldn't get anything out of him. But when Peter saw that it was no use, that they were going to screw Jesus, he wept."

"He wept because Jesus had told him he was going to deny him three times, but he hadn't told him whether that was going to be good or bad, and that's why he wept because what Jesus had told him had come true."

"He wept because earlier he'd felt very brave, and Jesus had told him: you'll see that you yourself are going to deny me. And he'd seen that when the moment of truth came he was scared. But it's a fact that he didn't do any harm when he denied him because he wouldn't do any good by surrendering."

"So then Jesus Christ didn't do any good either by surrendering?"

"He was already very leftist. And he didn't surrender; they arrested him. The others they hardly knew. They're saying that maybe Peter's one of them just by his way of talking."

"And what do you suppose he was saying that they'd say: it's his way of talking? Because he was a fool! He was probably talking in revolutionary terms, in Christian terms."

I: "By his way of talking they knew he was a Galilean. But Galilean to them was the same as revolutionary. Galilee was the place where rebellions and guerilla warfare sprang up."

"He denied Jesus because he was afraid, and he was afraid because he didn't believe in him."

"I still don't believe it was through fear."

"I say it was not through fear."

I: "If not fear, why did he do it?"

"It wasn't through fear but because he understood there was no point in letting himself be killed just like that at that moment. Look, you're mixed up in a revolutionary movement, and some security police come and say to you: You're a revolutionary. Are you going to say yes to them?"

"You were with Carlos Fonseca."

"Well, what I'd say is: No, man, God forbid I'd get mixed up in that."

"Yes, I'm with Laureano. Remember, Oscar, that when you were in San Carlos with some spies, you said: Long live Somoza!"

"But there comes a time when you have to tell the truth."

"Yes, sure, if they're going to kill me, sure. If I'm already caught. 'You were mixed up in the Front.' Son of a bitch! Caught there. 'You were with so and so and what's his name.' 'Well, yes, I am. And you're the son of a bitch that's going to kill me.' Now that's what I call coming clean."

"But if you can get away you ought to."

"He had an out. The proof is that he got out of it. It's not the same as if your back's to the wall and you're shouting 'Long live Sandino! Long live Nicaragua! Go on, kill me.' "

"But the Gospel shows this like a weakness in Peter. There's got to be some other explanation for what he did, updating it of course with what's happening in Nicaragua, to be able to understand it."

I: "The other time, when we were talking of Judas'

betrayal, we had seen that it seemed it wasn't due just to money but that he'd become disillusioned with Christ. Nowadays Peter's denial is also interpreted as disappointment in the cause of Christ. When he announced his Passion, Christ had said: 'Happy is he who does not become disappointed in me!' And that same night he had just said to the disciples after the supper: 'All of you will lose your faith in me tonight.' We've already seen that the name of Peter, not Simon Bar-Jonah, as we used to think, but Simon the Terrorist, shows that he was a zealot. Peter had tried to dissuade Jesus from his Passion. He believed in a triumphant messiah but not in a suffering messiah that was letting himself be killed. At the supper Jesus had also expressly told Peter that he has prayed for him so that he won't lose faith, lose faith in Jesus as the messiah, in his liberation. And when Peter denies Jesus, what he's really doing is turning his back on the cause of Jesus."

"Peter was violent. He wanted Jesus to defend himself and when he saw him surrendering so meekly he got sore."

"And he was used to being brave. He was the bravest one in the whole group. He'd wanted to use his sword and when he saw that in spite of being brave he hadn't been able to follow Jesus, that's when he wept."

"But if he didn't want to have anything more to do with that cause, what was he doing there?"

"He wanted to keep faith with Jesus right up to his death."

"Maybe he was wavering."

"You've got me all confused."

"It seems to me, Ernesto, that if somebody gets disillusioned about a movement, the leader can say that

he'll mess it all up. That's what Jesus told Peter when he told him he was going to deny him three times."

"It was just fear."

"No, it wasn't, man."

"He was scared there. You know why? Because he saw himself all alone, surrounded by a bunch of bastards. Besides he felt guilty because he'd cut the ear off one of those sons of bitches."

"We're talking about stupid things. What's important is that Christ had promised to come back to life in three days. The lesson is that we ought to follow Christ, and right up to death."

"Die for the kingdom. And believe that even if you die you go on living."

"Love is hard. Peter didn't know that love leads you to give yourself over. He found out later that love leads you to die and that, after all, dying is living more."

23.

Jesus Before Pilate

(John 18:28-40 and 19:1-16)

*The Jews did not go into the palace
in order not to become impure,
for then they could not eat the Passover meal.*

“They have scruples about entering a pagan house, but they have no scruples about taking Jesus there to be condemned to death. All they worried about was eating their Passover meal without ‘sin.’ ”

“The same thing happens nowadays. The rich are the most religious class.”

“They have scruples, from certain dimwits, about taking communion, but they have no scruples about exploiting, about killing innocent people with their exploitation.”

“It was people very conscientious about their religious duties that killed Jesus.”

“The charge they bring against him is that he was stirring up the people. I remember what General Somoza said a short while ago in his San Carlos speech, when he was on his electoral campaign: Don’t let yourselves get fooled in Solentiname. He said that because he knows that here something good is developing.”

“Well, Solentiname is much on his mind now; before, he never mentioned Solentiname, as I remember. And now why is he talking to us in Solentiname? Why does he keep referring to Solentiname?”

“Because he knows Solentiname is coming out of obscurity, you see? That now you can’t be fooled here very easily. The fact that he has mentioned this is an announcement of something.”

“Well, that he’s going to screw us.”

“That was a political speech, once he said it he forgot it.”

*Pilate came back into the palace,
summoned Jesus and asked him:*

“Are you the king of the Jews?”

I: “They condemned Jesus for having declared himself the messiah. Pilate didn’t care about that; for him it had something to do with the religion of the Jews; so they have to present that to Pilate as a political crime, because he was coming to change the world. In their court, which was a religious court, they had condemned him for religious crimes because he had declared himself the Son of God. Before the civil court they accuse him of having proclaimed himself king. It’s like saying he’s coming to make a revolution.”

“Pilate was something like the gringo ambassador here.”

Jesus said to him:

*“Do you ask this on your own account,
or because others have said this to you about me?”*

I: “He asks him this before answering him, and what he wants to tell Pilate is that it depends on what

he understands by 'king': if he understands it as the Romans understand it, or as the Jews understand it. King as the Romans understand it he is not. King, messiah, as the Jews understand it, one who comes to change the world, that he is."

Pilate answered him:

"Am I perchance a Jew?

*Those of your nation and the chief priests
are the ones who delivered you to me.*

What have you done?"

Then Jesus answered:

"My kingdom is not of this world.

*If it were, my followers would have fought
so that I would not be turned over to the Jews.*

But my kingdom is not here."

A Spanish priest who is visiting us: "He is telling him that his kingdom is not political. He tells him: Be calm, for I'm not against Rome. My mission is another direction."

I: "He's telling him that his kingdom is political, but not with an army. You have to know what the word 'world' means in St. John's Gospel: it means sin, the world of injustice, the established order that we now call 'the system.' A little earlier, at the Supper, Jesus has told his apostles that they are 'in the world but are not of the world,' which was like saying they were in the system but not part of it. The proof that Jesus gives to Pilate, that his kingdom is not of 'this world,' is that his followers have not fought to keep him from becoming a prisoner; but that's not a proof to show that his kingdom is not of this life or that it's not political. His kingdom was political but of a different order

of politics. It wasn't political in the sense of the politics of that time; if it had been it would also have been a slave kingdom, and his kingdom was a revolution."

"It seems to me that if he had assured Pilate that his kingdom was not political but 'spiritual,' Pilate wouldn't have condemned him. But Pilate was not reassured. He asked again."

"So you're a king?"

Jesus answered:

"I'm a king, as you say.

I was born for this

and for this I came into the world,

to say what is the truth.

All those who obey the truth

listen to what I say."

The Spanish visitor: "I think he's telling him again: Be calm, I'm not moving in that direction. My kingdom is not like those kingdoms of yours, we're not going to fight against Rome. It seems to me the answer he gives Pilate is very open and simple, but nowadays we want to interpret every word of Scripture as we choose."

"If he'd told Pilate clearly that he doesn't meddle in politics, he's only preaching a religious doctrine so that people will go to heaven, Pilate wouldn't have condemned him. But he declares himself king, which is the same as declaring himself subversive."

OLIVIA: "It seems to me that when they heard 'kingdom' all they thought of was a kingdom of injustice like their own kingdom, and he's telling them that their kingdom is a kingdom of love. But that didn't suit them either, the kingdom of love, because love is

against injustice; and that's why the powerful still go on being against this kingdom of love; this revolution of love; they always fight against it because it doesn't suit them. For them, the kingdom of love is subversion."

"The kingdom of God is liberty, and all the other kingdoms are oppression. That's why he has to make a distinction; that's why he says his kingdom's not part of that system."

I: "But he was coming to change the whole system, not just to shake off Roman domination (that wouldn't have been a true revolution). And his doctrine was not only coming to put an end to the slave system but also an end to feudalism and capitalism, and he's even going later to put an end to socialism, which isn't the most perfect system in humanity, until he creates the most perfect one, and that will be his kingdom."

RAUL: "I don't believe Christ's death was just a misunderstanding of Pilate and that his revolution was just 'spiritual,' as they've tried to picture it to us. The proof is that afterwards they persecuted the Christians just as much."

I: "His position was not that of the zealots, the guerilla fighters of that time, that's clear. But they were accusing him before Pilate of being a zealot, and he preferred the confusion of considering him a zealot (and condemning him to death for it) to the confusion of considering his kingdom purely spiritual, apolitical, not revolutionary."

OLIVIA: "He says he's a king, and that he came into the world to tell the truth, so his kingdom is certainly in this world, but it's the kingdom of truth, which is to

say, justice, and the opposite of exploitation, deception, what people do to other people."

FELIPE: "There's another interpretation of the Gospel which is purely individualistic and leaves out the great deceptions that humanity suffers, and is concerned only with the private life of each person. And it doesn't notice the fact that the world is divided between bosses and workers."

GUSTAVO: "That religion is opium, because it keeps you asleep or seeing illusions, ghosts."

RAUL: "On the contrary, Christ's mission was to bring truth to the earth. He says to Pilate: 'I am a king, and my political order is to put an end to lying and exploitation; my followers are all those who struggle for the transformation of the world.' "

"And why does he say: 'All those who obey the truth'? As though the truth was in charge. Or is the truth a law?"

I: "Truth is the law of love. Jesus brought that truth; it's the incarnation of the commandment of love. That's why he says to Pilate: 'I was born for this.' And at the Supper he said: 'I am the truth.' "

"He says all those who obey the truth listen to what he says. That's funny. It seems it ought to be the opposite: those who listen to what he says obey. Obey the commandment of love."

"But it's not like that. He himself is the commandment of love. And he doesn't say that those who listen to him, the Christians, live in accordance with love, he says the opposite, that those who live in accordance with love, those are his followers."

"He tells Pilate that he's king and that he came to tell what the truth is. It would seem there's nothing in

common between being king and telling what the truth is. But they'll have a lot in common, his kingdom and the truth."

I: "The organization of a just society, that's the truth of humanity. Christ came to tell what the truth is, what justice is; and that justice will be his reign."

Pilate said to him: "And what is truth?"

And he went out again to speak with the Jews.

"He asked and turned around to leave. He didn't wait for the answer."

"Like those who say: 'And what's the revolution?' They're all alike, all stupid."

"He asked what was truth, and he turned his back on truth, because if he'd faced the truth, he'd have had to resign that position he had, which was something like the American ambassador."

*"Do you want me to release to you
the king of the Jews?"*

And they all cried:

"Not that one!

Release Barabbas!"

And Barabbas was a bandit.

I: "Luke adds that this Barabbas was in jail because of a rebellion. He was clearly a guerrilla fighter. And Pilate clearly understands that Jesus' crime is the same kind. He proposes to exchange one subversive for another. At that time the government called guerrilla fighters bandits, just like now. That's the way we must understand the word 'criminal' as applied to Jesus.

Even the Roman historian Tacitus, writing a few years later, says in his *History of Rome* that Jesus was a man that Pontius Pilate condemned as a ‘criminal.’ ”

“But the Jewish upper class considers Jesus more subversive than the other one; they prefer to see Barabbas released.”

“That Barabbas couldn’t have had very clear ideas. And the upper class sees that Jesus’ revolution is quite complete.”

“If he’d said his revolution was inward or that he was coming to have rich and poor alike converted, not a damned thing would have happened to him.”

I: “Like that Protestant biblical magazine that’s around here, very attractive (they won’t ban it, it’s not subversive). It says the world is full of injustice, and that the Bible is against injustice, which is true; but afterwards it says the boss must check whether he’s unjust toward the worker, and the worker whether he’s unjust toward the boss.”

MANUEL (laughing): “How is Jesus going to say the worker is unjust toward the boss?”

“They think the work belongs to the boss, as in the time of Jesus Christ they thought the person belonged to the master; if the slave escaped, it was unfair, because he was stealing himself from his owner.”

MANUEL: “Oh, they had them all counted.”

*Then Pilate ordered Jesus to be whipped.
On his head the soldiers placed a crown of thorns,
and they covered him with a purple mantle
and they went up to him saying:
“Long live the King of the Jews!”
And they kept hitting him in the face.*

“They were making fun of Jesus, right? And Jesus really was a king, except that he didn’t wear king’s clothes; he wore the clothes of the workers of that time.”

“He was a poor person’s king.”

“He had come to be the king of the poor and humiliated of the earth, and when they put that rag on him to make fun of him, and they hit him, there he is in his true role as king of all the poor, the humiliated, the beaten, the tortured.”

“In Managua they cover them with a hood so they can’t see who’s beating them. Like they said to Christ: ‘Guess who beat you.’ The thorn business is now more refined, like the electric shock. In the North they take *campesinos* up in helicopters and drop them in the mountains.”

“He was a king, but not like those kings those guards knew, and that’s why they thought it was funny to see him like that. He was the king of the people oppressed by the kings. He was *our* king.”

“But it seems that Pilate suspected he might be dangerous. Because the Gospel says he was afraid.”

The Jews said to him:

“We have a law,

and according to our law he must die,

because he has made himself the Son of God.”

When Pilate heard this he was more afraid.

He went back into the palace and asked Jesus:

“Where are you from?”

PANCHO: “I think he thought maybe Jesus was divine, but what he was really afraid of was losing his

job, because he was earning a pile of money there.”

MANUEL: “Or maybe he thought he came from some other country.”

LAUREANO: “I think instead that what he wanted to tell him was: So where you come from, you’re a poor man, son of a carpenter. You’re not a son of a millionaire or anything, so you’re not a son of the upper class, then.”

I: “The question might have had another purpose also. Galilee was a center of rebellion, and there was always armed struggle there. A few years before, when Jesus was a child, a great rebellion had been suppressed in Galilee, and two thousand revolutionaries had been crucified. And Jesus came from Galilee.”

But Jesus gave him no answer.

“Simply because he knew his Father had ordered him to die.”

“And if Pilate’s question was intended to imply that he belonged to the zealots, maybe Jesus preferred to be silent rather than speak against the zealots.”

Then Pilate said to him:

“You do not answer me?

*Don’t you know I have the authority to crucify
you*

and I have the authority to set you free?”

Jesus answered him:

“You would have no authority over me

if God had not given it to you;

that’s why the one who handed me over to you

is guilty of a greater sin than you.”

OLIVIA: "That one that handed him over for money. He was guiltier because he knew him. Like who knows Ernesto better than we do? If we hand him over we're guiltier than the guy that's going to kill him."

PANCHO: "And he tells Pilate that he wouldn't have any power if it hadn't been given to him from above. So he means he'd been given power from above."

ALEJANDRO: "But he was unjust. You can give power from above, but it's just, not unjust."

RAUL: "Christ tells him power comes to him from above, when Pilate was thinking it was coming from Rome."

ALEJANDRO: "But it turns out that God is love, and he wasn't acting according to love."

RAUL: "To say that power comes from God is the same as saying it comes from the people. And you can't use it just as you please. Jesus tells him he's sinned, making it clear that he's not the biggest sinner."

ALEJANDRO: "Well, he was one more cog in the machinery, in a system that was opposed to love. The system is the greatest sinner."

"He was coming to establish a society of brothers and sisters that didn't then exist, and it doesn't exist now. Pilate, by killing him, is much to blame, like any colonel that orders an innocent person killed. But the others, who knew the message, it was the messiah they were rejecting; it was because of hatred of change."

I: "Reactionaries often refer to this phrase, 'all authority comes from God.' This is like saying that it comes from the people, as Raúl says. All authority, but not all abuse of authority. The revolution, when it comes, is also an authority. It's the authentic authority

of the people as opposed to the false authority of those who abuse power. Since the revolution is an authority, it comes from God."

The chief priests said to him:

"We have no other king but Caesar."

FELIPE: "It's the chief priests, not the people. Like now, it's a little group of sons-of-bitches who are part of the system. The ones that loved Jesus didn't have any voice or vote at that time; and they don't have one now."

I: "The upper class was also oppressed by Rome, and they didn't really like Caesar. But they preferred to accept foreign control as long as they could kill the liberation, which is Jesus; they prefer dictatorship to the messianic kingdom. The Caesar was Tiberius, the cruelest emperor that Rome ever had."

*And so Pilate turned him over to them to be crucified,
and they took him away.*

"Christ's death is really the death of the opposition, the way members of the opposition die now; he was opposed to a system and he died the way so many dissidents die now, tortured and massacred."

"Like many others in Vietnam, or Nicaragua, he was accused of being a Communist, an agitator, a dangerous person, a revolutionary leader who was stirring up the people."

"And Pilate washes his hands: 'Me not know nothin', me no mix in your politics. Me innocent.' "

I: "Crucifixion was the Roman punishment for political crimes. Jesus had repeatedly spoken of his death on the cross; and what he was saying was that he was going to be condemned by the Romans as a subversive. He knew it had to be that way."

"And the chief priests went off to their homes to eat their Passover meal without 'sin.' "

Someone asked Julio Ramón: "And you, why don't you say something?"

He answered: "The people don't need these religious commentaries; they need action."

His brother ALEJANDRO: "It's stupid to talk like that; you don't talk because you're timid. We've not been talking about religion but about everything. I've learned a lot in today's commentary. There are very important things I didn't know before, and now I know."

24.

The Crucifixion

(Luke 23:26-49)

Good Friday. In church, at three in the afternoon, in suffocating heat. We are in the worst of the dry season, which is called “summer” here. No breeze blows, not a leaf moves, and the lake is as still as though it were a stone. All around us all the vegetation is dry or withered. Farther off the fields appear black, charred, because they’ve been burned for future crops, when the rains come. In the air there’s a burnt smell.

*When they were taking Jesus to crucify him,
they grabbed a man from Cyrene called Simon,
who was coming from the fields,
and they made him pick up the cross
and carry it behind Jesus.*

FRANCISCO: “A privilege for that man.”

“Would he take it as a privilege? He’s coming from the fields, he’s coming from work, and he’s going home to lunch. It was three in the afternoon. And they force him to carry the cross.”

"Of course he didn't want to do it. But even though he grumbled and everything, it was a privilege."

"He was out working, he wasn't coming from a party. He was coming from the fields."

"Yes, it says there clearly that he was coming from the fields, he was coming from work."

"Simon of Cyrene, he may have been going to do some errand, maybe, and he saw all that there and he said to himself: I'll just have a look."

"Here we see the situation of injustice that there was then; somebody that has nothing to do with it has to lug the cross. The same injustice as now, but it's clearer here: a guy that's coming from working in the fields has to lug the cross of Jesus."

I said that in history there have been many cases like that. Many people who have been obliged to help Jesus with his cross, who have had that privilege, as Francisco says.

"It seems to me he was a very peaceful man, and it's easier to take advantage of those. If he was strong and somewhat timid, well they imposed on him to lug it."

"I see a relationship between the worker carrying his cross and that other farm worker that was called to help him. I don't know if he'd go because he had to, by force, or if he'd go willingly. But you might suppose he'd go willingly, if he had any knowledge of what Jesus was, of his message. Anyway, it's a very symbolic picture: the worker and the farmer accompanying him, taking part in his tragedy."

I said that in the Gospel According to Saint Mark there is the added detail that this Simon was the father "of Alexander and of Rufus," two names that must have been known to the first Christian community.

"But they forced him. It says: 'They made him pick

up the cross.' It's like, for example, when some guards are taking you away—right—and they say to another man, come help us handle this shitty prisoner. They're forcing you to help them because if you don't help them they screw you."

"But it was also because they saw he was lower class. If he'd been Mr. High and Mighty they wouldn't call him; they'd call someone else, someone as screwed as the one they were taking away. That's why they screwed that guy."

"An arbitrary action. Like so many that they've been committing against the *campesinos* for so long."

*Many people were following him
and many women who were crying and shouting
with sorrow.*

"Because here his people were really following him. It wasn't only the Pharisees and the priests; the people were there, who had always followed him."

"It was only then that the people could get in touch with him, because around Pilate they wouldn't let the people get close; the people were kept outside. But now they're really with him. And it says 'they were shouting'; I bet they were shouting at the guards: 'sons of bitches' or something like that, and maybe Simon, who was in the field, realized they were going to kill Jesus and he came, and maybe gave a shout and a guard said: 'Hey, you, you carry the cross.' Maybe that's the way it was."

I: "At least, given the circumstances of Nicaragua, that's the way it would be here, right?"

"They give you a whack."

"There were a lot of people who loved him. And

especially the women. He was their liberator and in his passion they were faithful to him."

I: "Those women were revolutionaries, and that's why they got involved and supported him. And among them was his mother, the most revolutionary of them all. It was she who had said during her pregnancy: 'The powerful will be toppled from their thrones and the humble will be exalted, the hungry will be filled with good things and the rich will be left without a thing.' She was a revolutionary and a communist before Jesus was born. Those ideas she had received from the prophets of the Bible. And those ideas Jesus sucked in with her milk. She shaped him, she influenced him, she contributed greatly to his being what he was and to his meeting the end that he did."

"But the devotions to Mary give a different image of her, an image that wouldn't please her at all."

"Because those songs they have written to her are quite horrible. She surely wouldn't like them."

"They give the image of a very rich and very powerful lady who gives alms to poor children."

"They seem to be written for a First Lady, for Lady Somoza."

Turning to them Jesus said:

"Women of Jerusalem,

do not weep for me,

weep for yourselves and your children.

Because a day will come when it will be said:

'Happy are the mothers without children,

the women who did not give birth or breast to suck.' "

MARIITA: "Well, those women were people that understood him, that is, they understood his sacrifice, and afterwards they also were going to be ready to surrender, they and their children. So that the same thing would happen to them as happened to him. And maybe he himself said to himself: you weep and maybe you don't know you're going to suffer the same fate, and that they're going to kill you, too. Because there wasn't any justice. Everybody was in a bad way."

I: "What you say is very good, Mariíta. He saw the state of oppression the world was in at that time, and that liberation wasn't easy, that cruelty was going to go on for a long time, and that there was going to have to be suffering for a long time. His death he has accepted, he himself sought it, as he said; and he thinks they shouldn't lament so much for him as for themselves and their children. Above all he is foreseeing the sufferings that the Romans were going to cause in Jerusalem. Many, many young people were going to rise up and they would be sentenced like Jesus. The Wailing Wall is still in existence, where Jews go to bewail the ruin of Jerusalem."

*Because if they do all this with the green tree,
what will they not do when it is dry?*

LAUREANO: "He's making fun of them."

"Why do you say that he's making fun of them, Laureano?"

"He's making fun of them. He's telling them that they are dry and that he is green."

"He's distinguishing between two kinds of wood.

He who has life in him, he has sap. He's a live tree. Others are just wood fit for a fire. But it's not that he's making fun of them. He's telling them that if they do this to the Son of God, what won't they do to the others, to the poor."

"That's what I think, he's comparing himself here with a green tree, which is stronger than a dry one; and if they're so unjust to him, well, after his death, what won't they do. And right here he's seeing the injustice they're doing to him and to the others: to him that they're killing, and to the guy beside him that's all tired out. The guy that comes exhausted from the fields, all pooped, they set him to carrying the cross, another injustice. So if at the same time that he's dying they're doing so much injustice, how will it be afterwards? It's something so common, committing injustice. It's something so easy to do."

I: "In modern times some people give it this interpretation: that he is saying that if this happens to him, who is a pacifist, what won't happen to their children, the young people who were soon going to have recourse to violence against the Romans. 'If they've condemned me, who have not borne arms, as a subversive, what won't they do to your children?' "

"It can also be that he's seeing that he was a tree with many branches. And that when he dies the branches are going to dry up and be easier to burn. Without a leader like him, the movement was going to be more easily destroyed."

"Well, when the sap is dead the tree dries up."

"Lots of people in Holy Week think only about the sufferings of Jesus, and they don't think about the sufferings of so many Christs, of millions of Christs

that exist. And Jesus didn't want them to be wailing for him but to wail for the others that were going to suffer like him or worse than him."

"Still right now there are people that are suffering for the same cause, and maybe they're suffering more than him, because at that time crucifixion was a kind of torture but you died right then and there; now they torture you but they leave you alive."

I: "He's also saying that although he's not a zealot and has never borne arms, his death is for political reasons and they're sentencing him as a subversive. But for many centuries they have ignored the political nature of the death of Jesus."

They also were taking two criminals to kill together with Jesus.

I: "Criminals, as we already know, are the zealots, the guerrilla fighters. We also know that the cross was the torture for subversives, and that's why Jesus was crucified with them. Many people who wear a cross on their chests don't know what that cross means. It's clear that he was not a guerrilla fighter, and that's why he makes that distinction between green wood and dry wood, but in the eyes of the authorities there was no distinction. Because *subversive* he certainly was."

"I've heard that in some readings it's said, though it's not in the Bible, that those thieves stole things from well-off people to give to the poor, like the Tupamaro guerrillas in Uruguay."

I: "These people were outside the law. To support themselves in the country maybe they had to attack private property and commit what is usually called

theft. Those were the ‘thieves’ with whom they crucified Jesus. But it should rather be said that he was crucified between two subversives.”

*And when they were crucifying him,
Jesus said:
‘Father, forgive them,
because they don’t know what they’re doing.’*

“Nowadays the same thing happens with the torturers, because these people are machines; they don’t even know why they’re torturing a guy. They’re torturing him; they’re killing him; they don’t know why they do it. So it could be that those people were also machines and they did it because it was their job.”

“They were carrying out orders.”

“I think that happens now also with the guards, because notice that now when there’s a protest about the high price of milk or bread, the ones that are tossing the tear-gas bombs are the buck privates, the same exploited ones earning a few pennies, and it’s for them that people are protesting the high price of milk or bread. Which means that they’re doing things against their own selves.”

“Through ignorance.”

“That’s why Jesus says: Forgive them, because they don’t know what they’re doing.”

“I think that among those who crucified Jesus there were two groups: those who did know what they were doing, and those who didn’t, like the buck privates, that you give an order to and they carry it out. If you don’t understand that, maybe you’ll understand a whack or a kick. It’s been known that if you talk in private to one of them, when no boss is around,

they're distressed to be carrying out that order. But there's others who know very well what they're doing. Christ was referring to those who were carrying out an order and not to the others, who didn't even go up to Golgotha."

"That was just like now; the soldiers and the Jews didn't know what they were doing, but the authorities did know. Because those guys knew that Jesus was against the powerful, and that he was the messiah who was going to liberate the people. The same thing now, the ones who persecute anyone who wants to make a change, they know very well why they're doing it. So-moza knows why he's doing it. The United States knows why it's doing it."

The people were looking.

The leaders were making fun, saying:

*"He frees others, let him free himself,
if he is really the Christ, the chosen of God."*

"But he was coming to free others and not himself."

"They'd heard a lot about Jesus coming to liberate. The message about Jesus' liberation had been spread around. But they had no idea what that meant. For them the messiah was somebody that wouldn't let anybody screw him."

"They thought he had failed. The same thing has also been thought about revolutionaries that have died for the people: Che, Camilo Torres, Allende. And they don't know that that's their victory."

"If somebody tries to liberate himself, it's all right; he's not doing anything for other people. He stays inside himself. If somebody does try to do something for other people, I think he always has to be in danger

of death. Whenever anybody tries to do something for others, he has delivered up his life.”

*And there was a sign over his head,
written in Greek, Latin, and Hebrew,
which said: “This is the King of the Jews.”*

“It was to make fun of him, of his reign. And even now the enemies of the kingdom go on making fun of the kingdom and of people that are struggling for it.”

I: “And it was also a Roman mockery for the whole Jewish nation. It’s a sarcastic sign with which Pilate is telling them that their famous messiah is this poor shit. And that’s why the Jewish authorities resented that sign, and they demanded that Pilate take it down, but he didn’t.”

“He has entered Jerusalem acclaimed as king. But he entered as a humble king, on a working donkey, not in a fancy automobile. And the new leaders now also come in poverty, preaching hard work and equality.”

“They didn’t expect that a king could come in on a donkey. On a donkey there ought to be a *campesino*.”

“All that business about being received in Jerusalem like a leader, with a political rally in the streets, with banners (branches were then like banners), that must have upset the authorities a lot, and they decided to get rid of him. But now they’re furious when Pilate tells them their king is that thing: a subversive, outside the law.”

I: “And Pilate is also explaining there what his crime was: a political crime. That means that we Christians must follow his example and be subversives. Now in Holy Week they’re preaching a lot of sermons, but most of them won’t be subversive.”

“Right now on the radio you can hear a sermon on the Seven Last Words. But it’s sponsored by Coca Cola.”

We read that one of the “criminals” asks Jesus to remember him when he begins to reign. And Jesus says to him:

“I tell you truly that today you’ll be with me in Paradise.”

“It seems that at that time there were good criminals and bad criminals, right? Because the other one, who was also in trouble there, he didn’t want to believe in him.”

“And how was he going to believe him if he saw him there as a failure as a political leader?”

“The other one believed in him in spite of his failure.”

“Among those who suffer with Jesus, some can believe in him and others don’t.”

“Maybe one of them thought that when Christ died, Christ’s revolution died, and the other one maybe realized that when Christ was dying Christ’s revolution was beginning and it was going to get bigger.”

“He talks to Christ of a future kingdom, when he begins to reign. And Christ tells him that kingdom is already here. ‘Today,’ he tells him. That very afternoon. He welcomes him to that kingdom of love among all. Although on the other side of death.”

I: “That change of words catches my attention. The man has talked to him about his kingdom, and Jesus talks to him about Paradise. In Genesis Paradise had been presented as something that there was at the beginning of humanity. But the intention of the biblical

writer was not to present to us a past that we were to yearn for in vain (the Bible never looks backward) but to present to us a *utopia*, a future goal for humanity. The prophets speak of Paradise as something that would be in the future, and they identified it with the messianic era. And Christ says that Paradise (his kingdom) begins now, that afternoon. With his death."

Then Jesus cried out:

"Father, into your hands I entrust my spirit."

And when he said this, he died.

I: "Jesus is here repeating a verse of a Psalm, adding the word 'Papa,' *Abba*. He tells the Father that he is returning to him the life that he has given him, and at the same time he is saying that he returns to him his spirit, which he has given him."

"And which has been transmitted to us."

"So that we too may give it up by giving up our lives for others."

"In each place where we live, we Christians must continue this redemption that Christ brought, because he didn't bring it completely. Because each one is born, first one, then another. And we're all deformed and we have to form ourselves. Jesus made the start so we could continue the work."

I: " 'Redeem' is a word from antiquity that means to ransom a captive by means of a price. It has often been said that Christ's death redeemed us, but it's not true; no death redeems from anything. His message redeemed or liberated us and his death made his message have an impact on the world."

"Jesus came to die for the poor, fulfilling a proph-

ecy, to help the poor to free themselves, because by themselves the poor are cowards and fearful and timid, it seems to me. With his death he tried to give strength and bravery to the poor. But many, many poor people say: If Christ suffered like that, we too should suffer. But his message is that we must denounce the injustices of the rich, of power, of the police. He teaches us to fight for that same liberation that he died for as a man, as a brave man (he did not die a coward). If we're without love, conformists (I believe lack of love is conformity), there'll never be an end to all the poverty and exploitation there is in Nicaragua, and everywhere else. Even though I know just Nicaragua, they tell me that the calamity of exploitation is everywhere. I'm not a well-read woman, but reading the Gospels I always see the bravery of Jesus. Jesus is a brave man. Just as there are today so many men and women who are so brave, who aren't afraid to denounce injustice. Others are silent, and that is lack of love."

"Traditionally Holy Week is celebrated in Nicaragua with religious services, sermons, and processions. But we never stopped to think what was the cause of the death of Jesus, never. And that has made me think a lot. And I realize that Christ didn't give himself a Holy Week of devotions and processions and religious ceremonies or any of that stuff. He died beaten and tortured, giving a message of liberation to us poor."

1: "He died while all Jerusalem was celebrating Holy Week. Jesus had the Passover supper with his disciples the day before, on Thursday, which was the date on which, as we've discovered in modern times, the Essenes celebrated it. But John says that Friday was the day when all Jerusalem celebrated Passover.

So while he was dying on the Cross, in every house they were eating ritually the paschal lamb. Just as David Tejada was beaten to death on Good Friday, at the hour when they were making the Stations of the Cross on the streets of Managua. And his body was then thrown into the crater of the Masaya volcano."

"What I meant is that for me a true Holy Week is one in which we can see the fruits of Christ's liberation. There are some countries where the fruits can already be seen, even though they don't celebrate Good Friday or any other day."

"The Christianity that we had was very false, and every year we heard about the Passion, but we didn't understand it the way we now understand what Good Friday is. Now we're gradually understanding it and we're gradually having courage to stand up to things."

"He has come to free us from now on from selfishness, even before we free ourselves from all injustice and also from fear and also from death. Although they imprisoned him and they sentenced him and they killed him and they did everything to him, they really didn't do anything. He triumphed over death."

I: "We have often said here that the Father, *Abba*, is love. It was to love that Jesus delivered up the life he received from him and his spirit received from him and after his death he's alive; he is one with love. And we must do the same, triumph over death through love. One day the whole life of the earth is going to die, like these fields that are dry. The earth will be a dead planet in space, and in it will be buried all our bones. But all that part of humanity that, like Jesus, has delivered up its life to love will be alive in the universe—in love, which is the soul, the life of the universe. Like Jesus, who came out of his tomb. Accord-

ing to the Apocalypse, Christ is only the first-born of a resurrected humanity."

"We must then deliver ourselves up to death with love, filled with love."

"This is the command."

There is a prolonged silence, broken only by the lowing of the cows in the dry fields.

I: "Hasn't anyone anything else to say?"

25.

The Resurrection

(Matthew 28:1-10)

It is midnight on Holy Saturday. We are in the little church, which is now brightly lighted and crowded with people. Outside, the lake is very calm under the full moon. There has been a festival all evening, with music, drinking, and dancing under the mango trees, a festival organized by the Youth Club to celebrate the resurrection. *Campesinos* have come from all the islands, and also others not from around here who are working on the company estate. Some have got drunk. And there was even a fight, a few minutes before the Mass, in which Félix Mayorga got stabbed near the heart. We took care of him, and we have begun the liturgy of the Easter vigil. I went into the church wearing my vestments, carrying the Easter candle. After the Easter announcement, and some songs, I read the Gospel, and we commented on it.

*When Saturday ended,
at dawn of the first day of the week,
Mary Magdalene and the other Mary went to see
the tomb.*

TOMAS PEÑA: "They got up early because they wanted to. And they were brave, because they weren't scared of the National Guardsmen that were on duty there."

"It was women who went there, not men, because women are braver than men."

OLIVIA: "Women are more loving. And love gives you a lot of strength. And when you love you're not afraid, you face up to anyone. The death of Jesus, who died for love, had filled them with that courage, the courage of love. When you love, then there's courage; you're not afraid even of death."

LAUREANO: "I don't see where's the courage of those women. They weren't running any risk by going there, the soldiers weren't attacking the women or doing a damned thing to them. Going to see Jesus and weeping for him there, why were they running any risk? They were weeping when he was being crucified, and they could have screwed them right there and they didn't. So now if they go there when he's already dead, what's going to happen to them?"

WILLIAM: "It takes a certain courage, man; it's like going now to lay flowers on the grave of a guerrilla fighter."

I: "In those times nobody paid much attention to women. And that's why those women maybe didn't run any risk, as Laureano says. Their role was only to go and weep and then embalm the body of Jesus. A humble role. But this Gospel assigns them a more important role: they were witnesses to the resurrection."

LAUREANO: "They have a very important role to play, as important as the men; but that doesn't mean they are braver or even more loving."

MARIA: "They agreed to take care of Jesus' body,

and when they didn't find it there they said: They've stolen it; they've taken it away. Like what happens with the leaders, they kill them and they won't even give you the body."

The angel said to the women:

"Do not be afraid.

*I know that you are looking for Jesus,
the one who was crucified.*

He is not here, he is risen, as he said.

Come and see the place where they had put him."

Someone from Deer Island: "It seems to me that maybe if they hadn't had faith in him they would have found him. As they did have faith in him that's why they didn't find him."

I: "The important thing about this story is that they find an empty tomb. They were arriving to embalm a corpse and there wasn't any corpse."

ESPERANZA: "I think the importance of that is that from then on every tomb in which a corpse is placed is empty. Even though a corpse has been buried in it, it has to be empty."

I: "How's that? And the body that they'd placed in it?"

ESPERANZA: "It doesn't exist. There's no point in going to look for a body that's no longer anything, that's been resurrected, in that sense. And so, then, tombs are left empty. They were going to look for Jesus' body, right? And they didn't find it."

MARIA: "And afterwards he appears before them and shows them that he's alive."

I: "And he goes on showing us that he's alive, us, gathered here twenty centuries later; and he's present in the midst of us."

WILLIAM: "The important thing is that he's alive wherever there's community."

*Then the women went quickly from the tomb,
with fear and at the same time with much joy;
and they ran to bring the news to the disciples.*

From the back of the church came FELIX MAYORGA, his chest swathed in thick bandages, and he said: "They ran to bring the news to their friends. But that news wasn't just for them but so that the news could go afterwards from mouth to mouth. After many centuries it has reached as far as us in Solentiname. And later it will be heard by people not yet born."

OLIVIA: "The news is not only about his resurrection but about ours. Because he is simply the first one resurrected. Nobody before had ever been resurrected. And that was done so that afterwards the rest of us could be resurrected."

I: "That's why Olivia didn't wear mourning but wore a green dress when her daughter Olga was buried."

FELIPE: "They struck him, they wounded him, they killed him, and they didn't accomplish anything with all that. We too, doing what he did, we triumph over death."

"I'm also thinking they didn't leave a single trace of Che, and they sent his head, we're told, to the United States and his hands and feet they sent somewhere else, but it's clear that Che, just like Christ, has been resurrected in the hearts of everybody who wants a new world."

I: "The revolution makes no sense unless there's a resurrection. If death isn't conquered, it does no good to conquer everything else in the world; the revolution

has failed. That's why Saint Paul says the last enemy we'll have to conquer will be death. This is the consolation for the old people, for the incurably ill who know they will never see the triumph of the revolution, also for the young people who are dying for it and won't see its triumph. And for all of humanity that has already died. And not only for humanity but for all living creatures, who have given up their bodies for it. The ultimate failure of humanity is the failure of all creation. That's why Saint Paul speaks of the birth pangs of all creatures, waiting for the liberation of our bodies. We are the conscience of nature, and with the death of humanity nature dies, in the sense that it could no longer be aware or be in love."

At this moment, Jesus appeared before them and greeted them.

They then approached Jesus and adored him, embracing his feet, and he said to them:

"Do not be afraid. Go and tell my brothers that they must go to Galilee, and that they will find me there."

ESPERANZA: "It's very much like the case of Che when he died in Bolivia. There those who knew him closest probably wept a lot for him, and he might have told them to go to Cuba, which he liberated; he was alive there, completely resurrected, because he struggled for Cuba, and how could he die? So he was resurrected for them in Cuba."

I: "He had probably told them: 'Go to Cuba, you'll see me there; to Cuba, and to the rest of the world.' So Christ said to them: 'Go to Galilee and to the rest of

the world, there you will see me.' Also: 'Go to Solentiname, there you will see me.' "

BOSCO, Esperanza's husband: "And why were the women afraid if they've already seen Jesus Christ? Perhaps he's telling them not to be afraid of the police, of imperialism."

ESPERANZA: "The leader is dead, so they have an attack of nerves."

TERESITA: "And I think he's also telling them not to be afraid of death."

I: "Not to be afraid of imperialism or of death, it's the same thing."

LAUREANO: "What's important is for us to live resurrection here, right now, and for us not to believe, as many have believed, that this world doesn't count, that what counts is to go to heaven afterwards and all that nonsense."

"Like those Yankees they send us from the United States that go from house to house saying that you've got to be resigned, that poor people go right to heaven. That's what those Yankees that they send from the United States keep repeating."

OLIVIA: "And there's people that say you have to put up with things and live in poverty and sickness, and live with your kids naked, because that's the way Jesus lived, and be resigned so we'll get to heaven. We've been told that Christ's death is so we'll live resigned to misery. And I don't know why, because Christ died like a brave man, because that's why they killed him, for being so brave, always denouncing injustice."

I: "It's certain that they've put Jesus resurrected in heaven, in another life, in the blue beyond, so that the earth will go right on being the same, and there'll still

be injustice, and there'll still be poor people. But he rose to be here on earth: 'He was dead and he goes to Galilee before you.' And he's also here in Solentiname. And it's curious that now for the first time he calls the disciples brothers. Before, he used to say 'My Father and your Father.' Now, resurrected, he calls them brothers."

ESPERANZA: "He's a guerrilla fighter. They've killed him because he fought for freedom. Everybody who goes to fight for freedom, to die for it and to rise again, they're all his brothers and sisters."

BOSCO: "And the resurrection that Christ announces, isn't that going to be the progress of science, that will fix it so that one day humanity, in the perfect society, gets to triumph over death?"

MANUELITO: "How's that? Everybody old?"

LAUREANO: "That would be a bloody mess; you'd get tired of living."

WILLIAM: "Resurrection is a new life, not the prolonging of this life. It's not what that rich bastard in California tried to do when he died and had himself frozen so he could later be revived. The son of a bitch had himself frozen like that, paying a lot of money, so that after a few centuries, when science can cure his illness, they'll thaw him out."

MANUEL: "But he hasn't revived."

WILLIAM: "Why, he's packed in ice! That bastard wants to be revived so he can go on screwing people."

LAUREANO: "And it's possible he'll never be revived."

WILLIAM: "Why should he be revived if he's a parasite, an insect. Even though society has progressed, or rather, because it has."

I: "It's not a question of prolonging life, but the opposite, of giving it up, which is what the martyrs of freedom have done."

OSCAR: "Maybe when the revolution triumphs God will reward the guy who's died for it, so he can rise again."

LAUREANO: "But he *is* risen! Sandino's risen. Leonel Rugama's risen. Julio Buitrago's risen. All those people are risen, are living here with us."

I: "Christ said that all the dead will hear the voice of the Son of Man (that is, his commandment to love) and will rise from their tombs. Those who did good will rise and be alive; those who did evil will be condemned."

BOSCO: "That guy that got frozen there, that one will really get screwed."

FELIPE: "What I say, my personal opinion, is that if you rise again after you're dead, fine. What's important is to do what Christ commands, to live for the people; that's what's important for now. Let's forget about whether we're going to be revived. I think what we ought to do is do good. So if I rise again, good; if I don't, all right."

OSCAR: "That's crossing from death to life. If you do something good here, you've triumphed over death."

FELIPE: "Because otherwise, if we start thinking we're going to rise again, we're biased. I personally don't think about if I'm going to rise again."

WILLIAM: "Christ says that to be revived you've got to let go of life. He gave the example of the seed that, to give fruit, has to die. It's not just getting shot; there's also a daily giving of life."

ADAN: "That business about reviving after death, are they really going to rise from the tomb? That seems very queer, rising like that."

OSCAR: "Or it may really be that you're not dead, maybe you're just resting [laughter]. Or rather, maybe you're not totally dead, your whole body."

DONALD: "I don't think they're going to be revived in a very material form. What's going to rise up is the consciousness and the love that person had, and so we might say that person is rising from the tomb; it's not that the skeleton will get up and go walking around [laughter]. And society's going to be changed."

I: "I think the revolution is going to be for the dead, too, for all of humanity that has died without being able to see the revolution. It would be unfair if the kingdom were only for that minority of those still alive, when a whole majority fought for it who died before it. And I believe humanity will be a single organism when it's united, and those who have become one with Christ, or rather with humanity, those who have fulfilled the commandment to love, are going to belong to that organism. It's not that anyone is going to be alive and isolated; they'll be in that body."

OSCAR: "When the new society is created, it's going to be like seeing a bunch of bastards rise up out of the tombs."

LAUREANO, whose family are Protestants: "The Protestants are the ones who raise those problems. If a shark eats you, is the shark going to vomit you up? If a tiger eats you, is the tiger going to vomit you up? That's a bunch of nonsense. If it was like that, poor Che could never rise again; hell, they sent his head one place and his hands somewhere else."

JULIO MAIRENA (who has now come with his wife to

be part of the commune): "It seems to me that if a guy dies fighting for the people and nobody follows his ideas, that one doesn't rise again. But if they follow his teachings, I think he's risen. Like what's happening now with the Nicaraguan songs, the old ones; they'd been forgotten, and Mejía Godoy finds them, and he plays them on the radio for all of Nicaragua, so now they're revived."

I: "Christ says that when they hear his voice the dead will rise. He means that when his message of love and revolution is heard by all humanity, and the new society is created, all those who formerly lived that message are going to rise again in that society, like those old songs, as Julio says, that nobody remembered except Don Rafael Arana. And that one that got frozen, he'll be unfrozen so that they can judge him."

WILLIAM: "Maybe he'll be left frozen forever, suffering the cold."

I: "Porfirio Miranda says that the kingdom hasn't come because people haven't believed in it. The news that the kingdom is coming will make the kingdom come. And when there's justice throughout the earth there will come the resurrection of the dead. The error of twenty centuries of Christianity has been to believe that we can obtain the kingdom of heaven without changing the world. And that's why we're still without the kingdom of heaven. Christ had said before that the kingdom wouldn't come until the news was announced to the whole world. And now, after he is risen, he will tell them to go throughout the world and announce the news to all the earth."

The journalist PEDRO RAFAEL GUTIERREZ, who has come back from Managua to spend a few days: "I've just read also in the Gospels another account of the

resurrection, where it says that Thomas put his hand in. They say there are no miracles now, and just a little while ago I felt very strange, with Félix Mayorga, I swear to you I had a deep impression. Because just as Saint Thomas put his fingers into the Master, I put mine into Félix Mayorga, in the same place, on the left side. And I said afterwards: How wonderful! It's too bad it was due to such a painful event; it's a lesson for no human being ever again to raise a hand against a brother or sister. But for me it was an unforgettable experience, to have felt the beating of the heart of Félix Mayorga, resuscitated. We had seen him fall to the ground, and his relatives weeping over him, and suddenly here he is, commenting on the Bible."

MAGDA asks: "So the resurrection is here and now and not in the other world?"

I: "Christ says that it's now. When Martha says to him, 'I know that they will be resurrected on the last day' (and that's what Christians continue to think), he corrects her, saying 'I am the resurrection.' Christ talks a lot about 'eternal life,' but we now know that that does not mean a life beyond this world but a life without death. Many modern theologians say there is no other world than this one. But Marxism, on the other hand, maintains that the world is eternal. About the resurrection we know almost nothing, and we mustn't talk a lot about it; Christ himself refused to say much. I simply believe, with Esperanza, that the tombs of all those who have loved their fellow human beings are empty."

26.

Jesus at the Shore of the Lake

(John 21:1–13 and 20–25)

Simon Peter said to them:

“I’m going fishing.”

They said to him: “We’re going with you.”

LAUREANO: “It seems those disciples, with the death of Jesus, went back to their old habits.”

DONALD: “It seems they decided, since he was dead, there was nothing to do. They weren’t going to continue his mission.”

BOSCO: “It must have been the first time they went fishing since the death of Jesus.”

WILLIAM: “Maybe what Peter told them was: ‘I’m going back to what I was before, a fisherman.’ And the others said they were going to do the same.”

ALEJANDRO: “And they were wrong, shitting it all up, because they were going to look stupid.”

TOMAS: “It seems that night they were jinxed, because when they pulled the net in it was all empty.”

“Haven’t you caught anything, boys?”

They answered: “Not a thing.”

Then Jesus said:

“Cast your net to the right and you’ll catch something.”

ESPERANZA: “It seems to me this way: Jesus wanted to make a comparison with the way it was before they found him resurrected. They felt everything they’d do was going to be in vain. But with him resurrected, what they’d do would be positive. When he joins them abundance comes. This is the picture. The fact is that without him they didn’t catch a thing and with him they did. That pointed out to them the mission they were going to have in the world. And that they ought to change jobs, because they could do more important things, with Jesus there, than just be catching *mojarras*. For Jesus had told Peter he was going to be a fisher of people, not fish.”

LAUREANO: “It seems here it was a sign they needed to know him, because it was only after they caught the fish that they knew who Jesus was.”

TERESITA: “It was lack of faith, because they needed his physical presence; they felt lost without Jesus. That’s why he had to appear before them several times so they’d know they weren’t living without him.”

OSCAR: “It seems too he was being angry with them, telling them to cast the net on the other side. He was trying to tell them that people shouldn’t live working only for themselves. They had to work for other people too, to free the others. That’s what he meant by that stuff about the other side. I’ve not explained it well, but it’s something like that.”

BOSCO: “It looks like if there hadn’t been that miraculous catch they’d have gone on fishing.”

OLIVIA: "He was punishing them, making them catch nothing all night long. It was very funny they hadn't caught anything through the whole night, because good fishermen like they were, how could they spend the whole night without catching a thing? But they didn't. So then he appeared before them so they could see they were stupid."

*Then the disciple that Jesus loved said to Peter:
"It's the Lord!"*

*The minute Simon Peter heard it was the Lord
he put on his clothes (because he'd taken them off)
and he jumped into the water.*

"Why was it they hadn't recognized him?"

"Maybe because he was far away."

I: "Not very far, because he could talk to them. It seems it was dawn and still dark. But I think even at night you can recognize a friend that speaks to you."

LAUREANO: "If Felipe speaks to me from the shore I know it's Felipe. They must have been confused."

OLIVIA: "It looks like they were in great sorrow because of Jesus' death. When you're bowed down like that with suffering, well then, you're not interested if somebody calls to you."

FELIPE: "It's not every day you see somebody resurrected just like that."

I: "In the other accounts of the appearances of the risen Jesus, he always has to tell them: It's me. It seems those apparitions aren't the way we can see Felipe there, or like we can hear him from the coast. They were mysterious apparitions, and you needed faith to recognize this."

WILLIAM: "The people in Emmaus recognized him

by his way of breaking bread. Here John recognized him because of their catch of fish. Peter heard it was him, and kerplunk! in he went."

"He put on his clothes to jump into the water?"

"Maybe it was so he wouldn't be naked or in his underwear in front of the resurrected Jesus."

I: "Maybe so, but they were used to getting wet and going around with wet clothes, just as you too get wet all the time and dry off and get wet again."

DOÑA NATALIA: "As Peter had behaved badly toward him, maybe that's why he jumped into the water, to get there first."

TOMAS: "With clothes there's more danger of drowning, but he didn't care about that."

*When they reached land,
they found a fire with a fish on it,
and bread.*

Jesus said to them:

"Bring some of the fishes you've just caught."

FELIPE: "That Jesus was a good cook."

TOMAS: "Well, at least he was trying."

GLORIA: "He was making breakfast for them."

TONO: "He'd also scaled and cleaned the fish himself, right?"

OLIVIA: "He's showing love that way, with that roast fish, because that's the way he was cooking it. Suppose it *was* easy to cook. What's important is the love he's cooking it with. He knows those men are tired to death and they've spent all night soaking wet. They need breakfast. That's what the fish is for."

*Simon Peter got on the boat
and dragged the net to the beach
filled with big fishes,*

*a hundred and fifty-three,
and even though there were so many
the net didn't break.
Then Jesus said to them:
"Come to breakfast."*

"It must have been an old net if they were surprised it didn't break."

TOMAS, a great fisherman: "A hundred and fifty-three fishes, that's a lot of fish."

I: "*Guapotes* and *mojarras*. We have a book on the fish in Lake Nicaragua which says that the *guapotes* and *mojarras* in this lake also exist in the Sea of Galilee."

TONO: "Jesus was probably roasting them a big *guapote*."

MARCELINO: "The fishes are all of us, and the net is unity, which doesn't break."

OLIVIA: "Love is so important and so beautiful. He was showing them his love after his resurrection, making them that breakfast with a father's love, or a brother's, or a comrade's."

ALEJANDRO, her son: "It seems like that would take away a little of the previous mystery, doing such a common thing (though maybe not so common after all) as giving them something to eat, so natural. But the mystery is also where he'd got that fish. But he treats the mystery very simply, because he doesn't appear before them to say anything except 'Eat,' so as to feed them."

I: "And so they could see that he was still one of them."

ALEJANDRO: "That's it: to take away the mystery."

OLIVIA: "He wants to go on being identified with them, and with us. He hadn't done that before, before

he died. He'd done the multiplication of the fishes and the loaves. But it was only after he was resurrected that he roasted those fishes. It was to make us see that death hadn't separated us from him. Because he appears and he begins to roast the fish, and he calls them to come to breakfast. He's not like we might say a fleshless spirit concerned only about spiritual things. Here he's concerned about their breakfast, the resurrected Jesus, and he tells them to come to breakfast."

ALEJANDRO: "That's a very good image, because he appears there at work. And he's shown like a real person, material, not like something theoretical or an idea. And about that earlier business, about the net on the right side, that's easy to explain. When you're busy at work here, they always say: Cast on this side, cast on this side. The ones that come up to watch, right? Because they're always guessing where there's more pebbles, where it's deeper and all that. And then maybe Jesus saw it was deeper on that side and then he told them to cast on that side. So I see him there in the little bay. Well, you've got to believe he did it so they could get all those fishes."

And none of the disciples dared to ask who he was because they knew he was the Lord.

I: "My attention has always been caught by that little phrase in the Gospel."

LAUREANO: "They went back to fishing because they were fishermen and so now that Jesus appears before them they don't even want to ask. It seems they're ashamed. They probably didn't even think he'd be resurrected."

BOSCO: "Maybe that business about not daring to

ask is because they weren't sure. I mean at the beginning, they weren't sure it was him. But they didn't say who are you for fear he'd tell them they had no faith."

TOMAS: "It seems like they knew it was him but they weren't so sure it was him. They knew through faith it was him."

I: "That shows that his presence was a mysterious presence."

ALEJANDRO: "It's very puzzling because it says they didn't *dare* to ask him, as if they'd wanted to ask him. But it says they didn't because they knew it was him. They knew it but they *wanted* to ask."

LAUREANO: "As I see it, it's like those guys still didn't believe he'd been resurrected. So it must have been that they saw him but they thought it was a fake or that they were dreaming. That's what they must have thought."

I: "But besides they probably weren't seeing a person of flesh and blood like us. That's clear from that little phrase in the Gospel."

BOSCO: "That must have been a mysterious apparition, as Ernesto says."

TERESITA: "Asking would have meant having doubts. They made an act of faith. Besides, they were feeling it was him, they were knowing it was him."

TOMAS: "He'd already lit the way."

I: "And it could be that they don't dare to ask him about his resurrection, they don't dare to go deep into that mystery. It's enough for them to know he's resurrected."

TOMAS: "You needed faith to be able to recognize him. Suppose he appears here among us—right?—in these meetings. But be careful: if we have faith we'll see him too. Before that they'd started to fish, but I

don't think he blamed them for starting to fish. They had a right to fish to get food."

I: "He doesn't blame them, but after they saw him they didn't go on fishing; they devoted themselves to spreading this message, which has been written down, and which we now have in our hands on these islands."

DONALD: "It seems to me that maybe they went fishing because they were sad, looking for relief, to forget, in the fishing, in the lake."

GOYO, a timid little man, almost in a whisper: "Jesus has appeared now, near another lake."

*Then Jesus came near,
took the bread in his hands,
and gave it to them,
and he did the same with the fish.*

"Wasn't he so near to them?"

"The Eucharist?"

I: "The Eucharist."

TOMAS: "They were really celebrating the bread of the Mass."

WILLIAM: "The communion was with bread and roast fish, which symbolize the abundance of the goods of the earth, and water. The water of the lake."

I: "Earlier they'd had a Eucharist at a supper, and now they have another Eucharist at a breakfast, with bread and fish and water, as William says."

WILLIAM: "A common and ordinary meal, then. But a meal that had that meaning, the sharing of all the goods of the earth, the communion of those who have everything in common in a community. That's the sign he makes there with the bread when he divides it and shares it. And the same way he divides the fishes

in equal parts, the one he'd prepared for them and the others they caught and added afterwards. It's to make us see that everything ought to be shared like that, the whole economy of the country."

JULIO: "He was doing it as an example, feeding them, because that's the way they must share the bread or work so that everybody can eat. It seems to me that he began like that with that example, with his apostles, so that they (who are us now) would go on sharing the bread like he did."

I: "That's what he had taught them when he multiplied the loaves at the Last Supper."

JULIO: "That's why he said his followers should go on doing that work and remembering him: You do the same."

I: "At the time of the multiplication of the loaves and fishes, which was beside this same lake, the Gospel says these same words: Jesus took in his hands the loaves and the fishes. Afterwards at the Last Supper he uses the same words again: He took in his hands the bread, and he took the wine, and he gave it to his disciples. In the appearance to the disciples at Emmaus, Jesus again took in his hands the bread and gave it to them, and it wasn't till then that they recognized him. And here the Gospel again uses those same words: He took in his hands the bread and gave it to them and he did the same with the fishes. It seems that the Gospel wants to make us see the same thing is being repeated, the Eucharist."

DOÑA NATALIA: "It's the same thing that happens with us, who are seeing all this right in front of us, what you're explaining to us, even though we're without faith. That's the way it probably happened with them, who were knowing what Jesus told them,

and it seems even so they had little faith, just like us, just the way we are.”

ESPERANZA: “That was a sign, it seems to me, that sharing that he was doing of the bread and the fishes, something humble. But they already knew him by means of that. Now, if somebody goes around with good things, good books, for example, but real books, not false ones, well that’s how we get to know him. That’s the way he identified himself through the fishes, through the bread, humbly. Those disciples liked to eat fish, and they knew he was the one who gave it to them.”

I: “It’s just as Esperanza says. He becomes known to them through that communion of humble but necessary things. That time, with the sharing of the loaves and the fishes, he had everyone take part in a common meal, a communion, you might say. At the Last Supper he made them see that that communion of their little community was his body. And now again he has that communion with them in the bread and fish. This is interesting, because it shows that the Eucharist doesn’t have to be only bread and wine at the altar. Now, we may say, we’re going to have a Eucharist with turtle, in our meeting hut, right?”

“That’s it.”

I: “It’s a communion given to us by the boys of the commune who went to hunt for it last night in the shallow waters of La Salvadora, and the girls who are cooking it now. Well, I’d say that we’re also having a Eucharist with that turtle, not just the one at the altar.”

DOÑA NATALIA: “In that breakfast he was giving them a communion that he wanted to be for everybody.”

ELVIS, her son: “Doña Olivia said a while back that Jesus had identified with the people, right?”

OLIVIA: “I believe this Gospel is very much needed throughout Nicaragua. If this Gospel was preached and discussed everywhere, there’d be an end to that ridiculous Holy Week they have. Instead of those traditional ceremonies and prayers that they commemorate the death of Jesus with, everybody’d go into action to see what we can do for each other, and we’d take into account the injustice that people haven’t eaten in this Holy Week. They once used to tell us we shouldn’t run or even take a bath on these holy days, because Jesus was under the earth. Jesus came to wake us up. He died so he could come back afterwards to act more effectively.”

*This is the same disciple who states these things and
who has written them.*

And we know he tells the truth.

*There are also many other things that Jesus did,
that if they were written down one by one,
I believe there would not be room in all the world
for the books that would be written.*

Amen.

I: “These are the last verses of the last chapter of the Gospel According to Saint John, which was the last Gospel to be written. Now it’s not he but other people who are talking. This was added when John’s narrative began to spread in the early communities and they were commenting on it as we are commenting on it now. It appears that this is the commentary of people who had known Jesus at first hand and they say that his testimony is true. We also believe in Jesus because

we believe in the testimony of those who knew John, who knew Jesus. That's why we are here holding this book in our hands, the story that through many hands has reached us, on the shore of this lake."

BOSCO: "It seems very exaggerated to say that not even in the whole world would there be room for the books that would be written."

ALEJANDRO: "It seems that in those times it was very hard to get paper, and books were scarce. That's why many things were left unwritten."

"Books were rolled up. Big rolls."

I: "And what would they be, those things that were left unwritten?"

LAUREANO: "Gosh, if they didn't write them, you can't tell what it was. The only thing you know is what got written."

TERESITA: "Since everything Jesus did was good, you can never get to the end of telling all the things he did."

ADAN: "Among the things Jesus did that aren't written could have been his contacts with the guerrilla fighters."

WILLIAM: "It seems to me it also refers to the great changes he made in people and in the world, and that he goes on making and will go on making through his followers."

I: "And all that he did and said, and it's told here, we comment on it and we can go on commenting on it for a long time. And we could say that these commentaries never end."

ALEJANDRO: "And they even get written, and they could never finish being written."

I: "We're going to publish that book, of the commentaries that have been made, a selection of them."

And those commentaries of Alejandro, Donald, Marcelino, Laureano, Oscar, Elvis, Olivia, Ivan, Bosco, Esperanza, Tomás, Felipe, William, Gloria, Goyo, Adan, Pancho, Natalia, Manuel, Teresita, Julio, Myriam, Rebeca, maybe will lead others in other communities also to comment on the Gospel. It can also be said that our lives are included in what Jesus did and goes on doing, together with the lives of many, many others throughout the world, and all that would never manage to get written and if it did get written it would fill the entire world with books. Anything more? Then, if you're willing, we'll stop here, because the boys want to have time to play their baseball game."

GOYO: "We can say that the love he had for us was so great that you couldn't get it into all the books in the world."

DONALD: "It's because what he did is infinite, man, like nature."

FELIPE: "And the revolution too never ends, because there's always something to revolutionize more. It's limitless."

GOYO: "And there's a lot of ways of revolutionizing the revolution."

OLIVIA: "Whenever anybody's struggling for liberation they're carrying out the Gospel, and that's why Jesus' Gospel never ends. And that's why there wouldn't be room for it on the earth if it was written."

I: "The teaching of Christ is infinite, like nature, as Donald says. And the teaching of Christ is the revolution itself. And we can say that the revolution is nature itself."

DONALD: "It's really an endless labor. And the revolution has no end because there can always be a greater liberation."

GOYO: "And that's what keeps leading us to God, then."

I: "Until we reach God completely."

WILLIAM: "And the kingdom of God comes into being on the earth."

FELIPE: "Then there'll be an end to the Gospel."

I: "Which means in Greek the good news of the kingdom."

DONALD: "But there won't be an end to it, because even if this humanity ends, the work of Christ will continue on even beyond death."

I: "And the Gospel ends with a final word, Amen, which is a Hebrew word that means a very strong 'Yes,' the assent of a community. It's the community that was commenting on it and that has said 'Yes.' This is our response to the word of Jesus, to the one who, as John has said at the beginning of his Gospel, is the word that existed from the beginning."

EPILOGUE

In October 1977, during a period of countrywide upheaval, the Nicaraguan National Guard ravaged the Solentiname community. In December, writing from Costa Rica, Cardenal explained in a "Letter to the People of Nicaragua" why he had joined the Sandinista guerrillas. The following translation by William Barbieri is reprinted with permission of the National Catholic Reporter, Box 281, Kansas City, MO 64141.

Twelve years ago I arrived at Solentiname with two companions to found a small, contemplative community. Contemplation means union with God. We soon became aware that this union with God brought us before all else into union with the peasants, very poor and very abandoned, who lived dispersed along the shores of the archipelago.

Contemplation also brought us to the revolution. It had to be that way. If not, it would have been fake contemplation. My old novice master, Thomas Merton, the inspirer and spiritual director of our foundation, told me that in Latin America I could not separate myself from political strife.

In the beginning we would have preferred a revolution with nonviolent methods. But we soon began to

realize that at this time in Nicaragua a nonviolent struggle is not feasible. Even Gandhi would agree with us. The truth is that all authentic revolutionaries prefer nonviolence to violence; but they are not always free to choose.

The Gospel was what most radicalized us politically. Every Sunday in Mass we discussed the Gospel in a dialogue with the peasants. With admirable simplicity and profound theology, they began to understand the core of the Gospel message: the announcement of the kingdom of God, that is, the establishment on this earth of a just society, without exploiters or exploited, with all goods in common, just like the society in which the first Christians lived. But above all else the Gospel taught us that the word of God is not only to be heard, but also to be put into practice.

As the peasants of Solentiname got deeper and deeper into the Gospel, they could not help but feel united to their brother and sister peasants who were suffering persecution and terror, who were imprisoned, tortured, murdered; they were violated and their homes were burnt. They also felt solidarity with all who with compassion for their neighbor were offering their lives. For this solidarity to be real, they had to lay security, and life, on the line.

In Solentiname it was well known that we were not going to enjoy peace and tranquillity if we wanted to put into practice the word of God. We knew that the hour of sacrifice was going to arrive. This hour has now come. Now in our community everything is over.

There a school of primitive painting became famous throughout the world. Paintings, woodwork, and various handicrafts from Solentiname are sold not

only in Managua, but also in New York, Washington, Paris, Venezuela, Puerto Rico, Switzerland, and Germany. Lately peasants from Solentiname had begun to write beautiful poetry. Their poems were published in Nicaragua and other countries.

Several films were made in Solentiname, one of them by BBC in London. Much has been written about Solentiname in various languages; records have been made, even in German. We have in that distant corner of the lake a great library gathered during a lifetime. We had a collection of pre-Columbian art found in Solentiname that grew through the years. We had a large guest house with plenty of beds for visitors. We had ovens for ceramics and a large shop for all kinds of handicrafts. There we worked with wood, leather, copper, bronze, and silver. We were also developing communal work for young peasants through a cooperative. The cooperative, with the help of a German institution, was about ready to begin a dairy and factory of European-style cheese.

It was said in Germany: "Solentiname is everywhere, it is the beginning of a more human world. It is a Christian life—not just waiting for a better world, but working for their neighbor's peace, for peace in nature, for peace within the community." In Venezuela it was said that "Solentiname is something so God-like and so much of this world that it is a place where poetry, painting, and the harvest do not divide people into poets and farmers, but constitute the solidarity of one life." Now all that is over.

Twelve years ago, when the apostolic nuncio approved my project to found a new monastery, he told me that he would have preferred that the community

be established in a less remote place than Solentiname, because there we would have no visitors. The truth is that we were always flooded with visitors from Nicaragua and other countries. Many times they were people who arrived in Nicaragua only to visit Solentiname; sometimes they arrived directly by way of Los Chiles or San Carlos, without any interest in even visiting Managua. Abundant correspondence from all parts of the world arrived in Solentiname.

But now brush will grow once again where our community used to be, just as it did before our arrival. There, there was a peasant mass, there were paintings, statues, books, records, classes, smiles of beautiful children, poetry, song. Now all that is left is the savage beauty of nature. I lived a very happy life in that near paradise that was Solentiname. But I was always ready to sacrifice it all. And now we have.

One day it happened that a group of boys and girls from Solentiname, because of profound convictions and after having let it mature for a long time, decided to take up arms. Why did they do it? They did it for only one reason: for their love for the kingdom of God, for the ardent desire that a just society be implanted, a real and concrete kingdom of God here on earth. When the time came, these boys and girls fought with great valor, but they also fought as Christians. That morning at San Carlos, they tried several times with a loudspeaker to reason with the guards so they might not have to fire a single shot. But the guards responded to their reasoning with submachine gunfire. With great regret, they also were forced to shoot.

Alejandro Guevara, one of those from my community, entered the building when in it there were no

longer any but dead or wounded soldiers. He was going to set fire to it so that there would be no doubt about the success of the assault, but out of consideration for the wounded, he did not do it. Because the building was not burned, it was officially denied that it was taken. I congratulate myself that these young Christians fought without hate—above all, without hate for the wounded guards, poor peasants like themselves, also exploited. It is horrible that there are dead and wounded. We wish that there were not a struggle in Nicaragua, but this does not depend upon the oppressed people that are only defending themselves.

Some day there will be no more war in Nicaragua, no more peasant guards killing other peasants. Instead there will be an abundance of schools, hospitals, and clinics for everyone, food adequate for everyone, art and entertainment. But most important, there will be love among all.

Now the repression that has gone on so long in the North has arrived at Solentiname. A tremendous number of peasants have had to flee, others are in exile, remembering those beautiful islands with their now destroyed homes. They would be there yet, living tranquil lives, dedicated to their daily tasks. But they thought of their neighbor, and of Nicaragua, and began to work for them.

I do not think about the reconstruction of our small community of Solentiname. I think of a task much more important that we all have—the reconstruction of the whole country.

On July 19, 1979, the Sandinista revolution was victorious. Many of the Solentiname community participated in the struggle against the Somoza dictatorship. Ernesto Cardenal is now Minister of Culture of Nicaragua.

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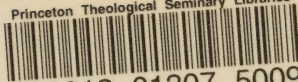
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